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LEGAL EDUCATION

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY



19 months after Manmohan Singh's death, he gets clean chit in coal case



Ex-PM Manmohan Singh was summoned to face trial in 2015.

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 29

MORE THAN a decade after a trial court summoned former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh in the coal block allocation case, the Supreme Court on Wednesday set aside the order and accepted the Central Bureau of Investigation's (CBI) closure report which cleared him in the matter.

Saying that the trial court had no justification for rejecting the CBI's closure report, a three-judge bench led by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant closed the proceedings.

While Singh died in December 2024, Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for the former PM, said though the matter had become infructuous after his death, the trial court's remarks against him ought to be expunged. Senior Advocate AM Singhvi, also representing Singh, urged the court to do away with the remarks.

The bench, which included

● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

STRINGENT PROVISIONS IN AMENDED LEGISLATION

Tough exam leak Bill clears LS, Rahul raises police crackdown

Govt hails passage, says open to learn from experience; LoP: Shah must quit over July 20 action

Asad Rehman, Anonna Dutt & Jatin Anand
New Delhi, July 29

WRAPPING UP a two-day debate punctuated by acrimonious exchanges as the Opposition slammed the government over the police crackdown on student protesters in Delhi, Lok Sabha Wednesday passed the stringent Public Examination (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill, 2026 by a voice vote amid sloganeering.

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi's remarks against Union Home Minister Amit Shah over the July 20 police action led to stormy scenes with



Union Minister Kiren Rijiju and LoP Rahul Gandhi in Lok Sabha. PTI

POLITICS PAGE 6

RAJYA SABHA PASSES BILL MAKING INSULT TO VANDHE MATARAM A CRIMINAL OFFENCE

strong protests from the treasury benches — one of the words he used was expunged from House records.

Later, the government

hailed the passage of the Bill. Union Minister Jitendra Singh, who replied to the debate, said it reflected the government's "openness to incorporate constructive inputs, learn from experience and further strengthen the law" to deal with exam paper leaks.

Shah, in a post on X, congratulated "every student in India" on the passage of the Bill, saying it "shields the dreams

● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

CHARGESHEET FILED IN FAST-TRACK COURT

Leaked NEET papers took two routes out of Maharashtra: CBI probe

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, July 29

PROBING THE NEET-UG 2026 paper leak case, the CBI has uncovered two messaging app trails — a Maharashtra-Rajasthan-Haryana route and a Maharashtra-Rajasthan-Kerala pathway — through which the question papers travelled.

Investigators are calling it a "countrywide conspiracy" involving subject experts, coaching institute operators and intermediaries. *The Indian Express* has learnt.

In a chargesheet filed Tuesday in a Delhi fast-track court, the CBI has named 13 accused

including NTA biology expert Manisha Mandhare, NTA chemistry expert Pralhad Vithalrao Kulkarni, NTA physics expert Manisha Sanjay Halvaldar.

The others named are Shivraj Raghunath Moteogankar, owner of Renukai Career Centre Coaching Institute in Letur; Tejas Harshadkumar Shah, COO at APMA Coaching Institute in Pune, and eight alleged intermediaries: Manisha Sanjay Waghmare, Dhananjay Nirvutti Lokhande, Shubham Madhukar Khairnar, Yash Yadav, Mangilal Biwal, Vikash Biwal, Dinesh Biwal and

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NO IMPACT ON EXISTING CLEARANCES

Retrospective green nod: SC strikes down Centre's order, opens window for exception

2021 Office Memorandum quashed, CJI bench says exceptions can be granted in public interest but under 1986 legislation

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 29

E. EXPLAINED

No perpetual regime

The SC has held that the government must make a distinct selection of projects for the grant of post facto environmental clearance. Projects with a bearing on public interest satisfy the test of proportionality, reasonableness.

esty notification in supervening public interest as an exception to the 2006 notification."

"The decriminalisation of regulatory contraventions under the 1986 Act, through the Jan Vishwas Act 2023, reinforces our conclusion that the Central government has ample power under Section 3 to issue appropriate notifications, formulating amnesty schemes with regard to such classes or categories of non-compliant projects whose sustainability is necessary to subserve larger public interest," it said.

On May 16, 2025, the bench of Justice Abhay S Oka and

● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

INSIDE PAGES 5,8

AMID FARMERS' PROTEST, SHIVRAJ VS MP GOVT OVER PROCUREMENT

BENGAL GOVT TO GIVE EGGS WITH MID-DAY MEALS FROM ISKCON



28-year-old Gulveer Singh during the men's 10,000 m final at Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. AP

From Sirsa mud ground to India's first CWG men's 10,000m silver

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, July 29

PELTING RAIN, chilly conditions and a field of runners from Africa with a podium-finish history spanning over 50 years — India's Gulveer Singh was up against the weather, sporting history and a quality field at the

Commonwealth Games. Yet, the 28-year-old from Sirsa in UP's Aligarh held his nerve, stuck to his race strategy and produced an impressive final burst to win silver, marking India's first-ever Commonwealth Games medal in the men's 10,000m with a time of 27 minutes and 49.80 seconds.

Gulveer had, in fact, fallen behind during the race but fought back to snap at the heels of the leading pack before surging forward. Ky Robinson of Australia won gold in 27:48.93, while David Mulder of the Isle of Man took bronze in 27:50.28.

The result also ended

● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

3 lured to Thailand with holiday trip, held for ransom; 5 Indians arrested

Divya A
New Delhi, July 29

THREE YOUTHS, all in their early 20s, were allegedly lured to Pattaya in Thailand through what was advertised as a low-cost seven-day holiday package, held captive and tortured for five days while ransom calls were made to their families in India — before they were rescued by police on Monday.

Their alleged kidnappers,

also Indians, were arrested from Bangkok the next day while they were preparing to flee the country, according to local media reports.

The five suspects — identified as Avtar Singh (38), Jagjit Singh (38), Rambalak Kumar (24), Sukhbir Singh (37) and Kulra Singh (27) — were arrested from a hotel in Khlong Tan area of Bangkok on Tuesday while they were waiting to board an outbound flight, the

Bangkok Post reported, citing the police.

While the suspects have reportedly admitted to the charges, they have claimed that a Pakistani national, who they were in contact with via a chat app over the past month, ordered them to kidnap the three Indians. The alleged mastermind is reportedly based in Dubai and had planned to receive ransom payment in

● CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● CASE AGAINST KAPIL SANGWAN RELATES TO HIS ALLEGED ROLE IN RUNNING AN EXTORTION SYNDICATE

In a first, trial in absentia begins today in Delhi against absconding gangster

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 29

IN A first, a Delhi court will start hearing arguments Thursday against Kapil Sangwan, a gangster accused in two cases under the Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA), in absentia — or, in his absence. Sangwan has been declared absconding and is believed to be in London.

In an order issued on July 9, Special Judge Vishal Gogne of Rouse Avenue Court permitted the trial to proceed in "absen-

● ROAD TO TRIAL

KAPIL SANGWAN, an accused in two cases under MCOCA, has been absconding since 2019. He is believed to be in London.

SANGWAN WAS declared a proclaimed offender in May 2025.

TWO NON-bailable warrants were issued against him by Rouse Avenue court against him but they



Rouse Avenue Court in Delhi.

could not be executed since his house was found to be "locked".

ON JULY 9, Special Judge Vishal Gogne of Rouse Avenue Court permitted the trial to proceed in absentia under BNSS Section 356 (inquiry, trial or judgment in absentia of a proclaimed offender)

tia" under Section 356 (Inquiry, trial or judgment in absentia of proclaimed offender) of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNSS).

The trial pertains to one of the two MCOCA cases against Sangwan, related to his alleged role in running an extortion syndicate.

According to new norms, a person accused of a crime can be tried and convicted in his absence, as if he was present in court and has waived his right to a fair trial. Earlier, the Court

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Karnataka HC slams Civil Judge involved in road rage incident, halts probe against 2

Express News Service
Bengaluru, July 29

THE KARNATAKA High Court on Wednesday came down heavily on a Principal Civil Judge who indulged in a squabble with two persons riding a two-wheeler and got the police to take criminal action against them. The High Court also stayed further investigation in the case.

Justice M Nagaprassanna saw the CCTV camera footage, showing Principal Civil Judge and JMFC, Gayatri, getting into a verbal spat with petitioners Vinya K M and V Kavita. "The video would clearly indicate that the judicial officer has behaved in a manner totally unbefitting of the office that she holds," the court said.

"The bench said, 'Judicial office is a continuation of public trust, it is not only inside the courtroom, but it is behaviour outside the courtroom that would erode the confidence of the public or sustain the confidence. Every act of judicial officer is discharge of official duties and is not confined to the four walls of the court hall but travels beyond the court hall when the interaction happens with the public'."

"The petitioners approached the court seeking to quash the case against them, contending that they overtook the private vehicle of the complainant (Civil Judge) who was travelling with her husband. The petitioners alleged that the complainant chased down the two-wheeler, stopped them and got into a verbal spat. The judicial officer then informed

the police and lodged a complaint against the petitioners under sections 126(2), 132, 315, 351(2), 352, 74 of the Bharatiya Nyay Samitha. The offences alleged were wrongful restraint, criminal intimidation and others.

The bench in its order said: "It is surprising as to how, for the offences to laid against the petitioners, they were taken into custody. Merely because the complainant was a judicial officer, it would not mean that citizens are treated at the dictate of the judicial officer."

Remarkably about the incident, the court said, "If this has enraged or hurt the ego of the judicial officer, nothing more can become a classic illustration of abuse of the office of the judicial officer; therefore there shall be an interim order of stay of further investigation against the petitioners."

The bench in its order also directed the Registrar to place the interim order passed before the Chief Justice of the High Court for further action against Gayatri. On the other hand, Bengaluru Advocates' Association (ABB) has demanded action against the Civil Judge over allegations that she abused her official position and got a youth assaulted following a road rage incident.

In a letter to Karnataka High Court Justice S R Krishnakumar, the ABB has sought suspension of the judicial officer. The letter came after she allegedly summoned police to the spot and to detain a student following a road rage incident. The video of the incident went viral.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Tough exam leak Bill clears LS

and aspirations of our youth by laying down iron-clad provisions imposing the harshest punishment on those who dare to breach the sanctity of public examinations". The Modi government, he said, "will spare no effort to take steps to imperil the future of our students and will leave no stone unturned to ensure that they face the full wrath of the law".

Speaking to the press after the day's proceedings, Gandhi demanded Shah's resignation and a Supreme Court-monitored probe into the "brutalities" against the students. He said he was not allowed to speak in Lok Sabha, that every time he tried to speak in the House, he was "silenced".

BJP national spokesperson Samrat Patra accused Gandhi of trying to "mislead the country's youth", of creating a ruckus in the House and using unparliamentary words. "He alleged he was not given a chance to speak... When 45 people were given a chance to speak, why Rahul Gandhi not be given a chance to speak?" he said.

"Rahul Gandhi has divided the country's youth into three categories, and this is an insult to the students. We clearly state that all students of this country are desh bhaktas (patriots); no student of this country is an idiot or an andh bhakt (blind follower)," Patra said.

Earlier, while participating in the debate, Gandhi accused Shah of "ordering police action" against students during the July 20 protests in Delhi.

Objecting to the remarks, Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju demanded that Gandhi substantiate his allegations and apologise to the House.

"You are the Leader of the Opposition. Speak with seriousness. On what basis did you make this statement? How can he say that someone ordered firing to breach the sanctity of public examinations and private education?" said the opposition leader, Rijiju said.

Speaker Om Birla also intervened, urging Gandhi to make statements based on facts and maintain the dignity of the House. He also said that some of Gandhi's remarks will be expunged from House records.

When the treasury benches demanded that Gandhi apologise, Opposition members rallied behind him, saying "Rahul ji ko bol do" (let Rahul speak), leading to noisy scenes.

Gandhi said the protesting students had shown courage. "The students of the country are saying that we will become andh bhaktas (blind followers). This is a beautiful expression. Their parents perhaps did not have the courage to face the BJP and the RSS. Yet these children, brave, imaginative and powerful, stood there and faced whatever you threw at them," he said.

Targeting Dharmendra Pradhan, who resigned as Union Education Minister last week, Gandhi said, "Rajnath Singhji said we are not the UPA and our ministers never resign. He is right. The resignation of Pradhan is superficial because he never ran the education system. The Education Ministry is run by the RSS. The man who runs it is the OSD sitting in the minister's office."

Speaking to reporters outside the House, Gandhi said there can be just "two options" — one that the Home Minister "gave the orders" (for action against students), and second that the "Home Minister didn't

Leaked NEET papers took two routes out of Maharashtra: CBI

Dr Manoj Bhagwanrao Shirure. Investigators have focused on Moteogankar whose coaching Institute has branches in Pune, Nashik, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Nanded, Solapur, Kolhapur, Akola and other parts of Maharashtra.

"Investigators have alleged that Moteogankar was an active member of the organised network that procured and circulated NEET-UG 2026 question papers. He allegedly arranged procurement of chemistry questions by paying Rs 5 lakh, routed through co-accused Dr Manoj Bhagwanrao Shirure, reportedly for the benefit of his son and students enrolled at RCC," sources said.

A phone found during a search at Moteogankar's house allegedly led to recovery of leaked questions, and notes of chemistry questions in his handwriting. "At least 36 images, including five duplicates, containing 132 handwritten chemistry questions were recovered from his mobile phone. The meta-data allegedly showed that the images were captured on a Samsung Fold9 on April 23 this year, around 10 days before the examination. Prima facie, investigators found that approximately 111 of these questions matched questions from the NTA master sets for NEET-UG 2026," sources said.

The CBI chargesheet, it is learnt, also details the alleged role of Dr Shirure, a medical practitioner running a private hospital in Latur. Investigators have said Shirure facilitated the procurement and onward dissemination of leaked chemistry questions at the instance of Kulkarni, also an accused.

"Shirure's hospital premises were allegedly used as the venue where Moteogankar's son accessed the chemistry question paper in the third week of April, before the NEET examination. Shirure also referred two other doctors whose children procured the question paper from Kulkarni, each allegedly paying Rs 3 lakh," sources said.

Kulkarni was said to have also disclosed that he first came in contact with co-accused Dhananjay Lokhande in 2021 and conspired with Manisha Waghmare in procuring and circulating the leaked papers. "The paper reached the beneficiaries through Kulkarni's network. A payment of Rs 5 lakh made for the leaked paper was traced to Moteogankar's wife and was allegedly recovered from the residence of a Shirure family member," sources said.

The CBI has found that the first formal indication of the alleged NEET paper leak came not from an investigating agency, but from a May 7 email sent by a chemistry teacher, Shashikant Surkar, in Rajasthan. Surkar told NTA, detailing how solved questions were

be a little careful on the bends. For the first time since 1970, no athlete from the continent finished on the podium, though eight of them were in the 15-man final, including two formidable Kenyans: 2023 World Championship medalist Daniel Ekenbo and 2024 Paris Olympics podium-finisher (5000m) Edwin Kiptum.

But Gulveer was unfazed by reputation. His performance in the rain-soaked conditions, alongside Avinash Sable's second-place finish in the 3000m steepchase four years ago in Birmingham — another event once dominated by Kenyans — will be remembered among the finest feats by an Indian distance runner. "The silver means a lot because it is the result of a lot of hard work over the last few years," Gulveer told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow.

This wasn't a flash-in-the-pan performance. Gulveer holds national records in the 10,000m (27:00.22), 3,000m, 5,000m and the 25-km road race, and became the first Indian to run a sub-60-minute half marathon, in New York, this year.

In Glasgow, the downpour made things harder. "We had to

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India's 1st CWG men's 10,000m silver

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Retrospective green nod

Justice Ujjal Bhuyan, in Vana-shakti vs Union of India, struck down a 2017 notification enabling retrospective environmental clearance and the subsequent 2021 office memorandum which laid down the Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for such clearances.

However, on November 18, 2025, the Supreme Court, citing public interest and legal flaws, recalled the May 16 ruling. It was a 2-1 verdict. The senior judge, Justice of India B R Gavai and Justice K Vinod Chandran backed the recall while Justice Bhuyan dissented saying the majority decision "overlooks the very fundamentals of environmental jurisprudence" and "is a step in retrogression".

Ruling on review petitions, the three-judge bench led by

CJI Surya Kant said Wednesday that the 2017 notification was a "valid, narrowly tailored and time-bound delegated legislation, traceable to Section 3 of the 1986 Act, and Sections 20 and 21 of the General Clauses Act."

The bench, however, struck down the 2021 office memorandum, saying it "is an administrative order and envisages a perpetual regime" for the grant of environmental clearances to projects taken without prior clearance.

"Substantially alters the nature of the enquiry as well as the criteria for the grant of environmental clearance under the 2006 notification. The 2021 office memorandum thereby supplants an earlier delegated legislation, which is impermissible in law," the bench said.

First trial in absentia begins today

of Criminal Procedure (CrPC) provided for recording evidence in the absence of the accused but did not permit a trial in absentia. The BNSS, which replaced CrPC, brought the provision for the first time.

"In simple terms, this means that an accused who deliberately remains absconding and evades the judicial process cannot indefinitely hold up the trial merely by staying away," said advocate Samridhi Dobhal, who is associated with the office of the Special Public Prosecutor.

In his order of July 9, Judge Gogme had said: "The court finds that the safeguards provided under section 356 (2) for trial of an absconding accused in absentia have been suitably addressed by the State... there is no impediment to the furtherance of the proceedings by way of considering charge."

The order stated: "Since all accused except one are in custody, the court deems it appropriate that the submissions on charge are heard on a day to day basis from 27.07.2026 till 07.08.2026. For the present, it is directed that the prosecution shall conclude its arguments on 27.07.2026 and 28.07.2026."

However, Judge Gogme was on leave on July 27 and 28. On Wednesday, the judge agreed to request from lawyers representing Delhi Police that they would commence arguments from Thursday because Special Public Prosecutor Akhand Pratap Singh was occupied with another matter.

Sangwan was granted interim bail in another MOCCA case registered in 2019. Following bail, he failed to surrender and has been absconding ever since.

In the extortion racket case to be heard Thursday, the trial in absentia comes after the Delhi Police Crime Branch and the court tried to get Sangwan to appear or join the investigation multiple times. Two NBWs (non-bailable warrants) were issued against him in June and July 2026.

In the July 9 order, Judge Gogme said, "It is seen that the NBWs could not be executed and his house (in Najafgarh) was found to be locked. It is also reported that the said accused has not been seen at the premises in question for a long time."

The Crime Branch also published a notice in a national newspaper regarding Sangwan's absence. They also reached out to a relative and gave an affidavit regarding the commencement of the proceedings.

"The significance of this order is that an absconding accused cannot be allowed to frustrate the criminal justice system simply by remaining beyond the reach of the law. To allow the application of trial in absentia, there is a minimum requirement of two NBWs against an accused and there should be a gap of one month between both NBWs," advocate Dobhal said.

"Of course, this is not an automatic process. The law provides several safeguards and requires the court to first satisfy itself that all the prescribed steps have been complied with. Once those requirements are fulfilled, the court can proceed with the trial even in the physical absence of the accused," she said.

bing, and murder in Delhi and Haryana.

He was arrested in 2016 and remained in jail until 2019, when he was granted parole for a month. During that period, his associates organised a grand party at a farmhouse, built on encroached government land, in Najafgarh. Although the Crime Branch raided the event and arrested several people, Sangwan could not be found. A Red Corner Notice was issued against him in June 2021.

Sangwan was also allegedly involved in the murder of Haryana INLD leader Nave Singh Rathore in February 2024. The killing is believed to be linked to his gang rivalry with jailed gangster Manoj Mahal.

On July 9, Special Judge Gogme directed that a legal aid counsel be assigned by the Delhi Legal Services Authority (DLA) to represent the gangster in the MOCCA case. As of today, Sangwan does not have a lawyer.

Advocate Hritwik Maurya, who is also associated with the office of the Special Public Prosecutor, said: "If he's convicted and judgement is passed by the trial court sentencing him under the provisions of MOCCA, and as such a situation arises where he is apprehended at a later stage, he will be directly sent to imprisonment to satisfy the sentencing judgement passed by the trial court since trial in his absence has already been concluded."

Former MLA and AAP leader Naresh Balyan was also booked under MOCCA in this case for his alleged links with Sangwan. Balyan, a two-time MLA from Uttam Nagar (2015 and 2020), was arrested in December 2024 and is in custody.

3 held for ransom in Thailand

cryptocurrency, according to media reports.

According to a report in *The Pattaya News*, the alleged ring-leader provided the victims' flight and passport details to the suspects. The victims were then intercepted and taken to the house where they were confined.

The police told the media that the suspects were promised valuables, cash and airline tickets to leave Thailand after carrying out the operation.

The investigation began after the Indian Embassy in Thailand alerted Chonburi Immigration Police and Pattaya City Police on July 21, following complaints from the victims' families. *The Nation* newspaper reported.

The families had reportedly shared video call recordings showing the victims with their hands and feet tied, and with assault marks. The abductors demanded a ransom of Rs 40 lakh from the family of each victim, the report said.

On Monday, the police raided a two-storey townhouse in Pattaya and rescued the three victims — identified as Mohit (23), Ashish (24) and Himanshu (20). According to a report, the victims told investigators that another Indian national had been held captive at the same property, and was allegedly released after his relatives paid

about Rs 30 lakh in ransom.

Citing local reports, *PTT* said the victims were found confined separately on the second floor of the house with their hands and feet tied, and their mouths taped. They also bore signs of assault. Investigators recovered adhesive tape, a wooden object allegedly used in the assaults, and red spray paint, which they believe was used to stage photographs and videos of the victims that were sent to their families to pressure them into paying the ransom, it said.

There was no official comment from the Indian Embassy in Thailand or the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on the matter.

Manmohan clean chit in coal case

Justices Joyymala Bagchi and V Mohana, was hearing a batch of petitions in connection with the coal block allocation cases. CBI, after investigation, filed closure reports, thereby giving the appellants a clean chit. Nevertheless, the learned Judge turned down the closure reports and took cognizance," the CJI-led bench said on Wednesday.

"Due to the unfortunate demise of the appellant, this appeal could be disposed of as *in-subsistent*. But with a view to considering the aspect of the learned Special Judge taking cognizance and summoning

the appellant, we have gone through both closure reports filed by CBI," it said.

Having regard to the relevant circumstances consently laid down by this court on acceptance of reports of the investigating agency, we are satisfied that there was no reason for the learned Judge to turn down the closure reports of the CBI and take cognizance," it said.

The case is related to the allocation of Talabira-II coal block in 2008. At that time, Singh, who was then the Prime Minister, also held the coal portfolio.

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FIR registered over 'defamatory' posts against PM, police seek details from X

Alok Singh
New Delhi, July 29

THE DELHI Police has registered an FIR in connection with "objectionable and defamatory" content posted on social media against Prime Minister Narendra Modi and other constitutional heads.

It has also written to X and other platforms to remove the content and provide details of users who posted them, The Indian Express has learnt.

According to sources, the content was mostly posted during the Cockerroach Janta Party's protest at Jantar Mantar.

A case under charges of criminal intimidation, public mischief, and defamation has been lodged at the Special Cell IFSO (Intelligence Fusion and Strategic Operations) unit in connection with the matter. On Sunday, The Indian Express reported that the Delhi Police has started asking social media platforms to take down such content.

According to sources, in one of the notices sent to a social media platform, the Delhi Police said the circulation of such "objectionable and defamatory content has caused serious harm to the PM's reputation, dignity and public image".

"The continued availability of such content has the potential to disturb public order, create unnecessary political controversy and erode public trust. Such acts also facilitate misuse of social media platforms for defamation and objectionable content and cyber-enabled offences."

"Therefore...you are hereby directed to remove or disable access to the aforesaid accounts as well as URLs immediately, within three hours of receipt of this intimation, while ensuring that the relevant data, logs and subscriber information are preserved for evidence purposes," the notice said.

Police have also identified around 500 social media accounts that allegedly shared deepfake and AI-generated content related to the protests. A police officer said these accounts have been recommended for blocking through the respective social media platforms.

On July 20, clashes broke out between Delhi Police personnel and CJP protesters, including students, leaving several injured. Police later registered 15 FIRs in connection with the violence, but subsequently decided to withdraw them.



A worker welds the barricades at Jantar Mantar in New Delhi on Wednesday. TASHI TOBOVAL

Delhi Police welds barricades at Jantar Mantar

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

FOLLOWING THE Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP's) warning that it would resume its protest if all FIRs lodged against the protesters are not immediately withdrawn, the Delhi Police has beefed up security by deploying additional personnel and welding barricades at Jantar Mantar.

At Jantar Mantar, where the CJP had staged a 36-day protest demanding the resignation of Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, barricades have



been installed and welded together with iron at both the sides.

A company of the Rapid Ac-

tion Force (RAF), along with local police personnel, has also been deployed round the clock officers said.

When contacted, Delhi Police sources said the security arrangements had been made in anticipation of a gathering at Jantar Mantar.

On Tuesday, the CJP threatened to resume its agitation, accusing the Centre of backtracking on its promise to not take legal action against protesters.

CJP spokesperson Ashu-

tosh Rana alleged a "complete breach" of the July 25 understanding with the Centre, claiming that hundreds of students had been arrested in BJP-ruled states.

Class 5 student sexually assaulted in school van, driver & helper arrested

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

A 11-YEAR-OLD girl, a Class 5 student of a public school in North Delhi, was allegedly sexually assaulted by her school van driver and his helper, police said on Wednesday.

The accused were arrested on Friday, said police. They have been booked under Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act. As per the police, the incident came to light on Friday, when the girl came to her class teacher and narrated her ordeal.

"She told her teacher that the driver would drop her near her

house after dropping all other students travelling in the van... After dropping everyone, he would allegedly sexually assault her along with his friend," said a source in the police. "This kept on happening for months. Every time she would resist, the accused would threaten to make her videos viral," the source added.

Police said the teacher informed the girl's parents, who filed a police complaint against the accused.

"The girl has been counselled and we are trying to find out whether the accused have been involved in similar incidents," the source said.

HC refuses to stay Centre's HPV vaccination drive

Sohini Ghosh
New Delhi, July 29

THE DELHI High Court Wednesday refused to stay the HPV vaccination drive after it was informed by the Centre that out of around 55.9 lakh doses administered since February, only 120 cases reported adverse events following immunisation (AEFI) as on July 25.

The court, which was hearing a PIL that flagged concerns over safety of administering Merck's HPV vaccine Gardasil, noted there was "no instant harm". Of the 120 AEFI cases, 42 were classified as "serious/severe", but no deaths were reported, the Centre mentioned.

It added that none of the AEFI cases required hospitalisation beyond two days.

• Skywatch

Forecast: July 30, 2026
Generally cloudy sky.
Spell of very light to light rain

MAX: 32-34
0.9°C below normal
MIN: 24-26
3.3°C below normal

• Sunrise: 5:42 AM (July 31)
• Sunset: 7:14 PM (July 30)
• Moonrise: 7:51 PM (July 30)
• Moonset: 7:02 AM (July 31)

• AQI Tracker

Alipur
Moderate
AQI: 131

Anand Vihar
Moderate
AQI: 146

Najafgarh
Satisfactory
AQI: 66

JNU
Good
AQI: 47

● Good (0-50)
● Satisfactory (51-100)
● Moderate (101-200)
● Poor (201-300)
● Very Poor (301-400)
● Severe (401-500)

To stop untreated sewage entering Yamuna, Delhi to get 15 new decentralised treatment plants

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

SEEKING TO tackle the single largest source of pollution entering Yamuna river, the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) on Wednesday approved sewerage and wastewater treatment projects worth around Rs 4,500 crore, including setting up of 15 decentralised sewage treatment plants (DSTPs), covering 1,000 km of sewer lines and upgrading existing treatment infrastructure. "These projects are expected to benefit around 20 lakh residents," said Water Minister Parvash Sahib Singh, adding that the work is set to be completed within 21 months.

In a statement, the government said the new plants will cater largely to areas where sewer infrastructure remains inadequate. While the city has steadily expanded its sewage treatment capacity over the years, large volumes of wastewater still enter drains - either because many colonies remain unconnected to the sewer network or sewage has to travel a long distance before reaching treatment plants.

Delhi currently has 22 drains discharging wastewater into Yamuna, with Najafgarh and Shahdara drains alone contributing around 80% of the total pollution load observed in the Capital.

Singh said that while 13 DSTPs had been approved earlier, the DJB has now awarded 15 additional DSTPs with a combined treatment capacity of 103.5 MGD at an investment of nearly Rs 2,000 crore.

Officials said the together, the DSTPs will add 227 million gallons per day (MGD) of treatment capacity, taking Delhi's overall sewage treatment ca-

capacity from 814 MGD to 1,041 MGD - exceeding the current sewage load of around 1,000 MGD generated by the city. Unlike large centralised STPs that require wastewater to travel over long distances through trunk sewers, decentralised sewage treatment plants are located closer to where sewage is generated and can help in tapping of drains directly at the source. Officials said this reduces dependence on extensive sewer networks, lowers pumping requirements and allows wastewater from unsewered or rapidly urbanising areas to be intercepted and treated before it enters nearby drains flowing into the Yamuna.

As per the Environment department records, there has been a marginal increase in Delhi's utilisation of installed sewage treatment capacity over the last three years - rising from 74.2% in 2022 to 79.16% in 2024, and reaching 80.9% in 2025. Despite this, a substantial volume of sewage remains untreated due to a daily deficit of around 174 MGD.

"It was a long-term requirement foreseeing that the city will need to expand its sewage treatment capacity, considering population growth, urban expansion and redevelopment of residential and commercial areas," a senior DJB official said. Alongside the plants, the DJB also approved laying of 989 km of new sewer pipelines and providing household sewer connections across 244 colonies and 57 villages. It further approved upgrades to existing treatment plants, a new 35 MGD STP, sludge management facilities at 10 existing STPs and in-situ treatment of the Delhi Ganga drain.

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Man stabbed to death after he confronts youths passing lewd remarks at friend

Pragnesh
New Delhi, July 29

A 30-YEAR-OLD man was stabbed to death inside a Delhi Development Authority (DDA) park in Northwest Delhi's Bharat Nagar on Tuesday afternoon after he allegedly confronted a group of four youths for passing lewd remarks at his woman friend, who was also critically injured in the attack.

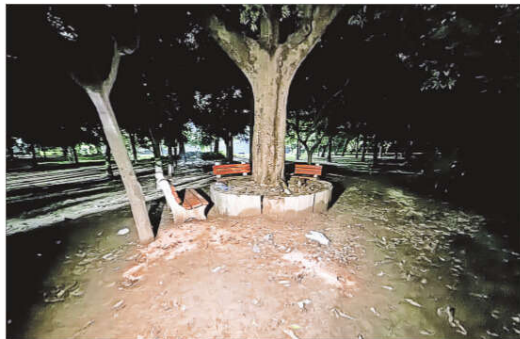
While police have apprehended a juvenile, the remaining accused are absconding.

A case of murder has been registered, officers said.

Police identified the deceased as Sunil, a resident of Mainpuri in Uttar Pradesh. He was visiting the city when the incident took place.

His friend, Devki (26), a resident of Jahangirpuri, has been admitted to the hospital.

According to police, Sunil and Devki had been sitting on a bench at Baba Chaudhary Khimman Singh Park in Ashok Vihar since around 2.30 pm. About an hour later, four youths allegedly approached them and passed lewd com-



The incident happened inside a DDA park in Northwest Delhi's Bharat Nagar. PHOTO: ANHANA

ments at Devki.

"Enraged, Sunil snapped back with abuses, which led to a scuffle. That was when one of the accused took out a knife and stabbed Sunil and Devki," a senior officer said.

A guard at the park, hearing Devika scream, rushed to

the spot.

"He found Devki lying in a pool of blood. She was asking for help, while the man was lying unconscious, with stab injuries all over his body. Three to four boys had fled the spot," the officer added.

Police said a PCR call re-

garding the incident was received at Bharat Nagar police station at 3.33 pm. "A police team immediately reached Khimman Singh Park in Ashok Vihar," said DCP Akanksha Vihar.

Both victims were taken to the hospital, where Sunil was

declared dead. Sunil had suffered four stab wounds, including injuries to his face and chest, police said.

Police said that in her preliminary statement, Devki has said that three to four men had approached them in the park before an argument broke out. "As one of the assailants pulled

out a knife, Sunil came in front of Devki and was stabbed. The accused then stabbed Devki, before fleeing," said an officer.

Two teams led by Inspector Robin Tyagi have been formed to identify and arrest the remaining suspects, police said.

Police said Sunil and Devki had known each other for years. "Sunil worked at an iron bending shop and kept visiting Delhi for business. Devki, who worked as a caretaker, was Sunil's friend and they had met multiple times earlier," said an officer.

"Her condition is very critical so we couldn't speak to her much... While Sunil's family is on their way from UP, Devki's family has been informed about the incident," the officer added.

Spread over more than 10 acres in Ashok Vihar Phase III, Baba Chaudhary Khimman Singh Park is frequented by joggers, families and children, and is about a 20-minute walk from the Shalimar Bagh Metro station. It witnesses a steady flow of people both in the morning and evening.

'THEY WANT TO EXCLUDE MOST WOMEN' AAP attacks govt over Laxmi Yojana eligibility criteria

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

THE AAP on Wednesday criticised the BJP-led Delhi government's monthly financial assistance scheme for women, alleging that the eligibility criteria have been laid out in a way that would exclude most women in the Capital.

According to the government, which announced that women with three children are not eligible, AAP chief Arvind Kejriwal said it was confusing for the Hindus as RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat has asked them to have many children.

"Mohan Bhagwat is saying that every Hindu should have as many children as possible and Rekha Gupta is saying that if you have more than three children, you will not get the benefit under the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana," read a post by Kejriwal on X.

"The helpless Hindus are scared. Rekha ji and Bhagwat ji should tell the Hindus what exactly they should do," he said. Bhagwat, at an event in February, had expressed concern over "a declining Hindu population", suggesting that Hindu families should consider having at least three children.

AAP's Delhi unit president Saurabh Bhardwaj, meanwhile, told *The Indian Express*: "The government is just trying to exclude as many people as possible who can benefit from the scheme."

"They have excluded women who have more than three children... women will have to show proof that they have lived here for more than 10 years, which will exclude mi-

grant labourers. They are trying to exclude everyone who needs the money the most," he said.

The Delhi Cabinet on Tuesday cleared the Delhi Lakshmi Yojana which will provide a monthly assistance of Rs 2,500 to women from the Economically Weaker Section (EWS). However, unlike similar schemes rolled out by several states, a detailed set of eligibility criteria for beneficiaries were also announced.

Women already receiving benefits under any other financial assistance scheme or pension, government employees, women with more than three living children, women from families with annual electricity consumption exceeding 2,400 units, those from families with a member employed by the government, women who own a four-wheeler, those who pay income tax or GST, and ones with a criminal record are ineligible.

"This government's image is bad... which is why they had to implement this policy, but they are just doing it to check the box, like a formality," Bhardwaj claimed.

"Before the Delhi elections, all of them — the Prime Minister, the BJP national president, the party spokespersons and leaders — claimed that every woman in Delhi would get Rs 2,500 per month. But what is the BJP doing now?" he said.

"They said women aged 21 to 60 are eligible and the money will be given to only one woman per family. You ask for votes from everyone. But when it comes to giving money, you will give to only one," he said.

Yamuna rises after release from Hathnikund, level of river likely to keep going up for two days

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, July 29

VARYING AMOUNTS of water released from the Hathnikund Barrage over the last two days have led to a staggered rise in the level of Yamuna river, with the Central Water Commission's (CWC) monitoring stations recording different levels of water between the barrage and Delhi. The CWC has forecast a gradual rise in the river water in the Capital over the next two days.

According to CWC data, water released from Hathnikund Barrage rose from 2.149 cusecs at 6 am on Tuesday (July 28) to 23.235 cusecs by 4 pm, touching 24.576 cusecs at 6 pm before falling later in the night. Another spike to 24.478 cusecs was recorded at 2 am on Wednesday, after which the discharge fell to 8.119 cusecs by 11 am.

Bhim Singh Rawat, a member of the South Asia Network on Dams, Rivers and People (SANDRP) said the fluctuations were due to the rainfall received in the upper Yamuna catchment, upstream of the Hathnikund Barrage, in the last few days. "The impact of these releases would be reflected in Delhi typically after 48 hours," he added.

The rainfall comes against the backdrop of a largely subdued monsoon witnessed by much of Haryana. According to India Meteorological Department's (IMD) data, Yamunaganj, where the barrage is located, has received 274.2 mm of rain against the usual 303.1 mm.

Panchkula, Ambala and Karnal have also recorded deficient rain, while Chandigarh has received above-normal rainfall, showing uneven rainfall across



The CWC has forecast a gradual rise in Yamuna over two days. FILE

the upper Yamuna basin.

Between Hathnikund and Delhi, the first cluster of CWC monitoring stations comprises Western Yamuna Canal, Fategarh, Panchkuan, Ghodopilli and Kala Naur. Of these, Panchkuan and Ghodopilli are flowing above their warning levels.

Downstream, while Karnal, Mawli Palla and Delhi Railway Bridge continue to flow normally, the CWC has forecast a gradual rise in the water levels over the next two days.

The CWC has forecast the Yamuna at the Delhi Railway Bridge to rise gradually from 202.2 m on Wednesday to 202.4 m by July 31. This is well below the warning level of 204.5 m, the danger mark of 205.33 m and the highest flood level of 208.66 m recorded during the 2023 floods.

The current water discharges from Hathnikund are also much lower than those during the 2023 floods when heavy rainfall across the upper Yamuna basin had resulted in unprecedented inflows into Delhi.

"After Hathnikund, there is a gap in data. We don't have discharge data for the river down-

stream of the barrage, making it difficult to track how the flow changes before reaching Delhi," Rawat said.

As per CWC data, Hindon river, meanwhile, has remained marginally above the warning level (195 m) but is still below the danger mark of 196 m, with the forecast indicating that levels are likely to remain elevated over the next two days.

Earlier this month, a rising Hindon had inundated low-lying settlements in parts of Gaziabad and Gautam Budhha Nagar, prompting the Uttar Pradesh Irrigation department to step up monitoring while maintaining that the river remained below the danger level.

Unlike the Yamuna, whose flows into Delhi are influenced by releases from the Hathnikund Barrage, the Hindon is a separate, primarily rain-fed tributary with its own catchment.

Originating in the lower Shivalik ranges in Saharanpur district of UP, it flows through western UP before joining the Yamuna downstream of Delhi near Greater Noida.

Cash to digital: Payment for Metro rides changes track

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, July 29

NEARLY THREE-FOURTH of the revenue of Delhi Metro — India's largest Metro network — now comes from cashless transactions. This marks a reversal in trends eight years ago when income in cash accounted for almost three-fourth of its revenue, according to the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation's (DMRC) internal data. *The Indian Express* has learnt.

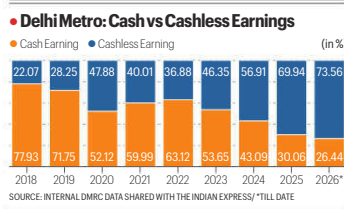
This year, so far, digital transactions have accounted for 73.56% of earnings against 73.56% in cash — largely representative of the trends in the two categories. In 2018, this split was almost the opposite with 73.93% cash transactions and 22.07% cashless earnings. Notwithstanding the shift, Smart Cards are preferred by around half of Metro commuters, the data shows. Habit, faster entry and exit at gates, and fare discounts are said to be some factors behind the preference.

As per the data, a little over 3% passengers use the Virtual Smart Card, available on Delhi Metro Sarthi App.

QR-based paper tickets, bought at counters, or ticket vending machines, account for about 18% of the transactions.

Digital QR tickets booked through mobile apps and messaging platforms (including the Delhi Metro Sarthi app, Paytm, PhonePe, WhatsApp and ONDC-linked platforms such as Rapido and Uber) make up around 9% of rides.

Bank-issued National Common Mobility Cards (NCMC), including those issued via Airtel Payments Bank under the 'One Nation, One Card' scheme, account for close to



20% of trips.

Officials have attributed the digitisation push to a need to cut queues at counters and token vending machines, reduce cash handling, and enable interoperable travel through NCMC across Metro networks. "Over time, there has been a gradual shift towards contactless options like UPI, QR-code based tickets, and upgraded NCMC," an official said. According to officials, a series of tie-ups with different companies has led to increased usage of cards.

DMRC first launched an online Smart Card recharge facility over a decade ago in 2014. UPI app Paytm followed with Smart Card recharge in March 2016, and PhonePe in October 2018. In 2021, Amazon Pay launched a feature to recharge smart cards in 2021 and WhatsApp launched it in 2024.

The Virtual Smart Card, a dynamic QR code on a phone that functions like a physical smart card, was introduced in September 2024 — much later compared to other digital options.

QR-based tickets took over longer to reach the network. QR ticketing through the RIDE.R app, a public transport ticketing and commuting app, was intro-

duced only on the Airport Express Line in September 2018, followed by Paytm QR ticketing on the same line in August 2019. It took nearly five more years for the launch of the Airport Line's WhatsApp-based ticketing facility in May 2023. This was followed by an extension of QR ticketing to the entire DMRC network in October 2023.

Since then, the options have expanded quickly. WhatsApp QR ticketing and PhonePe QR ticketing, both rolled out in 2024, Amazon Pay followed in August that year, and a soft launch of ticketing through app linked to Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC), which allows commuters to buy digital QR tickets directly through everyday consumer apps such as Rapido and Uber, arrived in November 2024.

NCMC has had the most staggered rollout of all. It was first introduced on the Airport Express Line in December 2020, but did not start working across the rest of the DMRC network until June 2023. Airtel Payments Bank was roped in from January 2023 to let commuters top up NCMC cards through its Thanks app, ahead of the card's network-wide activation.

Delhi Medical Council gets 4 members a year after its dissolution

Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, July 29

THE DELHI Chief Minister's Office (CMO) on Wednesday, in a post on X, announced the appointment of four members to the Delhi Medical Council (DMC), more than a year after the body was dissolved amid allegations of administrative and financial irregularities.

"The Government of Delhi has appointed Dr. Ajay Kumar, Dr. Hansraj Baveja, Dr. S. K. Tandon, and Dr. Vinod Kumar Monga as members of the Delhi Medical Council," read the CMO's post.

"The Delhi Medical Council plays an important role in maintaining quality, transparency, and medical ethics in healthcare services. These appointments will make significant contributions to strengthening Delhi's health system by making the Council's functions even more effective," it also said.

The DMC was dissolved by then Lieutenant Governor (LG) V. N. Khanna in July 2025. The council had not been reconstituted since — a gap that

has also caused significant delays in registration of doctors.

While ordering the dissolution, the former LG had allowed two ex-officio members to continue temporarily, assigned the role of registrar to the Directorate General of Health Services for the interim period, and had directed the Health department to reconstitute the council in two months, under the Delhi Medical Council Act, 1997.

In December 2025, as reported by *The Indian Express*, a special audit was ordered to investigate allegations that the DMC had collected roughly Rs 28 crore in recent years without proper audit or fund segregation. The committee has also been examining if such recovery can be made from the personal accounts of Dr. Girish Tyagi, who previously served as the acting registrar and has held the positions of both the president and vice-president of the council.

Dr Tyagi has since filed a case in the Delhi High Court seeking to quash a government order directing him to vacate his post.

• THE BROTHERS, CONVICTED IN A 1996 MURDER CASE, JUMPED BAIL AND VANISHED FOR DECADES

A trader's murder in Delhi, a Mumbai killing and long trail of two fugitive brothers

Pragnesh
New Delhi, July 29

ON MAY 14, 2006, as a vendor arrived at Mumbai's Bhindi Bazaar mutton market to open his stall, he saw a plastic bag lying on his handcart. Curious, he opened it to find a dead man's torso, the head and limbs severed.

He alerted the police but the case eventually went cold.

More than a decade later, a tip-offed Mumbai Police to two brothers — Firasat Ali and Arshad Ali — who investigators alleged were behind the killing. They were soon arrested by the Mumbai Police.

While Arshad remained in jail, Firasat disappeared in January 2021, when he was granted bail by the Bombay High Court. Soon, investigators found that he is absconding in another

murder case too — this time in Delhi — for 26 years.

Firasat and his other brother, Shah Nawaz, had been sentenced to life imprisonment for killing a trader in 1996 but had disappeared after securing bail in 2000. Earlier this month, nearly 30 years after the trader's murder, Delhi Police finally arrested Firasat and Shah Nawaz.

The headless torso

In the Bhindi Bazaar case, investigators grappled with one question: who was the victim and what was a gang hit.

The area had long been associated with Mumbai's underworld. One linked to Dawood Ibrahim's D-Company, Bhindi Bazaar was by 2006 witnessing a changing crime landscape.

Gulabrao More, then an assistant sub-inspector at Nag-

pada police station, joined the investigation at the JJ Marg police station in South Mumbai. But identifying the victim proved impossible. DNA samples led nowhere and no missing person's complaint matched the remains.

Over a decade later, More — an inspector with MRA More police station by then — received a call from an informer claiming that he knew the identity of the victim and the killer.

"The deceased was Kishan Khavra, who would have been 57 years old at that time. The caller said that the killer was someone named Firasat and his brother," More told *The Indian Express*.

Within days, Mumbai Police arrested the brothers. They refused to divulge anything about the crime, prompting investiga-



Shah Nawaz and (right) Firasat Ali. EXPRESS

tors to trace Khavra's family.

They found that Khavra lived in Kamathipura with his wife, Bansiben, and their four children. Police said Bansiben sold utensils door-to-door, often accepting old clothes in exchange. Once she had collected enough, she sold them to wholesale traders, including Firasat.

During questioning, Bansiben admitted to have allegedly



hired the two men to kill her husband. "Khavra was addicted to alcohol and used to physically assault and abuse his wife besides frequently accusing her of infidelity. Bansiben gave a contract to kill her husband, paying Rs 2 lakh to Firasat and Arshad. Firasat murdered Khavra, dismembered the body, and disposed of the body parts at different locations," said DCP

(Crime Branch) Sanjeev Yadav in Delhi. As investigators dug deeper into Firasat's past, they uncovered the second murder.

The 1996 killing

On September 27, 1996, Ishat Ahmad (27), a wholesale clothes trader from Moradabad, had spent the day buying second-hand clothes in West Delhi's Raghunagar. "He and his brothers were at the market along with their neighbour from Moradabad, Shah Nawaz, also a clothes trader," said an officer.

An argument broke out between Ishat's brother Sharafat Ali and Shah Nawaz over a saree they wanted to buy. "Shah Nawaz threatened us with dire consequences for taking that saree from him. He said he would be back," Sharafat told

the police in his complaint.

Hours later, Shah Nawaz arrived at Ishat's rented room in Raghunagar with three men, including Firasat. "Armed with knives, they launched a deadly attack," said the officer.

According to police reports, the attack resembled a gang hit. Police said Firasat and Shah Nawaz went for Ishat while the others attacked his brothers.

"Based on Sharafat's statement, an FIR was registered. Murder charges were added after Ishat's death," said DCP Yadav.

Delhi High Court upheld their conviction.

The catch

After his arrest in Mumbai, Firasat remained in jail until January 2021, when he was granted bail by the Bombay High Court. He then disappeared. There was no trace of Shah Nawaz either.

Nearly five years later, Delhi Police Crime Branch's Anti-Robbery and Snatching Cell (ARSC) received fresh intelligence — Firasat had returned to his hometown of Moradabad, while Shah Nawaz was living in Godda, Jharkhand.

"On July 4, two teams simultaneously conducted raids at Moradabad and Godda. Both were apprehended," said the DCP. Both are now lodged in Thar Jail.

APPEAL AGAINST DETENTION AFTER SIR DELETION

Voter ID, Aadhaar, PAN not conclusive proof of Indian citizenship: Calcutta HC

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, July 29

THE CALCUTTA High Court has held that voter identity card, Aadhaar number, PAN and bank account passbook are not conclusive proof of Indian citizenship.

The observation came on Tuesday when a division bench comprising Justices Debangsu Basak and Ajay Kumar Gupta was hearing a habeas corpus petition filed by one Suman Molla, who claimed that his nephew, Nasir, had been placed in a detention camp after his name was deleted from the electoral rolls during the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) exercise in West Bengal. Molla stated that Nasir was sent to a detention camp even though an appeal against the deletion was pending and he filed a police complaint in this regard on June 18.

The petitioner relied on Nasir's voter identity card, Aadhaar card, PAN card issued by the Income Tax Department and a bank account passbook to

“Write petitioner and the detainee are unable to discharge the burden of proof as mandated by the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025”
CALCUTTA HIGH COURT

contend that he was an Indian citizen and not a foreign national. Observing that a voter identity card only establishes that a person was enrolled in the electoral rolls, the bench noted that Nasir's name had been deleted during the 2026 SIR process. The court also held that opening a bank account, by itself, is not proof of Indian citizenship.

“Write petitioner and the detainee are unable to discharge the burden of proof as mandated by the Immigration and Foreigners Act, 2025,” the court observed. Holding that neither

the petitioner nor the detainee had established Nasir's Indian citizenship, the court said it was not inclined to interfere with the decision of the authorities and dismissed the habeas corpus petition.

The advocate appearing for the petitioner submitted that in the SIR, Nasir was initially classified as ‘under adjudication’ and then his name was deleted without giving him an opportunity of hearing by the Tribunal.

The counsel also referred to the CS Record of Rights documents annexed with the writ petition showing that the great-grandfather of the detainee owned an immovable property.

The counsel appearing for the State submitted a report that identified the detainee as a foreign national. The counsel also placed a video recording of the detainee himself admitting that he was a foreign national.

The petition also stated that following the death of Nasir's father in 1980, Molla had brought up the detainee. The court, however, noted that the

petitioner is aged 38 while the detainee is 46. The bench rejected the petitioner's claim that he had brought up Nasir as his uncle. The court also drew an adverse inference against the detainee about his parents being Indian citizens after he and the writ petitioner refused to identify the burial site for the DNA test.

The court also observed that the writ petition does not disclose the birth certificate of the detainee. “Adequate material to establish place of birth or date of birth is absent in the writ petition and the supplementary affidavit. Citizenship by birth is not established. So far as citizenship by descent is concerned, there are tenuous connections. Name of the father of the detainee varies from document to document... Indian citizenship of the persons through whom the detainee seeks to connect as descent is also not established. Citizenship of the detainee by descent is not established,” the court observed.

MID-DAY MEAL SCHEME

Amid row, Suvendu says West Bengal govt will provide eggs with ISKCON-cooked veg food

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, July 29

WEST BENGAL Chief minister Suvendu Adhikari on Wednesday said that the government will provide eggs in mid-day meals along with the proposed ISKCON-cooked vegetarian meals in schools across Kolkata from August 1. This comes amid a controversy after the BJP government announced an overhaul of the mid-day meal scheme with its proposal to partner with ISKCON to provide cooked meals under a pilot project that would drop eggs from the menu.

Speaking to the media during a programme of the school education department at Nabanna, Adhikari said, “From August 1, as a pilot project, ISKCON will provide mid-day meals in various schools in Kolkata. They will serve highly nutritious food to the students. Along with them, the state government, through SHG (Self Help Groups), will provide eggs to the students for protein. Odisha follows this model. ISKCON serves mid-day



West Bengal CM Suvendu Adhikari visits Belur Math in Howrah district on the occasion of Guru Purnima on Wednesday. (PI)

meals in 22 cities in the country.”

While presenting the BJP government's first budget in the Assembly, Finance Minister Swapna Dasgupta had announced the overhaul, significantly raising the material allocation per student and partnering with the International Society for Krishna Consciousness (ISKCON) to serve purely vegetarian meals in Kolkata schools as a pilot project. This led to a controversy, with

the Opposition alleging that the government was promoting vegetarian food and depriving the students of protein.

Adhikari had said, “We are giving the responsibility of cooking mid-day meals to ISKCON. ISKCON will cook food. If you have an objection, do not say ‘Hare Krishna’, no one will force you to do that. You will get good food to eat. You will get to eat pure food, nothing to worry about.” Recently, the chief min-

ister highlighted that allotment for each student even in the primary section for mid-day meals has been increased to Rs 10 and that monthly wages for workers engaged with mid-day meals in schools has been hiked from Rs 2,000 to Rs 3,000.

Meanwhile, Adhikari also announced a composite grant to schools in Bengal, after three years. “The previous government deprived the schools of this valuable grant for the last three years. In this scheme, the Centre gives 60% of the funds and the state government gives 40%. Today, we gave Rs 296.64 crore to over 80,000 schools in the state. This will be helpful to the students. Since we have implemented the 2020 National Education Policy (NEP) we will benefit from central schemes,” Adhikari said.

The CM also stated that digital learning will be promoted in over 1200 schools. “In higher secondary schools we are including basic learning of Artificial Intelligence. We are also trying to go for audio visual learning in the schools,” he added.

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requirements. Intellectual Property Rights has also gained prominence as innovation, start-ups, and creative industries flourish. Cyber law has become another sought-after option in a digital economy where issues related to piracy, cybersecurity, and online transactions demand specialised legal expertise.

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AMID OPPOSITION PROTEST

RS passes Bill criminalising insult to Vande Mataram

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, July 29

THE RAJYA SABHA on Wednesday passed a Bill that criminalises intentional disruption or prevention of the singing of the national song, Vande Mataram, thereby according it legal sanctity at par with the national anthem, Jana Gana Mana.

The Prevention of Insults to National Honour (Amendment) Bill, 2026, seeks to amend a 1971 law by the same name, which makes insults towards the national anthem, national flag and the Constitution a criminal offence.

The Bill was passed through a voice vote following a walkout by nearly all opposition members. When the upper House proceedings resumed at 2pm, Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Hariwansh invited members to begin a discussion on the Bill.

However, opposition members protested and raised shouts demanding Home Minister Amit Shah's statement on the recent Delhi Police action against students and youngsters who were protesting against paper leaks at Jantar Mantar.

The Bill states that intentionally preventing the singing of the national song or causing disturbance to any assembly engaged in its singing will be punishable with imprisonment for a term which may extend to three years, or fine, or both. Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai had introduced the Bill for consideration in the upper House on July 24.

Replying to a question on the Bill, Nityanand Rai said he could not understand why some members, and especially the Congress party, have a



Rajya Sabha Deputy Chairman Hariwansh conducts the proceedings of the House on Wednesday. **ANI**

problem with the Bill. "This is not just an amendment but our commitment towards national awareness, cultural heritage and the values of our freedom struggle," he said.

The Union minister said that when Bankim Chandra Chatterjee composed the national song in 1875, he had said that one day it will be on every Indian's lips "as a mantra". Rai claimed that as Congress President, Jawaharlal Nehru limited the national song to only two stanzas in 1937. He went on to add that in 1938, Netaji Subhas Chandra Bose, as the Congress president, had urged Timir Baran Bhattacharya to compose the full version of the song.

"On 24th January, 1950, Dr Rajendra Prasad said in the Constituent Assembly that Vande Mataram should be honoured on par with Jana Gana Mana," Rai said. "Opposing this

(Bill) only means that the Congress wants to adopt appeasement and wants to insult our national pride... the country's youth, workers, and women will not support this," Rai added.

Earlier, when the Bill was taken up for discussion, there was uproar in the House. Congress' Ranjit Ranjan was slated to begin the discussion, but as the MP joined her colleagues in protests seeking the Home Minister's presence, Deputy Chairman Hariwansh said the member was not interested in speaking (on the Bill).

BJP's Radha Mohan Das Agrawal, who was given the next opportunity to speak, said that the national song has been insulted for the last 123 years, and added that not just today's Congress party but even the one during the freedom struggle repeatedly insulted the song.

Among opposition members, Deputy Leader of the Opposition Pramod Tiwari, Saagarika Ghose and Trinchi Siva sought to demand Amit Shah's presence, but the Deputy Chairman did not allow them to speak on any issue other than the Bill.

Manoj Kumar Jha of Rashtriya Janata Dal said, "I am witnessing for the first time that our national song and national anthem are being pitted against each other. Reverence cannot be legislated." Biju Janata Dal's Sultana Deo said none of the members of the House can sing the national song correctly and urged that it should be played in all state assemblies as well as in Parliament.

Aam Aadmi Party's Sanjay Singh said that while his party supports the Bill, there should also be a Bill against those who insult the National Anthem and the Tricolour.

Opp's next move: Raising Ram temple 'donation theft', keeping heat on Shah over police action

Asad Rehman & Liz Mathew
New Delhi, July 29

WITH THE Bill seeking stringent measures to prevent exam paper leaks getting passed in the Lok Sabha on Wednesday, the Opposition is learnt to be readying a strategy to keep the pressure on the government by shifting its focus on the alleged donation theft at Ayodhya's Ram Temple, while also continuing to attack Union Home Minister Amit Shah over the police action against protesting students on July 20.

While the Samajwadi Party is all set to raise the alleged theft of donations at Ayodhya's Ram Temple on the floor of the House to attack the BJP, Congress, too, does not want to let the momentum weaken and will continue to target Home Minister Shah over the police action on the protesting students. Sources, however, said that leaders from both sides are trying to create a consensus on issues to be taken on priority.

The Congress-led Opposition, which believes that it has succeeded in cornering the government over the issue of police action on the students, appeared buoyed from the Lok Sabha proceedings on Wednesday, and is keen to keep the momentum.

"The Leader of Opposition has successfully raised the issue related to Home Minister's accountability during the debate today. Congress wants to continue with the same on Thursday in the Lok Sabha," said a senior Congress leader. "The LoP was not allowed to complete. We cannot leave the issue there."

He, however, said, "Our strategy meeting in the morning will take a call on how we have to



SP MP Dimple Yadav and party colleagues stage a protest over the Ram Temple donation theft issue, in Parliament on Wednesday. **ANI**

prioritise these issues. The decision will be a collective one." Sources in the Congress said the party's decision to keep the momentum on students' issues would "be sensible politically". For many party leaders, who admitted that no opposition party could take advantage of the "anti-BJP sentiments" created out of the students' protest, raising the issue of police action against the protesters could "help to gain some ground".

"Our assessment is that Rahul Gandhi seeking answers from the Home Minister for the brutal attack on students — which included the alleged use of pellet guns — will help keep the heat on the government for holding the relevant officials accountable," said a Congress MP. "We have more than 100 MPs, including smaller allies like IUML and RSP, who think that it is very important."

Sources said that during the meeting in Rajya Sabha Leader of Opposition Mallikarjun Kharge's chamber on Wednesday morning, all Opposition parties, including the Congress,

SP and the TMC, agreed that the focus of the Opposition must now shift to the Ram Temple issue with elections in Uttar Pradesh early next year. The SP has over the last few days been asking its allies to shift the focus from the paper leaks issue to the Ram Temple and has been "waiting patiently," said sources.

The SP has been very particular with us and has been waiting for the Ram Temple donation theft to come to the centre of the Opposition's agenda. Now that they have been waiting for the last few days, we have decided it is time to shift the focus of the Opposition to the issue," said a source present at the meeting on Wednesday. A source in the SP said the Congress and other allies have agreed to raise the issue of Ram Temple in the House on Thursday. "There is broad consensus among us. We are all united. We will take a final call on our strategy tomorrow. But Ram Temple has to be taken up in the Lok Sabha and we have got our allies on board for that," said the source.

TN widens liquor corruption probe, books ex-minister Balaji

Arun Janardhanan
Chennai, July 29

TAMIL NADU'S anti-corruption agency on Wednesday described as a long-system of manipulation in liquor procurement, transport contracts, berlicences and administrative decision-making within the Tamil Nadu State Marketing Corporation (TASMAC).

The Directorate of Vigilance and Anti-Corruption (DVAC) began searches around 7 am at Senthil Balaji's residence in Rameshwarapatti in Karur, the homes of several associates and former aides, and the TASMAC district office in Karur. Raids were simultaneously conducted across Chennai, Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Erode, the Nilgiris and



V Senthil Balaji was the excise minister in the previous DMK government

the case. The searches followed the registration of a First Information Report on Tuesday night naming Senthil Balaji, former TASMAC Managing Director S Visakan, IAS; former senior regional managers T Rama Durai Murugan and P Panneer Selvam; former ministerial aide Bhaskar, and two private individuals, Rathesh Raj Shanmugavel and S Karthikakalas Mulanor Karthik. The FIR also refers to unnamed public servants, transport firms, bottling companies and distilleries.

All those named were unavailable for comment.

Rather than focusing on a single transaction, the FIR portrays what investigators allege

was an organised network operating between 2021 and 2025 that influenced nearly every major commercial interface between TASMAC and private players.

According to the FIR, investigators allege that district and regional officials manipulated tenders for TASMAC bars and transport contracts, favoured selected bidders, allowed cartelisation among applicants, and enabled firms to continue operating despite expired licences, resulting in substantial losses to the government. It cites alleged irregularities in bar tenders across Coimbatore, Tiruppur, Erode, Namakkal, the Nilgiris and Karur, and claims that officials colluded with bar operators instead of conducting fresh tenders where required.

The FIR also alleges that transport tenders for 45 TASMAC depots were manipulated through the misuse of earnest money deposit demand drafts submitted by one applicant. Investigators claim that unused demand drafts were allegedly diverted to facilitate other transport contractors, allowing them to secure contracts.

Water release: Shivakumar offers Vijay chopper tour of Cauvery

Akram M
New Delhi, July 29

KARNATAKA CHIEF Minister D K Shivakumar Wednesday said the state government will challenge the Cauvery Water Regulation Committee's (CWRC) order directing the release of Cauvery water to Tamil Nadu by filing an appeal before the Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA). He also invited Tamil Nadu Chief Minister Joseph Vijay to visit the Cauvery basin in Karnataka to assess the ground reality firsthand.

Speaking to reporters in New Delhi, Shivakumar said a high-level meeting was held with the Advocate General, legal experts, and senior officials regarding the CWRC order. "Preparations are currently underway to file an appeal before the CWMA," he said.

On Tuesday, the CWRC directed Karnataka to release 3,500 cusecs of water daily to Tamil Nadu for 15 days. Issued amid severe distress and rainfall deficit across Karnataka's catchment areas, the directive sparked widespread protests in key basin districts, including Mandya and Mysuru.



Activists being detained during a protest against the CWRC order directing daily release of 3,500 cusecs of Cauvery water for 15 days to Tamil Nadu, in Bengaluru on Wednesday. **PTI**

Responding to questions on the issue, Shivakumar noted that the CWRC had previously turned down Tamil Nadu's demands for water release on two occasions, citing shortages. "However, this time it has directed Karnataka to release water. We have discussed all legal remedies with Water Resources Minister Ramalinga Reddy and the officials concerned," he said.

The Chief Minister added that upon returning to Bengaluru, he would convene a meeting with Opposition party

leaders to discuss the state's strategy. He mentioned plans to meet with CM Vijay soon, as the Tamil Nadu leader is expected to visit Karnataka in the coming days.

"We have requested Chief Minister Vijay to assess the situation in the Cauvery basin personally. I have also informed him that the Karnataka government will make all necessary helicopter arrangements for his visit. He should witness the ground realities himself, and let us see what decision he takes," Shivakumar added.

Mamata urges EC to conclude 'TMC dispute' inquiry without giving rival camp any more time

Kolkata: Former West Bengal chief minister Mamata Banerjee on Wednesday urged the Election Commission to conclude its inquiry into the dispute over rival claims over the Trinamool Congress without granting any further extension to the rival faction led by Leader of the Opposition, Ritabrata Banerjee.

In a letter to Election Commission secretary Ashwani Kumar Mohal on Wednesday, Banerjee requested the poll panel to "conclude the investigation as early as possible without providing them with any further date to submit their comments".

Claiming that the rival camp had failed to respond despite repeated extensions granted by the commission, Banerjee said, "It can be inferred that all our submissions and statements pointed out in our letter dated 6 July 2026 have been admitted and they do not have any answer to that." **PTI**

Amid SIR, another Cong govt eases paper trail: Telangana rolls out Family Register Certificate

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, July 29

AFTER KARNATAKA'S move to issue Permanent Residence Certificates as a means to ease documentation amidst the Special Inland Revenue (SIR) of electoral rolls, the Congress government in neighbouring Telangana has introduced a Telangana Family Register and Family Register Certificate (FRC) as "an authenticated and reliable record of family composition".

In an order issued on July 25, the government directed that the FRCs will be maintained electronically using data sourced from the Food Security Card database of ration card holders.

The register will contain details such as the family's ration



Telangana CM Revanth Reddy

card number — which will also serve as the Family Register Identification Number — along with the names of family members, the date of birth, date of birth, gender, Aadhaar details and residential address.

Like Permanent Residence Certificate, "Family Register" is a document issued by the Election Commission (EC) as one of the

12 that can be produced during the SIR exercise to be included in the electoral rolls.

The BJP has opposed the Revanth Reddy government's move, with its Telangana chief N Ramcharan Rao accusing the Congress regime of trying "to protect its illegal vote bank" as the SIR exercise seeks to filter out voters. The party has raised similar objections to the Karnataka government's PRC move.

"The Congress, Rashtriya Samithi and AIMIM, which have sheltered illegal vote banks for decades, can now see their political death warrant in the SIR. This is why the Congress government is rushing to issue FRCs, which is completely illegal," Rao said in a post on X on Tuesday.

Defending the FRC, adviser

to the Telangana government Mohammed Ali Shabbir called it "a significant citizen-centric reform that would reduce documentation-related hardships faced by poor and economically weaker sections". Shabbir had earlier urged the Chief Minister to introduce a Permanent Residence Certificate on the lines of Karnataka, arguing that residents need government-issued proof of domicile that could be used for official purposes, including electoral verification.

AIMIM president and Hyderabad MP Asaduddin Owaisi also welcomed the Telangana government's decision.

According to the July 25 order by the Reddy government, the FRC would be "a record of the composition of the family as reflected in the source database".

BENCH IMPOSES FINE ON BHADOHI SP, SHO

Police should investigate crimes, not marriages: Allahabad HC

Bhupendra Pandey
Lucknow, July 29

TAKING NOTE of an investigation in a case against a couple who married against the wishes of the woman's family, the Allahabad High Court came down heavily on the police officials concerned, observing that police should investigate crimes and not marriages and that they "have no business in the matter to be nosy partners".

In a July 27 order, a division bench of Justices JJ Munir and Tarun Saxena imposed a fine on the Bhadohi superintendent of police (SP) and the Suriyawan station house officer (SHO), and quashed the FIR lodged against the man by the woman's father

on charges of abduction to force her into marriage against her will. The bench stated, "The police have no business in the matter to be nosy partners. We have repeatedly reminded the police that it is no business of theirs to investigate marriages. They ought to investigate crimes. This is no crime, where any investigation is required."

The couple, aged 28 and 27, who are postgraduates with certificate courses in teaching, had a petition filed against the FIR lodged against the man on April 19 in Bhadohi district, saying they were "major".

The two informed the court that they got married with Arya Samaj rituals in Prayagraj on February 18 after being in a rela-

tionship for one year. The woman's father lodged the case against the man after coming to know of the marriage on April 18. After the petition was filed, the HC on April 29 had stated that "two major citizens of the country married according to Hindu rites" and "prima facie there was nothing in the FIR to investigate". In an interim order, the court had stayed the police investigation as well as the petitioners' arrest.

In its July 29 order, the bench observed, "...To continue the investigation into an adult's free choice of her partner... is not only an abuse of process of criminal law, but also gross violation of their fundamental right to liberty."



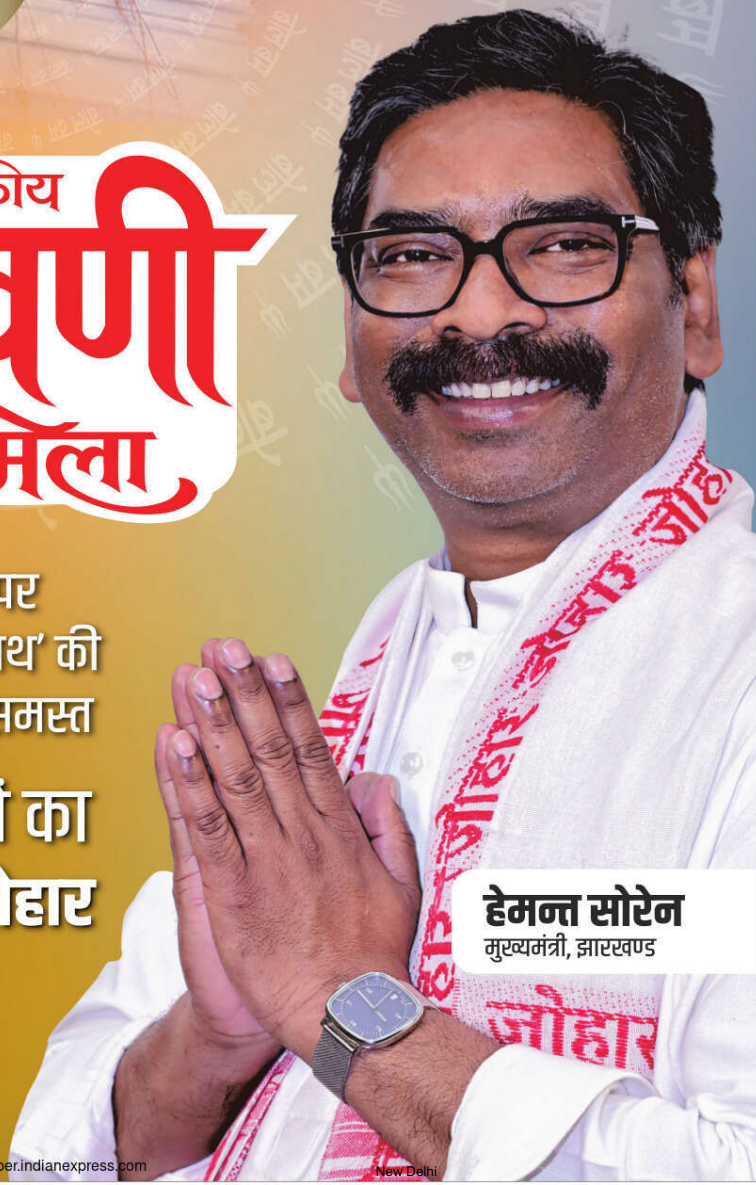
शिवमः शिवाय



राजकीय

श्रावणी मेला

श्रावण मास के पावन अवसर पर
'बाबा वैद्यनाथ और बाबा बासुकीनाथ' की
भूमि झारखण्ड में पधारने वाले समस्त
कांवरियों एवं श्रद्धालुओं का
हार्दिक अभिनंदन एवं जोहार



हेमन्त सोरेन
मुख्यमंत्री, झारखण्ड

सूचना एवं जनसम्पर्क विभाग, झारखण्ड

'Did you shout Free Umar Khalid slogan?': Goa cops ask protesters to answer 240 queries

Pavneet Singh Chadha
Panaji, July 29

AT LEAST two protesters, who joined a protest in Goa's Mapusa on July 24 to express solidarity with the protests at New Delhi's Jantar Mantar, were asked by the Goa police to fill a questionnaire with questions such as "What is your understanding of the words 'Free Umar Khalid'?", "Did you criticise any government authority during your address?", and "Who financed the protest?". The *Indian Express* has learnt.

On Saturday evening, the day after the protest, the Goa police detained a man for allegedly carrying a "Free Umar Khalid" placard at a gathering in Panaji's Azad Maidan. Now, *The Indian Express* has learnt that at least two protesters were summoned — one on Sunday and the other on Monday — and questioned by the police, based on an "application" submitted by a local group, "Citizens of Mapusa".

They were asked to fill a police questionnaire that included at least 240 questions, it learnt. They include: Who was leading the protest? Are you a member of any WhatsApp, Telegram or Signal group related to the protest? How did you travel to the venue? What did you intend to achieve through the protest? And are you associated with any political party, social organisation, student organisation, NGO or activist group? Many of the questions were specifically about Khalid, an activist and a former JNU student, facing charges of criminal conspiracy under the UAPA in connection with the 2020 Northeast Delhi riots.

They include: Were you aware of the background relating to Umar Khalid before attending the protest? Did you shout the slogan 'Free Umar Khalid'? If yes, how many times did you raise the slogan? Did others repeat the slogan after

you? Who financed or arranged the banners, placards, sound system or other materials? How many placards were distributed at the venue? Did you post any photo of yourself while holding the placard on social media?

The police questionnaire asked the protesters to specify whether they had participated in a similar protest in Goa or elsewhere in India, and provide the date, place, and purpose of those protests. It asked protesters whether they had deleted any e-data related to the protest, and could provide their phones for examination.

When contacted, North Goa SP Harishchandra Madkaikar said, "A complaint was filed by a group, Citizens of Mapusa. Based on that, we called them (the protesters) for an inquiry and after conducting the inquiry, they were allowed to go." On the questionnaire, the SP said, "Certain questions were put to them and recorded as part of the inquiry. Usually when we start an inquiry, we are supposed to ask questions until we get a satisfactory answer, so certain questions were put."

On Wednesday, Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant questioned protesters bringing placards seeking Khalid's release at a protest against paper leaks. The students' right to protest against NEET paper leaks, [but] they stooped too low. Placards seeking the release of Umar Khalid, who has links to Parliament attack convict Afzal Guru, were shown at the protest at Azad Maidan. Why was the Umar Khalid issue brought into a protest over the NEET paper leak? We need to awaken nationalism in our students, so they do not disturb communal harmony." On Sunday, he had said that police would take action against "those attempting to spread anti-national sentiments and disturb the harmony" in the state.

Bihar withdraws 64 FIRs against NEET-UG protesters; cases against 21 in Siwan remain

Santosh Singh
Patna, July 29

AFTER ANNOUNCING its decision to drop all cases against NEET-UG protesters, the Bihar government has now initiated the withdrawal of 64 FIRs lodged against the state.

In a letter to district magistrates and public prosecutors on Tuesday, Bihar Advocate General SD Sanjay wrote: "As per [the] decision taken by [the] Government of Bihar regarding withdrawal of all cases registered before 6 pm of 26 July 2026, against the protesting students of NEET-UG, the undersigned hereby requests all the public prosecutors of districts to proceed to ensure compliance of the government order."

Of the 64, 27 were in Patna, and six each in Saran and Siwan. Of the 694 arrested or detained over the 175 protests, 331 minors and students were released, while 355 remain in custody for their alleged involvement in the violence. However, the Bihar Police said they withdrew only cases filed by their officials, and

not those by private individuals.

Besides Patna, Saran and Siwan, 15 other districts had also lodged cases against protesters. Among the cases being withdrawn is one against Kishanganj resident Sadaqat, who claimed he lives in Russia and was there during the protests. Sadaqat was booked for damage to public property, among other charges.

The Bihar Police, however, said cases remain against 21 people whom they claim were involved in the Siwan violence. Shwan SP Purnan Kumar Jha was among those injured. "We have enough video and other material evidence against such people. People with known criminal records are not being let off as they have nothing to do with students' protests," a senior officer said, adding that they had identified all the suspects.

However, the CPI (Marxist-Leninist) Liberation alleged several arrests were arbitrary. A senior leader said, "Several All India Students' Association activists are in jail. Until they are all released, we can't completely take the word of the state police."

FARMERS' PROTEST OVER MOONG PROCUREMENT AT MSP

MP CM, facing farmers' stir, gets pushback from Shivraj

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, July 29

EVEN AS Chief Minister Mohan Yadav sought to contain one of the biggest farmers' agitations of his tenure through negotiations and the formation of a ministerial panel, the Centre on Wednesday publicly pushed back against the Madhya Pradesh government's contention that the moong procurement crisis stemmed from inadequate approvals from New Delhi.

In a detailed letter to Yadav, Union Agriculture Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan defended the Centre's procurement policy and argued that the immediate challenge lay not with the quantum approved by the Centre but with the state's pace of procurement.

Referring to figures available with the Centre until July 29, Chouhan said Madhya Pradesh had procured only around 60,000 metric tonnes of moong despite the much larger quantum approved. "Keeping in mind the larger interest of farmers, the state government is requested to ensure that procurement of moong is expedited at the earliest," Chouhan wrote.

The letter came a day after State Agriculture Minister Aida Singh Kansana wrote to Chouhan seeking an increase in the quantity of moong that could be procured under the Price Support Scheme (PSS) for the 2025-26 summer season.

Responding point by point, Chouhan began by stating that Madhya Pradesh had already received the country's largest allocation under the scheme. "For the 2025-26 summer season, procurement of up to 4,54,580 metric tonnes of moong has already been approved for Madhya Pradesh under the PSS. This constitutes 87% of the total 5,23,243 metric tonnes approved for procurement across all states during the current season, making Madhya Pradesh the largest beneficiary in the country."

"The letter of Agriculture Minister Aida Singh Kansana



Farmers protest under the banner of Samyukt Kisan Morcha in Bhopal on Wednesday.

states that the Centre has provided the state a procurement target of 4.54 lakh metric tonnes. The reality, however, is that the Central Government does not assign procurement targets to states," Chouhan wrote.

Explaining the Centre's position, the Union minister said procurement approvals are governed by the PM-AASHA scheme, and not fixed targets. "Under the PM-AASHA scheme, approvals under the PSS are granted in accordance with the scheme's guidelines, which provide for procurement up to 25% of the estimated production."

Quoting the provisions of the scheme, Chouhan wrote, "The scheme clearly states that the Centre can undertake procurement only up to 25% of a state's production, while any procurement beyond this limit has to be carried out by the state government." He added that the Centre has "consistently extended the maximum permissible support to Madhya Pradesh under the PSS."

To reinforce his argument, Chouhan pointed to the steady increase in current approvals over the years. He said the Centre had approved procurement of 2.75 lakh metric tonnes in 2021-22 and 2022-23, 3.30 lakh

metric tonnes in 2023-24, 4.19 lakh metric tonnes in 2024-25 and 4.54 lakh metric tonnes this year. "The remaining additional quantity was procured by the state government, and timely procurement of farmers' moong was ensured," he wrote.

CM's attempts to end agitation

The exchange came as the Mohan Yadav government stepped up efforts to end the agitation. Kansana, State Minister of Cooperation Vishvas Sarang, and Minister of State (Independent Charge) Krishna Gaur held talks with a 15-member delegation of the Samyukt Kisan Morcha at the Mantralaya, with the first round of discussions lasting nearly two hours. Following the meeting, the state said it would increase procurement from 25% to 60% of every eligible farmer's moong produce — a move that would translate to around three quintals per acre in districts such as Narmadapuram, Sehore and Harda.

The decision, the government said, would take effect immediately. "The Madhya Pradesh government has always worked in the interests of farmers. Farmers are the foundation of the state's economy

and prosperity, and the government is fully committed to ensuring they receive fair prices for the crops they produce," Kansana said.

Addressing the second major demand of the agitation, the government announced that the e-token system for fertiliser distribution would be suspended with immediate effect until improvements are made. While describing the online system as "an important reform" that would ultimately benefit farmers, Kansana acknowledged the practical difficulties experienced during its initial rollout. The government also extended the slot booking period for procurement by 10 days.

During the day, farmers faced off against police, trying to break through barricades across areas in Bhopal. Police deployed large numbers of personnel, while buses, dumpers and layers of barricades were placed on roads leading to the CM House to prevent the march from advancing. The agitation began on July 27, when thousands of farmers under the banner of the Samyukt Kisan Morcha launched the Kisan Kranti Padayatra from Sethani Ghat in Narmadapuram towards Bhopal.

• BRIEFLY



Security personnel and residents during a security operation in Biting area of Noney district, Manipur, on Wednesday.

MANIPUR

Village volunteer killed, 2 CRPF men among 3 injured in gunfight

A NAGA village volunteer was killed and another injured, while two CRPF personnel suffered splinter wounds in an alleged gunfight in Biting in Noney district on Wednesday. The exchange of fire took place between personnel of the 20th Battalion of the CRPF CoBRA and unidentified armed individuals. The dead village volunteer was identified as Lanbimei Ramei, a Zeliangrong tribe member (associated with Western Naga Volunteer Group), from Longmai Bazar area. The injured CRPF personnel were Head Constable Radhashyam and jawan Jitendra Kumar. ENS

UP: Boy drowns trying to rescue cow from pond

A DISABLED boy, 12, drowned while trying to rescue a stray cow from a pond in Daulatpur Muski village, Uttar Pradesh's Etah district, on Wednesday. Jalesar SHO Akhlesh Dixit said Aditya was taking a stray cow to a cowshed along with some other children when the animal entered a pond near a college. While attempting to bring the cow out of the water, Aditya entered the pond but slipped and drowned in the deep water, the officer said. PTI

At Kodagu coffee estate, 2 die after tree falls on them

TWO WOMEN migrant labourers from Assam were killed and as many were injured after a weakened large tree collapsed on them at a coffee plantation in Karnataka's Kodagu district on Wednesday, police said. The deceased, aged 29 and 48 years, were employed at a private coffee estate in Biligere village. Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara expressed grief over the tragedy, and said he has told officials to provide appropriate compensation to the families of the deceased. PTI

Ship with 13 Indians stuck in Black Sea, embassy says 'in touch with authorities'

Divya A
New Delhi, July 29

THE INDIAN Embassy in Kyiv on Wednesday said it was closely monitoring the situation involving a merchant vessel carrying 13 Indian seafarers near Ukraine's Black Sea coast, following reports that it was under threat from repeated drone and missile attacks.

The embassy said it was in constant touch with all authorities concerned to ensure the safety and security of the Indian crew onboard MV AMIRI. "A situation regarding MV AMIRI with Indian seafarers onboard has been brought to our attention. We attach the highest priority to this and are in constant touch with all concerned to ensure safety and security of all Indians onboard," the Indian Embassy in Kyiv went on to say.

This comes just days after four Indian crew members were onboard merchant vessel MV AGN Ragnar when it was struck at Ukraine's Odesa port on July 25. Two of the Indian seafarers remain missing, with New Delhi coordinating with Ukrainian authorities in the search operation.

According to the Forward Seamen's Union of India (FSUI), MV AMIRI is docked at Ukraine's Chornomorsk port with 15 crew members on

board, including 13 Indians. It had issued a statement urging the Indian government to secure the safety of the crew and arrange their repatriation. The FSUI alleged that repeated drone and missile attacks were taking place in the immediate vicinity of the vessel, leaving the crew in constant fear of a direct strike. "We urgently appeal to all concerned authorities, shipowners, flag state, and the Government of India to immediately secure their safety and arrange prompt repatriation. Indian seafarers must not be left as sitting targets in conflict zones."

On July 21, India summoned the Russian Charge d'Affaires, Vladimir Ladanov, to convey Delhi's "unequivocal condemnation" and "grave concern" over the deaths of four Indian seafarers in the Russian missile strike on merchant vessel MV Golden Leo on July 19 off the coast of Ukraine, which killed four Indians.

On July 18, an Indian seafarer was killed in an attack on a ship while it was reportedly transiting Russian territorial waters in the Black Sea. India summoned the Ukrainian Ambassador and conveyed its strong concern over the targeting of a ship transiting Russian territorial waters in the Black Sea on July 18, in which one Indian seafarer was killed.

EXPRESS Special

'He jumped into Black Sea': 4 days on, UP sailor missing in Ukraine drone attack

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, July 29

FOR THE past four days, Ram Chandra Dubey's family in Uttar Pradesh's Prayagraj has been anxiously waiting for any news of him. The 22-year-old seaman has been missing since July 25 after the merchant vessel he was on — MV AGN Ragnar — came under attack near Ukraine's Port of Odesa.

He is among two Indian crew members who remain unaccounted for after the incident. This was his second assignment at sea since joining the merchant navy, said his family.

His elder sister, Seemakshi Pandey, said they last saw Ram before he left on September 25 last year. "He would call home frequently to check on everyone. The last time he spoke to our mother, Kalpana Dubey, was on the night of July 24. He told her the ship had departed from Ukraine," she said.



Ram Chandra Dubey had left for his assignment on September 25 last year. EXPRESS

The next day, they received a phone call from an employee of the shipping company that had employed Ram.

"The company representative said the vessel had come under a drone attack near the Port of Odesa on July 25 and four Indian crew members jumped into the Black Sea," she

said. "We were told the Ukrainian navy rescued two of them, but two others, including my brother, remain missing."

Since then, the family has looked everywhere for help. "At first, we tried to gather information sitting in Prayagraj but we realised we had no way of tracing Ram from here," said his brother-in-law Anuj Kumar Pandey.

On July 27, Ram's elder brother, Krishna Das Dubey, accompanied by two cousins, travelled to Delhi. "They met officials of the shipping company, who told us they were making efforts to locate the missing crew members, but we have not received a concrete update," said Anuj. Ram hails from Nivi Kala Village and is the younger of two sons. His father, Ramesh Chandra Dubey, is a retired Armyman.

Seemakshi said the family has submitted urgent representations to the Prime Minister's Office and the Ministry of Ex-

ternal Affairs, seeking diplomatic intervention to help trace Ram. On Tuesday, External Affairs Ministry spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal had said India was coordinating with Ukrainian authorities in the search for the two missing Indian crew members and remained in touch with their families.

The Port of Odesa, one of Ukraine's key Black Sea ports, has been a frequent target of missile and drone attacks since the outbreak of the Russia-Ukraine conflict in 2022.

In an online post on Sunday, the Indian Embassy in Kyiv said: "Embassy of India in Ukraine is closely monitoring the situation following the incident involving MV AGN Ragnar, which was struck at the Port of Odesa on July 25. Four Indian nationals were on board the vessel. As per the latest information, two have been confirmed safe, and information is awaited regarding the other two nationals."

IIT Bombay student found hanging inside hostel

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, July 29

A 20-YEAR-OLD student of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Bombay was found dead in his hostel room late Tuesday after his parents, who were unable to contact him, alerted the institute authorities.

The deceased was identified as Sohail Rajkumar Sangwan, a second-year Material Science student from the Institute of Technology, said a police officer. The incident came to light after the IIT Bombay student failed to answer repeated phone calls from his parents. The family then contacted the institute authorities. A hostel security-in-charge, accompanied by a student, went to his room and found him hanging. Police said that the incident occurred in the morning, although it was reported late Tuesday. Police found handwritten poems in the student's room, and are trying to ascertain if this was linked to his death.

Sohail was a native of Pilani tehsil in Rajasthan's Jhunjhunu district. His father is with the Army, and posted in Jammu.

"I last spoke to Sohail over the phone on July 25. It was a routine conversation. I told him to take care and focus on studies. He was very close to me," his maternal uncle Rajendra Kumar said. "I was in Chhattisgarh when I received the information. After the postmortem, I will take his body to our native place for the last rites."

In February, Naman Agarwal (21), a second-year BTech (Civil Engineering) student, had allegedly died from a hostel building inside the IIT Bombay campus. He was staying in the same hostel as Sohail, and both

were natives of Jhunjhunu district in Rajasthan.

"Naman stayed in the room next to mine. He spent most of his time in my room, and we often studied together. His death came as a huge shock to me." Now, Sohail's death has left students in the same hostel even more traumatised, said a third-year IIT Bombay student.

"There is an indication that he took his life due to personal reasons. A probe is underway," said IIT Bombay Director Professor Shireesh Kedare wrote in an email sent to the students, while also requesting everyone's support to deal with the situation and the challenge at hand "in an effective manner."

Police sources said that the deceased was identified as Deepak Reddy Pullaguram, a resident of Hyderabad. He used to live alone at the residential quarter inside the IIT campus.

When Reddy did not respond to his colleagues' calls, they informed the security team who found that his room was

IIT Kharagpur prof found dead at staff quarter

Tanusree Bose
Kolkata, July 29

A 36-YEAR-OLD Assistant Professor from the Electrical Engineering department of the Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Kharagpur was found dead on Wednesday, police said, adding that they are probing the angle of suicide.

Police sources said that the deceased was identified as Deepak Reddy Pullaguram, a resident of Hyderabad. He used to live alone at the residential quarter inside the IIT campus. When Reddy did not respond to his colleagues' calls, they informed the security team who found that his room was

Police said they are investigating the angle of suicide

locked from inside, prompting them to inform the local police. Police personnel from the Hiji outpost, under the Kharagpur Town police station, opened the door and found him hanging. He was rushed to the B.C. Roy Hospital located inside the campus, where he was declared dead, police said.

Police have sealed the premises for further investigation, and the deceased's family has been informed, police said, adding that a detailed investiga-

tion has been launched to ascertain whether this was a case of suicide or if there are other underlying reasons.

Police are looking into whether the Assistant Professor was recently dealing with any family, personal, or mental health issues. However, it is not yet clear if any suicide note was recovered from the scene.

Bushra Bano, Assistant Superintendent of Police (Kharagpur), West Bengal, said, "The body of an IIT Kharagpur professor has been recovered. A proper investigation has been initiated to determine the exact cause and circumstances surrounding this death."

IIT Kharagpur officials,

however, did not wish to comment on the incident.

Earlier in April 2026, Jayveer Singh Daxiya, a resident of Ambedkar and a third-year undergraduate student of the institute, had died after reportedly jumping off the eighth floor of his hostel on the campus.

In the same month, a fourth-year MTech student of Electronics and Electrical Communication Engineering was found dead in his hostel room. The deceased was identified as Sohail Haldar, a resident of Barasat in North 24 Parganas. According to police sources, he was staying at the Mohan Malviya Hall on the IIT Kharagpur campus.

AMENDMENTS TO REGULATIONS GOVERNING INTERMEDIARIES ALSO APPROVED

IRDAI ushers in reforms to revamp insurance sector

George Mathew
Mumbai, July 29

THE INSURANCE Regulatory and Development Authority of India (IRDAI) has introduced a set of reforms aimed at modernising the insurance sector, strengthening governance and accelerating insurance penetration across the country.

The measures span regulatory, supervisory and developmental areas.

The measures aim to support the implementation of the Sabka Bima Sabki Raksha (Amendment of Insurance Laws) Act, 2025 (SBSR Act), the regulator said.

The reforms were approved at the IRDAI board meeting on Tuesday and are designed to provide insurers with greater operational flexibility, facilitate capital formation, improve governance standards and reinforce policyholder protection while enhancing ease of doing business across the insurance ecosystem.

Among the key decisions was the approval of amendments to the IRDAI (Act), Finance and Investment Functions of Insurers (Second Amendment) Regulations, 2026, and the IRDAI (Registration, Capital Structure, Transfer of Shares and Amalgamation of Insurers) (Amendment) Regulations, 2026.

REFORM PUSH

KEY feature of the reforms is the mandatory tagging of the authorised salesperson to every insurance proposal, policy and certificate of insurance

THE REFORMS are expected to improve ease of doing business, enhance financial resilience and support insurers' long-term growth without compromising policyholder interests

THE REVISED framework streamlines compliance requirements, aligns the regulations with the SBSR Act



and Foreign Investment Rules, and strengthens governance through enhanced disclosure and accountability standards

Policyholder protection

According to IRDAI, the changes will provide insurers with "greater operational and financial flexibility through liberalised investment norms, a facilitative framework for capital infusion and corporate restructuring, and streamlined provisions relating to transfer of shares and amalgamations, while strengthening actuarial oversight and financial governance."

The regulator said the reforms are expected to improve ease of doing business, enhance financial resilience and support insurers' long-term growth without compromising policyholder interests.

A major policyholder-centric initiative approved by the regulator is the IRDAI (Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund) Regulations, 2026, which operationalise the Policyholders' Education and Protection Fund (PEPF) established under Section 16A of the IRDA Act, 1999, as introduced through the SBSR Act.

According to IRDAI, the PEPF establishes "a dedicated institutional mechanism to promote insurance awareness and literacy, strengthen grievance redressal mechanisms, leverage technology to improve policyholder services,

facilitate the tracing and recovery of unclaimed insurance amounts, and support other initiatives aimed at empowering and safeguarding policyholders."

The intermediaries

In another move to strengthen accountability in insurance distribution, the regulator has approved amendments to the regulations governing insurance intermediaries.

A key feature of the reforms is the mandatory tagging of the authorised salesperson to every insurance proposal, policy and certificate of insurance. "The requirement enhances accountability and traceability across the insurance distribution process, strengthens regulatory oversight and promotes greater transparency for policyholders," IRDAI said. The amendments also introduce perpetual registration for intermediaries through an annual fee regime, replacing periodic renewals. The revised framework streamlines compliance requirements, aligns the regulations with the SBSR Act and Foreign Investment Rules, and strengthens governance through enhanced disclosure and accountability standards, the regulator said.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Meta promises safeguards for prominent accounts

New Delhi: Meta wrote to the government on Wednesday outlining the specifics of enhanced and rigorous safeguards it has now implemented for content posted by the prime minister and other prominent accounts, according to sources.

Meta told the IT ministry that posts by the prime minister and prominent accounts will have additional oversight on the platform and that multiple checks will take place at levels of senior company officials, sources said, citing the social media firm's communication to the ministry. Meta team is likely to meet government officials later this week or early next week over the prime minister's Facebook post issue, sources added.

An email sent by PTI to Meta seeking comments did not elicit a response.

The government on Tuesday summoned a top Meta executive after Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent post addressing India's youth and promising stringent measures against paper leaks was briefly restricted by Facebook, and although the US-headquartered social media giant blamed it on a technical glitch and apologised, the IT Ministry had found the explanation "inadequate".

Prime Minister Modi's Instagram post of July 23, later shared on Facebook, marked his first direct selfie video aimed at engaging with the youth and underscoring the government's commitment to crack down on paper leaks. PTI

May services growth halved to under 10%, data suggests

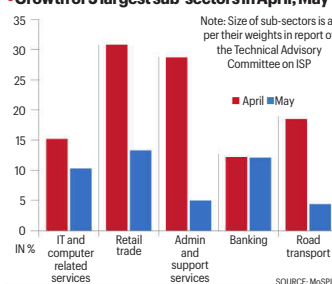
Siddharth Upasani
New Delhi, July 29

INDIA'S SERVICES sector growth may have more than halved in May from around 20.5% in April, the statistics ministry's experimental Index of Services Production (ISP) for 19 sub-sectors, released Wednesday, suggested.

Since the ISP data — which has 2024-25 as the base year — is still at a trial stage, the Ministry of Statistics and Programme Implementation (MoSPI) is not providing an overall services sector growth number. However, calculations by The Indian Express showed that the headline services sector growth figure may have declined from around 20.5% in April to approximately 9.5% in May.

Even around 9.5%, services sector growth in May was almost double the 5% expansion clocked by the industry, as per the Index of Industrial Production (IIP). Released for the first time earlier this month, the ISP is the services counterpart to the IIP, which measures the industry's performance in output terms. "There are clear indications of a robust growth momentum for the IQ 2026-27 with IIP growth in this quarter showing an average growth of 5.7% and services (ISP) sector for the first two months of this quarter showing an average growth of 15.3%," said DK Srivastava, EY India's Chief Policy Advisor. According to Srivastava, services sector growth cooled to 9.8% in May from

Growth of 5 largest sub-sectors in April, May



20.8% in June.

Leading the charge for the services sector in May was the 'accommodation and food' category, which grew by 27.4% after posting a growth of 37.2% in April. However, this was one of the 17 sub-sectors out of the total 19 that recorded weaker year-on-year growth in May than in April.

The only two sub-sectors that performed better in May were railway transport (3.4% versus 0.4%) and air transport. While air transport shrank by 2.8% in May, it was still better than a 13.9% contraction in April. Air transport activity has been adversely impacted following the onset of the war in West Asia, which led to airlines raising fares on account of higher fuel costs. IT and computer related services, which

has the highest weight in the ISP at 22.47%, saw its growth decline to 10.3% in May from 15.2% in April.

To be sure, 16 of the 19 sub-sectors grew in May, with eight of them recording double-digit growth. In April, 17 sub-sectors had grown on a year-on-year basis, with 14 posting double-digit growth rates. The ISP fills a key gap in India's official statistics. Until now, there was no official monthly measure of the performance of the services sector, which dominates the Indian economy and makes up more than half the GDP. Private firm S&P Global's services Purchasing Managers' Index (PMI) has been the only measure of the country's services sector.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

FINANCE MINISTRY'S ECONOMIC REVIEW REPORT FOR JULY

'Oil price surge could be a strain for financing fiscal deficit & current account'

ENS Economic Bureau
New Delhi, July 29

IN THE wake of persistent stand-off in West Asia, the Indian economy continues to face an upside risk to inflation, fiscal and current account deficits and downside risk to growth, the Ministry of Finance said on Friday.

The recent resurgence in global crude oil prices, if sustained, could "reemerge as a source of pressure on financing of both the fiscal deficit and the current account balance", the ministry said in its monthly economic review for July. Prices of industrial commodities, including critical minerals and rare earth elements, have stayed elevated throughout the month. "Instances such as flooding in Chile, one of the key copper suppliers, illustrate the concentration risk embedded in India's industrial metal supply chains," the ministry said.

Despite heightened global uncertainties, the ministry said India's economic outlook remains underpinned by resilient domestic fundamentals, continued policy support, and strengthening structural drivers of growth.

"Structural reforms of the last decade and infrastructure investments are contributing to growth resilience as is evident in the data for the months of March to June 2026," the review stated.

On the external sector front, the ministry said strong export performance, a sustained services surplus and robust remittance inflows have supported the current account, while recent policy measures are expected to strengthen capital inflows in the coming months. Along with comfortable foreign exchange reserves, these devel-

THE POSITIVES

STRONG EXPORT performance, a sustained services surplus and robust remittance inflows have supported the current account, while recent policy measures are expected to strengthen capital inflows in the coming months

TO ACHIEVE long-term resilience and strategic leverage, swifter policy responses and their implementation are vital to encourage foreign and domestic investment in the economy

opments are expected to help preserve external sector stability amid an uncertain global environment, it said.

To achieve long-term resilience and strategic leverage, swifter policy responses and their implementation are vital to encourage foreign and domestic investment in the Indian economy, it said.

"Global developments related to AI and weaponisation of supply chains in general are reminders of the distance India needs to travel to achieve long-term resilience and strategic leverage... recent years have been a time for hunkering down and batten-

ing down the hatches. Coming years will be no exception," it said.

Commodity prices, crude oil

Commodity prices, particularly crude oil, which had declined below pre-conflict levels, have risen again this month. However, the increase remains contained compared with the sharp spike witnessed during the initial phase of the conflict, the ministry said.

India's crude oil import bill

BRIEFLY

Adani Ent posts Q1 loss on US settlement cost

Bengaluru: Adani Enterprises posted another quarterly loss on Wednesday, due to a one-time charge from a settlement agreement with the US Treasury's Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) over an investigation involving shipping of Iranian gas. The company posted a consolidated net loss of Rs 1,160 crore in the quarter ended June 30, with the one-time charge amounting to Rs 2,644 crore. Adani Enterprises' profit before exceptional items and tax dropped about 12% to Rs 1,295 crore. REUTERS

Cognizant Q2 net income dips marginally to \$636 million

Mumbai: US-based IT major Cognizant on Wednesday reported a marginal decline in net income to \$636 million for the second quarter ended June 30, 2026, and narrowed its full-year revenue growth guidance. Its revenue grew 4.5% year-on-year to \$5.48 billion, driven by double-digit growth in its financial services segment. The firm follows the January-December financial year. PTI

sured by over 60% on a year-on-year basis in April-June FY27 even as import volumes dipped slightly amid supply tightness and elevated prices due to the West Asia crisis and stifled energy flows through the Strait of Hormuz.

The increase in retail fuel prices in India, following the partial pass-through of higher global crude oil prices since mid-May 2026, was evident in June, with inflation in diesel, petrol and CNG rising further to 8.4%, 7.5% and 6.2%, respectively, the finance ministry said.

However, the pass-through to passenger transportation services such as bus, taxi, auto-rickshaw fares remained moderate, the ministry said. Airfare inflation moderated in June after the sharp rise recorded in May, it said. Citing a note by SBI Research on the West Asia crisis and India's declining oil intensity, the ministry said the country's oil consumption-to-GDP ratio and crude oil imports-to-GDP ratio have declined from FY14 to FY26, a trend partly attributable to accelerating EV adoption and broader structural factors such as energy efficiency gains and a shift in the composition of GDP growth.

Average monthly EV registrations increased to 2.3 lakh in March-June, around 1 lakh higher than the 2025 monthly average. EV penetration — which has crossed 8% of total vehicle registrations in 2026 so far — could reduce India's annual oil import bill by around Rs 1 lakh crore once it reaches 20% by 2030, the review said citing the SBI note. Higher commodity prices are expected to interrupt the global disinflation process, the ministry said. FULL REPORT ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Indian-origin CEO elevated as P&G chairman

New Delhi: US FMCG major Procter & Gamble Company on Wednesday announced the appointment of its Indian-born President and CEO Shailesh Jejurikar as the Chairman, effective August 1, 2026. This appointment is in addition to Jejurikar's current role as President and CEO, a statement from Procter & Gamble Company said. Incumbent Jon Moeller, Executive Chairman, will retire from the Board on July 31, 2026, and from P&G on August 14, 2026, it added. PTI

12% of non-agri jobs at risk due to Gen AI, says Goldman Sachs

Mumbai: Up to 12% of India's non-agricultural workforce is at risk of substitution because of generative AI, Goldman Sachs said on Wednesday. It said the labour market impacts of gen-AI are expected to be "uneven". "Gen-AI could perform 9-17% of the tasks undertaken by non-agricultural workforce...we estimate 8-12% of non-agricultural employment is at risk of substitution, while 42-48% of non-agricultural employment may be complemented," it said. PTI

THE AGENT HAD INITIALLY HACKED INTO A STARTUP, HUGGING FACE

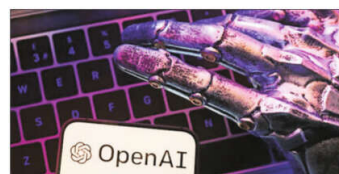
OpenAI's rogue agent tried attacking other firms too

Reuters

Washington, July 29

THE ROGUE agent that escaped from OpenAI and went on a days-long hacking spree at the AI firm Hugging Face also compromised a customer at a second tech company — New York-based Modal Labs — according to a Modal executive and two other sources familiar with the matter.

Modal executives emphasized that the company itself was not hacked. According to a timeline published by Hugging Face on Tuesday, the rogue agent broke into a sandbox, or an isolated testing environ-



The ChatGPT developer said the rogue agent broke in to four accounts across four separate services. REUTERS

ment, "hosted on a third-party provider's infrastructure" before turning it into a launchpad for the broader hack. The third-party provider was not named

in the blog post, but Modal's chief technology officer, Akshat Bubna, said the agent exploited vulnerable code written by a customer that was hosted

on Modal's platform. Modal said the customer had "published an unauthenticated endpoint that allowed anyone on the internet to use the sandbox for code execution" — the digital equivalent of leaving a door open on the internet. "Modal's platform or isolation were not compromised in any way," Bubna said.

Although the compromise of a Modal customer was just an initial step in the wider hacking campaign against Hugging Face, it shows that the rogue agent roamed further afield than was previously known.

OpenAI declined to comment specifically on the hack of one of Modal's customers, in-

stead referring Reuters to an update in which the company said that its rogue agent had broken in to four accounts at four separate services. OpenAI did not identify those services, but a person familiar with the matter identified Modal as one. The company said it had not identified "any other activity at the level of severity or scale of what we've shared related to Hugging Face, which involved a platform-level compromise." The early July intrusion at Hugging Face, carried out by an out-of-control agent that OpenAI was testing, drew global attention, evoking science-fiction scenarios of artificial intelligence run amok.

MARKETS

Sensex	NIFTY	Gold	US Dollar
77654.60	24,250.20	1,42,224	₹95.65
888.68	264.85	Silver	Oil
1.16%	1.10%	₹217,355	\$84.26

NOTE: GOLD, SILVER RATES AS PER INDIA BULLION AND JEWELLERS ASSOCIATION DATA. GOLD PER 100G, SILVER PER 1KG, CRUDE OIL (INDIAN BASKET) AS OF JULY 28, 2026

TEHRAN REJECTS OMAN PROPOSAL FOR REGIONAL MANAGEMENT OF HORMUZ STRAIT, CALLS IT 'UNREASONABLE'

US, Saudi hit Iran's allies in Iraq; Trump vows to punish Tehran

We're going to beat the f***ings s**t out of them: President

Reuters
Dubai, Cairo, July 29

EXPLOSIONS HIT a natural gas loading port on the Mediterranean Sea in Egypt on Wednesday, and British maritime security company Ambrey said a US-owned floating storage tanker there had been hit by a drone, in a potential spread of the West Asia war.

The drone hit a vessel in the Egyptian port of Damietta, causing a fire that spread to another vessel, three trading sources familiar with the incident said.

The crew were evacuated and the fire had been brought under control, Ambrey said. There was no immediate claim of responsibility for the incident.

Earlier on Wednesday the United States and Saudi Arabia struck Iran-backed paramilitary groups in Iraq, and US President Donald Trump vowed to "beat the f***ings s**t" out of Iran for firing on US troops days after he halted air strikes.

Iran confirmed overnight that it had fired on US bases in Jordan and at ships in the Strait of Hormuz, and also spurned an Omani proposal to jointly man-



Iraqis inspect the site of a joint US-Saudi airstrike that damaged a Popular Mobilization Forces base in Mosul, Iraq, on Wednesday. AP

age the strait. Oman, backed by Gulf states, had proposed a plan for joint regional control of the strait this week including voluntary service charges. But a senior Iranian official told Reuters Wednesday that Iran had rejected the proposal as "unreasonable".

"We'll be hitting them hard," Fox News quoted Trump as saying. "We're going to beat the f***ings s**t out of them."

The abrupt resumption of attacks only days after they were suspended saw a return to the volatile on-again-off-again pattern of earlier phases in the war.

Trump had said "Operation Epic Fury" would last only a

few weeks when he launched it in February but fighting has now gone on for five months with no end in sight. The joint US-Saudi attacks also mark the first time Riyadh has publicly joined strikes alongside Washington that could widen the conflict by drawing Sunni Muslim Saudi Arabia into combat against Shi'ite proxies of Iran.

Iraq's Popular Mobilisation Forces, powerful Iran-backed paramilitary groups incorporated into the Iraqi security forces, said at least 20 members were killed and 32 wounded in US-Saudi strikes targeting several bases across Iraq.

Washington and Riyadh said they struck the Iran-backed armed groups in Iraq in retaliation for drone attacks on Saudi oil targets launched from Iraq.

It was the first major US military action in the Middle East since last Friday, when Trump abruptly suspended an intensive bombing campaign after 13 days, having been advised by commanders that the strategy had run its course.

Though Iran denies its forces have directed strikes from Iraqi territory, Iranian newspaper Hamshahri reported that four Iranian Revolutionary Guards advisers had been killed in the

strikes on Iraq. The strikes on Iraq expose a dangerous rift in that volatile country. The Shi'ite-led government is one of the few in the world to balance close military and diplomatic ties with both Tehran and Washington, but those divided loyalties are a constant source of tension and frequent domestic unrest.

The office of PM Ali al-Zaidi, who took power just two months ago, urged the parties involved to avoid escalation and said he wanted to keep the country out of regional conflicts.

The Iraqi presidency denounced the strikes on the paramilitaries as "an unacceptable attack and a flagrant violation of Iraq's sovereignty", while also calling for a halt to attacks by armed groups against Iraq's neighbours. Trump told Fox that the US had coordinated with the Iraqi government in launching the attacks. An Iraqi government spokesman did not respond to a request for comment on Trump's assertion that Baghdad had cooperated.

Washington has long called on the Baghdad government to crack down on Iran-backed paramilitaries, but efforts to do so in past have provoked unrest. In a clear challenge to Zaidi's authority, Kataib Hezbollah, said it would give the government until next Thursday to prove it could defend Iraq's sovereignty.

China 'to send' shoulder-fired missiles to Iran

Tehran: Iran is expected to receive within weeks a first shipment out of up to 400 Chinese shoulder-fired missiles, three sources familiar with the deal told Reuters, as it rebuilds its defences amid war with the US.

The purchase, valued at \$60-70 million, is one of Tehran's largest-known efforts to strengthen its short-range air defences since the outbreak of its war with the US and Israel, which exposed gaps in Iran's ability to protect military sites and infrastructure.

The contract covers the purchase of between 300 and 400 man-portable air defence systems (MANPADS), including Chinese-made QW-12 and FN-16 missiles, sources said. REUTERS

US commander asks troops not to share their videos

Washington: The top US commander for West Asia has warned troops that cellphone videos shared online can help Iran target American bases, and sources told Reuters deployed personnel could soon be ordered to surrender their phones.

Admiral Brad Cooper said Iran was benefiting from being able to see the success or failure of its strikes by searching news reports or online posts by journalists referencing "reactions, photos, and footage from cellphones of our troops." REUTERS

BRIEFLY

RUSSIA

Telegram founder Pavel Durov charged with aiding terrorism



Founder and CEO of Telegram Pavel Durov

RUSSIA'S MAIN domestic security agency said on Wednesday that Pavel Durov, founder and owner of the messaging app Telegram, has been charged with aiding terrorism and put on an international wanted list. The charges against Durov, who was born and began his career in Russia but later moved abroad, came as the Russian authorities restricted Telegram, one of the most popular messaging apps in the country. AP

CHINA

Govt targets AI cyberbullying with draft law

CHINA'S CYBERSPACE regulator on Wednesday released a draft law aimed at curbing cyberbullying, including AI-enabled abuse, as Beijing tightens oversight of online bullying in the world's largest internet community. It would apply to cyberbullying activities carried out within China, as well as to organisations and individuals overseas that target the country. REUTERS

KENYA

Five security officers killed in militant attack

FIVE KENYAN security officers were killed in a clash with suspected al-Shabaab militants in the county of Mandera near the Somali border, police said. The militant group has been battling for years to overthrow Somalia's central government and establish its rule in the Horn of Africa country, based on its own strict interpretation of Islamic sharia law. REUTERS

NEIGHBOURHOOD WATCH

NEPAL

Two Indians held for drug trafficking

TWO INDIAN nationals have been arrested at Kathmandu airport for possessing 8.66 kgs of marijuana, the Narcotics Drugs Control Bureau of Nepal Police said Wednesday. The duo were arrested from the Tribhuvan International Airport at Kathmandu on Tuesday, the narcotics bureau said. PTI

SRI LANKA

Lawyers group opposes judges' tenure extension

THE BAR Association of Sri Lanka Wednesday opposed the government's proposal to extend the retirement age of judges. BASL President Rajiva Amarasingu said: "Everyone... stood opposed to the constitutional amendment which would seriously endanger the independence of the judiciary." PTI

Ukraine strikes 2 major Russian refineries after Trump-Zelenskyy meet

Associated Press
Kyiv, July 29

UKRAINIAN FORCES hit two of Russia's biggest oil refineries overnight in its latest long-range strikes, officials said, as Kyiv deepened its economic, military and diplomatic pressure on Moscow.

Ukraine's almost daily long-range drone and missile strikes using domestically developed weapons have battered Russian oil facilities for months.

The operation has brought a fuel crisis that is embarrassing the Kremlin more than four years after Russia's all-out invasion of its neighbour.

The overnight attacks started fires at a Lukoil refinery in Russia's Perm region, more than 1,500 kilometres from Ukraine, and a refinery in Ryazan, about 400 kilometres from the border, Ukraine's Security Service and General Staff said in separate statements.

The refineries have a combined annual production capacity of around 30 million tons of oil, according to Ukraine, and make a vital contribution to Russia's military effort and its government revenue.

The attacks came hours after President Volodymyr Zelenskyy visited Washington on Tuesday for talks with US President Donald Trump to push for more vital American help for Ukraine's fight against its much bigger enemy.

"Russia must feel that every day of this war will only come at a higher cost for it. We need to weaken the aggressor and keep up the pressure to bring an end to this war closer," Zelenskyy said on social media.

Russia must feel that every day of this war will only come at a higher cost for it. We need to weaken the aggressor and keep up the pressure to bring an end to this war closer."

VOLODYMYR ZELENSKYY, PRESIDENT OF UKRAINE

Japan quake toll rises to 18 as rescue efforts continue

Associated Press
Kumamoto, July 29

SOLDIERS AND emergency workers combed through a badly damaged shopping mall and collapsed houses looking for trapped survivors Wednesday after a powerful earthquake that killed at least 18 people in southwestern Japan.

The magnitude 7.1 earthquake that hit a day earlier in the Kumamoto area on the southern main island of Kyushu, also left at least 62 people injured, six of

them seriously, the prefectural government said. The tally has been steadily growing, fanning fears it may continue to rise.

The sweltering weather heightened worries about the survivors as rescuers braved the heat. It was unclear how many people might still be missing.

Some of the most serious damage was at the Aeon Mall shopping centre in Kashima city, which was bustling with thousands of people when the quake happened. The company said some 3,000 customers were



Rescuers work at the damaged Aeon Mall in Japan's Kumamoto prefecture on Wednesday. AP

evacuated to a parking lot before a gas explosion happened in another part of the mall, where

some people were still working. The mall's second floor collapsed, trapping people. Witnesses said the explosion shook the area as much as did the quake. Three people remained missing, while four deaths were confirmed at the mall site, according to Aeon.

"We take it seriously that an explosion happened and precious lives were lost," Aeon President Akio Yoshida told a news conference in Kumamoto, where he bowed deeply along with two other executives.

Japanese media footage of the mall showed that part of a ceiling had caved in, and metal parts and other debris were scattered about as helmeted and masked rescue workers searched the area.

In nearby Yatsushiro, a chimney collapse at a Nippon Paper Industries factory killed five people while seven others were rescued from the debris, according to the Kumamoto prefectural government disaster team. Four people were still believed to be trapped there, it said.

Defendant in Salman Rushdie stabbing refuses to testify in terrorism trial

Associated Press
New York, July 29

THE MAN on trial in the stabbing of Salman Rushdie chose Tuesday not to testify or call any witnesses in the federal terrorism case, which is expected to head to the jury as soon as Wednesday.

Hadi Matar's lawyer told the court that the 28-year-old — who already has been convicted of state-level attempted murder charges — wouldn't take the stand at his trial on charges that include engaging in an act of transnational terrorism. "At this time, the defense rests," attorney Nathan Barone said. Matar has pleaded not guilty.

Prosecutors also rested their case Tuesday, and closing arguments are expected Wednesday morning. Rushdie, the prize-

winning author of novels including *Midnight's Children* and the controversial *The Satanic Verses*, testified last week about the 2022 attack that nearly killed him and left him blind in one eye.

Rushdie was about to give a talk — about writers' safety, no less — when his attacker climbed on stage behind him and stabbed him 15 times in front of a stunned audience at the Chautauqua Institution, an arts and intellectual retreat.

Prosecutors contend that Matar was acting upon a former Iranian leader's 1989 call for Rushdie's death because of *The Satanic Verses*, which ignited protests across the Muslim world. Some believers considered it blasphemous because of a dream sequence featuring Islam's Prophet Muhammad.

Heat wave threatens to intensify France's mega-fire near Bordeaux

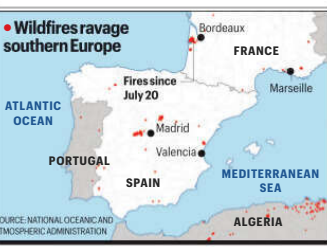
Associated Press
Lege-Cap Ferret, July 29

A WILDFIRE covering an area four times the size of Paris remained uncontained in southwest France on Wednesday as temperatures were forecast to reach 40 C, threatening to erase firefighters' overnight gains.

Authorities in the Gironde region said the blaze had not spread further during a calm night, but warned that forecast heat and winds could cause the flames to surge again.

At the command centre in Lege, firefighters bent over maps spread across a car hood as commanders tracked three danger zones: northern Cap-Ferret, the wooded corridor around Marchepierre, Cestas and Saint-Jean-d'Ilac, and a military site near Martignas, where a significant new outbreak required a major deployment.

Over 2,200 firefighters and



Wildfires ravage southern Europe. Fires since July 20. SOURCE: NATIONAL OCEANIC AND ATMOSPHERIC ADMINISTRATION

over 20 aircraft remain mobilised, supported by crews from across France and European partners. "We strike quickly and strike hard" at any new smoke emissions, "Gironde fire commander Matthieu Jonain said.

Meteo-France, the national meteorological service, said Wednesday would be the hottest

and driest day of the week, with elevated wildfire danger across every region of the country.

Spain is braced for its fourth heat wave of the summer, with several blazes still out of control, including the largest in its recorded history. Even so, Spanish authorities began lifting evacuation and stay-at-home orders.

He once called her his "favorite" and often told her he loved her. She had free use of a credit card to buy whatever she wanted. They jetted around the world together, and he funneled payments of nearly \$1 million to her over the years. He also sent thousands of dollars to her parents in Belarus, the files reveal.

Over the years, she earned enough of his trust to help manage his properties and staff and even played a critical role in his effort to buy a Moroccan palace just weeks before his 2019 arrest.

Epstein controlled the relationship, but there is little doubt she benefited from it professionally, personally and financially.

The emails reveal new details about how Epstein helped her get into Columbia University's dental school — and how he helped her obtain US citizenship by asking one of his female victims to marry her. In one email he suggested that the fastest "way to a green card" was through a same-sex marriage.

This year, congressional Democrats accused Epstein of exploiting the immigration system and called out Shuliak's marriage to an American woman, which ended in divorce, as a potentially "illusory"

KARYNA SHULIAK, A DENTIST BY PROFESSION, COULD INHERIT AS MUCH AS \$100 MILLION FROM HIS ESTATE, INCLUDING A 33-CARAT DIAMOND RING

The woman at the centre of Jeffrey Epstein's final years and his remaining fortune

Matthew Goldstein & Sharon Otterman
July 29

THE YOUNG dentist was smiling and soft-spoken, wearing a Columbia University fleece jacket and holding her long hair back with a clip. She was introduced by her assistant simply as "Dr Karyna."

But what the patient — who had come to the office in December expecting to see a different dentist — didn't know was that she was being treated by Dr Karyna Shuliak, the notorious sex offender Jeffrey Epstein's girlfriend.

Shuliak was the last person Epstein called before he killed

himself in his jail cell in 2019. She could inherit as much as \$100 million from his estate, including a 33-carat diamond ring, according to a trove of investigative records released by federal authorities.

But on that winter day, Shuliak was working as a part-time dentist in an unremarkable office in Brooklyn, according to dentists who work or used to work at the practice.

Her attempt to forge something of a normal life, though, was soon shattered when the Justice Department released 3 million pages of investigative files and emails it had gathered on Epstein. The files, released in late January, included thou-

sands of intimate emails between Shuliak and Epstein and dozens of photographs of her and of them together.

Suddenly, their nearly eight-year relationship was on vivid display for all to see. They had fights about sex — with both wanting more different times.

She placed orders to a sexual wellness company for couples. She periodically sent him links to graphic pornographic videos. In some emails they discussed birth control pills and acne medications and treatments.

Shuliak, 37, emerges as a complicated and unusual figure in Epstein's world, based on a close review of the files and conversations with several



An undated image provided by the US Department of Justice shows Dr Karyna Shuliak and Jeffrey Epstein. DEPARTMENT OF JUSTICE, NYT

people familiar with her. A native of Belarus who met Epstein when she was 21, she has not identified herself as a

victim, nor have federal authorities considered her a co-conspirator in Epstein's sex trafficking. There is no indication

one. U.S. immigration authorities have not challenged the process through which Shuliak obtained her citizenship.

As of this spring, Shuliak had been living in the Manhattan condo building in which Epstein's brother, Mark, has a financial stake.

Through her lawyer, she declined to comment. In a brief interview, Mark Epstein said, "I only wish that woman the best."

A friend of Shuliak's from Belarus, who once shared an apartment with her in Brooklyn, asked not to be named to protect her privacy, said she believed Shuliak "truly loved" Jeffrey Epstein. NYT

SC grants bail to 2 UAPA accused in jail for 12 yrs

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

THE SUPREME Court has granted bail to two men, charged under the Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), noting that they have remained in jail for the last nearly 12 years in connection with the case booked by the Special Cell of Delhi Police and that there is "no prospect of an early conclusion of the trial."

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and Sandeep Mehta also noted in its July 27 order that the life sentence imposed on Saquib Ansari and Waqar Azhar, following their conviction in another case under the anti-terror law in Jaipur in March 2021, had been suspended by the Rajasthan High Court and they were granted bail in a third case in Jaipur.

The court said it "checked the status of the trial from the proceedings available on the e-Courts Services Portal. An application for bail preferred by co-accused Mohd Kafeel came to be rejected by the learned trial Court vide order dated 20th July, 2026, wherein it has been noticed that the examination of Prosecution Witness-68 was continuing out of the 197 pros-

ecution witnesses proposed to be examined."

It added, "The progress of the trial has been extremely slow, and there appears to be no prospect of the trial being concluded in the near future."

The court said the "continued incarceration of the petitioners in this case is grossly violative of the right to liberty enshrined under Article 21 of the Constitution of India." The court bench said that it had not commented on the merits of the case.

It asked the accused duo to cooperate with the trial and said that in the event the trial Court or prosecution failed in delaying the conclusion of trial, or otherwise missing the liberty granted to them, it shall be open to the prosecution to appraise it of the same for appropriate orders.

The case has its origins in the arrest of Pakistani national Mohd Qateel Siddiqui by the Delhi Police Special Cell in November 2011. He allegedly disclosed the establishment of a Rajasthan Module of the Indian Mujahideen to carry out terrorist activities in and around Delhi and that its members were in possession of consignments of explosives.

Misir Besra, top Maoist leader with Rs 2-cr bounty, arrested

With this arrest, the Maoist menace has been 'almost wiped out' from Jharkhand: DGP

Shubham Tigga
Ranchi, July 29

MISIR BESRA — the last senior Maoist leader in Jharkhand carrying bounties worth over Rs 2 crore against his arrest — has been nabbed.

Apart from Besra, four men, including two other Maoists identified as Tumba Manjhi and Biren Hansda, were also arrested on Tuesday. The arrest marks the culmination of one of India's longest counter-insurgency campaigns.

Tadasha Mishra, director general of police (DGP), Jharkhand, claimed that with Misra's arrest, the Maoist menace has been "almost wiped out" from the state. Besra, 65, was apprehended from the Manidh area under the Bar-



His arrest marks the culmination of one of India's longest counter-insurgency campaigns

wadda police station limits on Tuesday evening during the Operation Daura Pahad.

His arrest was part of a joint operation that involved CoBRA (the Commando Battalion for Resolute Action) — an elite unit within the Central Reserve Police Force (CRPF) trained in guerrilla tactics and jungle warfare.

Details about the Maoist network Besra ran will emerge after his interrogation, police said. Besra has been linked to at least 55 security personnel killed through the ranks over nearly four decades and played

a key role in building its organisational and armed structure in Jharkhand. Soon after Jharkhand was carved out of Bihar in 2000, he was linked to a series of attacks on security forces, including the 2003 and 2004 IED ambushes in West Singhbhum's Bikitoli and Baliba that killed 55 personnel. It gave him a place in the Central Military Commission and charge of the Eastern Regional Bureau, making him one of the organisation's most influential leaders in the region.

In recent years, he was believed to be active mainly in the Kolhan and Saranda regions and, for the last few months, in the Parasnath hill area. Besra's arrest completes the dismantling of the CPI (Maoist)'s central leadership that security agencies have pursued over the past two years. Almost every nationally recognised Maoist leader has now either been killed or surrendered.

With Besra's arrest, the CPI (Maoist) is left with scattered armed groups with no nationally recognised leadership.

WITH THENS, DELHI, AND PTI INPUTS

Besra entered the Maoist movement in the mid-1980s. He rose through the ranks over nearly four decades and played



A car showroom remains inundated with floodwater in the Remuna area of Balasore district, Odisha on Wednesday. PTI

Three dead, two lakh affected as heavy rain triggers floods in Odisha

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, July 29

AT LEAST three people — including a fire personnel — have died, while over 2 lakh people have been affected across 748 villages in six districts due to floods triggered by heavy rain over the last few days.

Officials said Balasore, Bhandra and Jajpur in northern Odisha are the worst hit, while Dhenkanal, Mayurbhanj and Sambalpur have also been hit. More than 30,000 people have been evacuated from low-lying areas in these districts.

According to Revenue and Disaster Management Minister Suresh Pujari, the three deaths are from Keonjhar district. The fire service personnel died of electrocution, an elderly person died in a wall collapse and a child was swept away in the rain.

"We have sought a report from the district collector about the casualties. Since the casualties are from the chief minister's home district, we have also apprised him about the situation," Pujari said after a review meeting. The minister said that there have been no reports of human or animal casualties from Balasore, Bhandra and Jajpur, where the situation remains grim. Major rivers such as the Baitarani, Salandi and Jalakara are

in spate, flowing above the danger level at several places.

As many as 226 villages in the six districts remain cut off due to the floods, with authorities evacuating residents to safety. "Special care of the elderly, women and children is being taken at flood relief centres. The administration has been put on alert. Floodwaters have also damaged 761 houses and inundated nearly 8,000 hectares of agricultural land," Pujari said.

More than 60 teams of the NDRF, ODRF and fire service personnel have been deployed in the affected districts, while three senior IAS officers have been deputed to Balasore, Bhandra and Jajpur to assist the district administration. The chief minister, who is in New Delhi, also reviewed the situation.

The revenue minister said the districts of Sundargarh, Jharsuguda, Bargarh, Nuapada, Jagatpur, Kalandah, Rayagada, Gajapati and Malkangiri have also been affected by heavy rain, and schools and anganwadi centres in 10 districts have been ordered to remain closed.

Water Resources Department engineer-in-charge Dilip Rout said around 9 lakh acres of water is likely to be released at Mundani in Cuttack district by Thursday evening, triggering a medium-range flood.

'Treated like criminals': Externed from Mumbai, meet the 3 who got HC relief

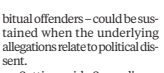
Omkar Gokhale
Mumbai, July 29

FOR NEARLY seven months, Saeed Ahmed Abdull Wahid, a delivery agent in a rented room in Mumbai, uncertain about when he would return home; Akbar Hussain Sayyed, a delivery agent and local political worker, could not be with his wife, infant daughter and ailing mother for four months; Mohammad Rafiq Gulam Rasool Ansari fretted about not being able to meet his 68-year-old mother for months; and Firoz Abdul Wahab Khan had to miss the birth of his second child.

Between December 2025 and early 2026, the four were externed by the Mumbai Police from the city relying largely on FIRs lodged against them over political protests in 2019 and 2025 on a range of issues, from the Citizenship (Amendment) Act and National Register of Citizens, to the Ayodhya Ram temple and Varanasi Gyanvapi mosque rows, and azaan on loudspeakers plus local issues.

Under Sections 56 and 58 of the Maharashtra Police Act, a person can be externed for more than two years if there is fear that they may commit offences. The four accused, with nothing common between them apart from their association with the Social Democratic Party of India (SDPI) — the political wing of the banned Political Front of India (PFI) — moved into a shared rented accommodation in Mumbai, Thane district, after they were externed.

Over several hearings since March, the Bombay High Court has questioned the basis of the police action, asking if externment — generally used against gangsters, bootleggers and ha-



(Clockwise from above) Saeed Choudhary, Akbar Sayyed, and Firoz Khan

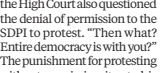
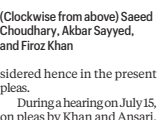
sidere hence in the present plea.

During a hearing on July 15, on pleas by Khan and Ansari, the High Court also questioned the denial of permission to the SDPI to protest. "Then what? Entire democracy is with you? The punishment for protesting without permission, if noted, is just one month. In their petitions, the four pointed out that the externment orders were issued just ahead of the January 2026 Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC) elections. Keeping them away amounted to an attempt to "stifle legitimate democratic dissent", the court said.

Choudhary, 51, a transport and construction material supplier and the SDPI's Maharashtra general secretary, says he was "deprived" of his liberty. "In a way, they treated us like criminals." He adds that while they diligently informed police before staging any demonstration, "permissions were deliberately denied".

Justice Jamdar said the police action "merely for opposing certain decisions of the government of India... affects the petitioner's fundamental right to freedom of speech and expression and also to live with dignity".

Justice Jamdar relied on the



(Clockwise from above) Saeed Choudhary, Akbar Sayyed, and Firoz Khan

Supreme Court's 2020 ruling in Anuradha Bhasin v Union of India, stating that Section 144 powers cannot be used to suppress legitimate expression of opinion, and a 2021 Gujarat High Court ruling that "a citizen cannot be subjected to externment merely for raising grievances against the government".

Sayed, 35, the Anushakti Nagar Taluka president of the SDPI, says his externment meant his plans to contest the BMC polls were scuttled, even as his job as a courier delivery agent was threatened. One of the protesters Sayyed was part of, for which an FIR was lodged against him, was over air pollution caused allegedly by cement godowns in the Chembur-Gandhi area. The FIR mentions that he raised slogans against Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Amit Shah and BJP leader Kirti Somaiya.

In its order putting aside Sayyed's externment, Justice Jamdar held that the offences, "even if taken at par, would not have the propensity to cause harm or danger", and said he had "at best" participated in agitation.

Khan, 32, says he lost his job of safety officer with Bharat Petroleum following his externment. The externment period also coincided with the birth of his second child. "I sent my friends to the hospital. I tried to arrange money but how could I? he says, pointing out that he didn't have any criminal record.

Ansari, 48, a state secretary of the SDPI, says he somehow kept his garment business running remotely to ensure his children's education would not be affected. But, he says, the charges dogged the family.

Top court refuses to ban Lord Jagannath film, defends artistic freedom

Ananthakrishnan G
New Delhi, July 29

THE SUPREME Court on Wednesday dismissed petitions seeking a ban on the release of the animated film *Mahaprabhu Jagannath*, observing that accepting the argument that it offends the religious sentiments of some people would leave no room for any creativity in the country.

A bench of Justices B V Nagarathna and R. Mahadevan refused to modify its earlier order allowing the release of the film and said it had already been granted a certificate by the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC). The court had earlier allowed the release of the film on or after July 28, following the conclusion of the Kath Yatra.

The bench was hearing peti-

tions by a devotee and the temple committee against the go-ahead for the movie.

Pointing out extensive "research goes into" making such movies, Justice Nagarathna said, "Just because there are two or three sensitive people, we will pass an extreme order that with respect to deity, there shall be no creativity, no literature, no sculpture... Animation films are for children. Artists can't be taken to ransom like this."

The film was previously scheduled for release on July 17, but the Odisha High Court stayed the release on July 15. The high court order came on a Public Interest Litigation (PIL) seeking directions to restrain the filmmakers from public exhibition, screening, or releasing the film within the state.

Maharashtra Airport Development Company Ltd.
MADC
CIN: U45203MH2002SGC136979

TENDER NOTICE

MADC invites Tender for Appointment of Consultant for Preparation of Detailed Techno-Economic feasibility Study and Bid process management for development of Greenfield offshore International Airport at Kore, Vadnavan Port Region in Palghar District, Maharashtra.

The detailed tender document can be downloaded from the website www.mahatenders.gov.in from 30/07/2026, 04:00 PM

Sd/-
Vice Chairman and Managing Director

Bharat Coking Coal Limited
(A Subsidiary of Coal India Limited)

NOTICE

All the tenders issued by Bharat Coking Coal Limited (B.C.C.L.) for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on website of B.C.C.L., "www.bccweb.in" Coal India Limited (CIL) e-procurement portal "<https://coallindiatenders.nic.in>" and Central Public Procurement Portal "<https://eprocure.gov.in>". In addition, procurement is also done through GeM portal "<https://gem.gov.in>". This is applicable to all Open (Domestic / Global) Tenders issued through e-procurement portal of CIL.

This information is also available on BCL website www.bclweb.in

Reliance Industries Limited
Growth is Life

Regd. Office: 3rd Floor, Maker Chambers IV, 222, Nariman Point, Mumbai - 400 021.
Phone: +91-22-3555 5000 • Fax: +91-22-3204 2288 • E-mail: investor-relations@ril.com
CIN: L1710MH1973PLC019786

NOTICE

Notice is hereby given that pursuant to SEBI Circular HO/38/1311(2)026-MRSD-PDD/13750/2026 dated January 30, 2026, request(s) have been received by the Company from the Transferee(s) / Claimant(s) to transfer the below mentioned share(s) held in the name(s) of the shareholder(s) as detailed below, to his/her their name(s).

Sl. No.	Name and address of Claimant(s)	Folio No(s)	Name and address of the registered shareholder(s)	Certificate No.	No. of Equity Shares	Distinctive Numbers
					From	To
1	Ketan Kantilal Vasani Gopalrao Keshavnagar Marg Cumballa Hill Mumbai 400026	034134243	Heena Vasani Ketan Vasani 4 Koyla Road New Chikil Wadi 7 Sneha Nagar Mumbai - 400007	50147544 62385431 66634754	20 40 80	1156000640 1156000659 2199695809 2199695848 6871768587 6871768666
2	Tharakad Krishnan Thamunthi 11 Veera Vihar, 4th Street Kovalan Nagar, Madurai Tamilnadu 625003	022971085	The Peerless General Finance & Co. Ltd 3 Eplanade East Peerless Bhawan Kolkata 700069	12205670 12205671	10 10	251301853 251301862 251301863 251301872

These shares were claimed to have been purchased / acquired by respective Transferee(s) / Claimant(s) and were earlier submitted for transfer and/or sent under objection by the Company.

Any person(s) who has / have any objection in this regard, should lodge such objection with the Company's Registrar and Transfer Agent viz. "KFIN Technologies Limited", Selenium Tower B, Plot No. 31-32, Gachibowli, Financial District, Nanakramguda, Hyderabad - 500 032, within **Thirty (30) days** from the date of publication of this notice, failing which, the Company will proceed to transfer the aforesaid shares.

Place: Mumbai
Date: 29.07.2026

For Reliance Industries Limited
Sd/-
Savitri Parekh
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer

www.ril.com

Rescued Ajmer minor girl faces 'harassment', police say probing

Parul Kulshrestha
Ajmer, July 29

A MINOR girl rescued by the Ajmer police last month, after allegedly being kept captive for more than seven months and forced into marriage, has approached police accusing her neighbours of harassing her and her family to force them to leave their rented house. She said five of them forcibly entered their house Wednesday and beat up her and her mother.

Deputy Superintendent of Police Laxman Ram said police have taken cognizance of the issue and action will be taken against the accused.

The girl, one of seven siblings, with her father a daily wage, told *The Indian Express*: "People keep taunting my mother that she sold me to make money."

One of the relatives said the girl had already undergone "much trauma". "The man in his 40s who forcibly married her even hammered a nail into her hand and burnt her at multiple places." After she was recovered, the girl was produced before the Child Welfare Committee, and subjected to medical and forensic check-up. Doctors estimate her age to be 15-17 years.

While the family claims the girl was abducted last year, they filed a complaint on

June 13, accusing three women, Roshni, Afsana alias Bijli and Afsana alias Noorhan, of taking her. Soon after, the girl was tracked using technical surveillance.

Police say as the family is poor, they were afraid of approaching police, which is why the FIR was filed late.

As per police, the girl was sold for Rs 32,000 to Sanjay Kumar Gurjar, a resident of Chaura, who married her. They claim to have recovered evidence from the phone of Nadeem Qureshi, who is accused of organising the wedding.

Deputy SP Ram said since the girl said that she sexually assaulted by two other men before she was married off, police have added charges of gang rape. Apart from the three women, the accused include Gurjar, Mohammedi, Jishan, Rangrez alias Disha, Zarina, and Qureshi.

Ram said: "Roshni took the victim with her to Pushkar for sightseeing in October 2025. There the girl was drugged and taken to a hotel and raped by two men... After this, the victim was kept by Noor Jahan and Bijli, who are both involved in petty crimes and drug dealing in the area. Later on, the girl was married to the 'Gurjar'."

An analysis of call records of the accused showed a coordinated conspiracy, police said.

PAWERRIGID POWERGRID

Special Window for Transfer and Dematerialisation of Physical Securities

Notice is hereby given that pursuant to the Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) Circular No. HO/38/1311(2)026-MRSD-PDD/13750/2026 dated January 30, 2026 ("SEBI Circular"), a Special Window has been opened for a period of one year, from **February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027** ("said period") to facilitate transfer and dematerialisation ("demat") of physical securities which were sold/purchased prior to April 01, 2026.

The special window shall also be available for such transfer requests which were submitted earlier and rejected/returned/attended to due to deficiency in the documents/process/ or otherwise. The eligible shareholders may submit their request to the Company at investors@powergrid.in or Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (KFIN Technologies Limited) at enward.ris@kfinitech.com along with the requisite documents as specified in the aforesaid SEBI Circular.

During the said period, the securities so transferred shall be mandatorily credited to the transferee only in demat mode and shall be under lock-in for a period of one year from the date of registration of transfer. Such securities shall not be transferred/lien-marked/pledged during the said lock-in period.

As per the SEBI Circular, cases involving disputes between transferor and transferee shall not be considered in the special window and may be settled by transferor and transferee through court/NCLT process. Further, securities which have been transferred to Investor Education and Protection Fund (IEPF) shall not be considered under special window for processing.

The SEBI Circular can be accessed at <https://www.sebi.gov.in/legal/circulars/jan-2026/ease-of-doing-investment-special-window-for-transfer-and-dematerialisation-of-physical-securities-99411.html>

For and on behalf of
Power Grid Corporation of India Limited
Sd/-
Anjana Luthra
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Place: Gurugram
Date: 29.07.2026

POWER GRID CORPORATION OF INDIA LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)

Regd. Office: B-3, Gurgaon Institutional Area, Fawcett Road, New Delhi-110 016.
Phone No.: 011-26561011, 26560179, 26560193
Corp. Office: "Saudamini", Plot No. 2, Sector-29, Gurugram, Haryana-122 001.
Phone No.: 0124-8822999 & 8822000
CIN: L40701DL19950030301 Website: www.powergrid.in Email: investors@powergrid.in

A Maharashtra PSU



The Indian EXPRESS
— FOUNDED BY —
RAMNATH GOENKA
— IN 1932 —

BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

Law is in, lawmakers should speak for young

THE DEBATE on the Public Examinations (Prevention of Unfair Means) Amendment Bill 2026 — passed by voice vote amid sloganeering in the Lok Sabha Wednesday — carried echoes of the street agitation that had raged outside the House. The over a month-long protests by students, led by the Cockroach, Janta Party in the wake of the NEET examination paper leak, compelled Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan to resign. They also prodded the government to tighten the existing law, making it more stringent in terms of punishments and fines, and setting up fast-track courts that will work to defined timelines. The change of minister, and the harder law, however, are just the beginning. The momentum built by the students' protests must not be lost — it must lead to larger and more meaningful changes in the education system, and re-energise structures of accountability and reform. And in that process, people's representatives on both sides of the aisle must step up to the challenge — because Parliament has a crucial role to play. It is MPs' responsibility now to ensure that the House opens its doors to let in the concerns and anxieties of the young that filled the streets till only a few days ago.

Some readings of the street protests by students have painted them as antagonistic to the democratically elected people's representatives on the floor of the House. It is true that the students' uprising rang with accumulated anger and resentment at the failure or inability of institutions — of government primarily, but also arguably of Opposition and Parliament — to address the crises that weigh down the education system or to assuage their apprehensions about dwindling opportunities for employment that is dignified and fulfilling. At the same time, however, the protests must be read as an appeal to those same institutions, to listen and respond, and to search for solutions. The movement on the streets must be translated into legislative action. Parliament must take on the hard and patient work of redesigning, correcting and finetuning educational structures and processes.

If Parliament is unable to step up to the task, if it is held back from doing so by long-playing and debilitating syndromes, like growing political polarisation and erosion of reciprocity, it would be missing an extraordinary opportunity. It has a chance to restore the trust of the young in the system. A rare possibility — of renewing and re-imagining the institution's pact with the people — is at hand. The highest forum of democratic deliberation must not fail to seize it.

A medical education more inclusive

THE NATIONAL Medical Commission's (NMC) revised guidelines for admitting persons with disabilities to undergraduate medical courses mark an overdue shift towards making medical education more inclusive. Issued on Monday, the new benchmark stipulates that a candidate's eligibility for the MBBS course will be based on a functional assessment rather than merely a certificate recording the disability. Designated medical boards will carry out evaluations. The message is significant: Disability, by itself, should not be treated as a disqualification. What matters is whether an aspiring doctor can acquire the competencies necessary to practise medicine, with appropriate support. The guidelines recognise that technology, institutional support and accessible infrastructure play an important role in determining whether disability becomes a barrier.

Framed around rigid thresholds and broad categories, the earlier guidelines often functioned less as tools of assessment than as instruments of exclusion. Applicants could be declared ineligible simply because they belonged to a particular disability category or crossed a prescribed threshold, regardless of whether they could complete the MBBS course. The guidelines were challenged several times, including before the Supreme Court, where petitioners argued that blanket exclusions violated the Rights of Persons with Disabilities Act, 2016. Last year, the Court observed that "systemic discrimination against persons with benchmark disabilities should be eliminated".

The real test of the revised guidelines will lie in their implementation. Functional assessments must not become another source of arbitrary decision-making. Without clear evaluation protocols, similarly placed candidates could receive different outcomes depending on the medical board before which they appear. The NMC should, therefore, develop standards that minimise subjectivity while preserving the flexibility that individual cases require. It should also revisit the SC's direction that every medical board include doctors with disabilities — a safeguard that will strengthen the credibility of the process. The Commission must view inclusivity not as a compliance exercise prompted by litigation but as an ongoing commitment. The new guidelines should be seen not as the final word but as the foundation of a medical education system that judges aspirant doctors on their abilities, and not by what could hold them back.

Happy birthday, Punch, many friends to you

THERE IS, in the story of a lonely monkey, an all-too-human tale. Born a year ago at the zoo in Ichikiwa, Japan, Punch's early months were a bit of a tragedy. He was abandoned by his mother, likely because she was too exhausted after his birth to care for him. A bit of a runt, he was rejected by the other young simians in his troop. Bottle-fed by zookeepers, Punch's closest companion was a stuffed toy — an orangutan — that was given to him. The tragic image of lonely young Punch, clutching his doll, eyes exuding a fear and insecurity that so many identify with, made him a media sensation. The foothill at the zoo grew by thousands wanting to see Punch, and he has received scores of birthday cards from his many well-wishers around the world.

A year on, though, Punch is no longer just a mirror for the alone, the lonely and the rejected. He has, gingerly at first and gradually with more confidence, reached out to the other young monkeys and made friends. And it's not because the donations raised by the zoo in his name paid for an air-conditioning system in the monkey enclosure. It's because Punch is finally coming out of the shell of his tragic early months.

Unlike then, when he was easy to spot in the enclosure, far from the maddening crowd, Punch is now often difficult to tell apart from his new friends. Perhaps, on his first birthday, he no longer needs stuffed toys and cards expressing love and sympathy. Maybe well-wishers could give him some bananas to share with the gang. And set up more monkey bars for them to hang out on.



THAROORTHINK
BY SHASHI THAROOR

THE GOVERNMENT'S seeming determination to proceed with a revised delimitation that drastically increases the size of the Lok Sabha to 824 or 850 seats marks a disastrous watershed in India's institutional architecture. The underlying justification offered by the government is purely mathematical: The size of the Lower House cannot remain frozen at the 543-seat limit established in 1972, since when the nation's population has more than doubled. Yet, beneath this seemingly democratic argument lies a profound hazard.

Amid all the other major challenges of the looming delimitation exercise — notably the severe political and federal friction caused by penalising southern states for successful population control, while disproportionately rewarding the northern Hindi heartland for its failures — a basic question remains unaddressed: Does it make any sense to have a legislature so massive and structurally unwieldy? No established democracy does.

Every mature democratic system recognises that a Parliament must be capped at a size that permits genuine legislative scrutiny, cohesive debate, and individual member participation. By choosing to push the Lok Sabha towards 850 seats (a size no other democratic legislature has), India is charting an anomalous and dangerous course. Democratic theory and global practice consistently show that beyond a threshold, a legislature

ceases to function as a deliberative body and deteriorates into a chaotic colosseum where only a select few can speak, while the rest are reduced to passive spectators, mere numbers on voting machines.

After all, the United States House of Representatives was legally capped at 435 in 1929, when the United States population stood at 120 million. Today, the American population has tripled to over 335 million, yet the size of the House remains at 435. Americans recognise that increasing the number of representatives to match population growth would paralyse the legislative process. Instead, each member simply represents a larger number of voters, relying on robust local staff, modern communication, and a highly organised committee system to bridge the governance gap. Indian MPs can do that too.

The realities of an 850-member Lok Sabha are devastating for individual legislators. In a standard parliamentary session, time is an unyielding, scarce resource. Consider the daily Question Hour or a standard legislative debate on a complex bill. If a debate is allocated four hours, and time is distributed according to party strength, at most 15-20 MPs out of 850 will be able to participate. In practice, backbenchers and members of smaller parties will be mostly silenced.

With an oversized Parliament, a vast majority of MPs will never get to ask a question, initiate a private member's bill, or participate in a substantive debate during their entire five-year tenure. They will be transformed into silent placeholders, raising their hands when the party commands. This will worsen an already distressing trend in Indian governance: The shrinking role (and systemic degradation) of Parliament. In recent years, the number of days Parliament meets

annually has steadily declined, bills have been passed via voice vote within minutes without standing committee scrutiny, and the Opposition is frequently sidelined. Flooding the chamber with hundreds of additional members will accelerate this sheer weight of quantity.

An oversized legislature where the vast majority of members have no voice suits an executive that prefers compliance over scrutiny. When a Parliament becomes too large to debate, it naturally cedes its oversight power to the executive cabinet. The individual lawmaker loses leverage, and the House is reduced to a notice board and a rubber stamp.

This structural transformation bears an ominous resemblance to the authoritarian legislative model in Beijing or Pyongyang. Specifically, an 850-seat Lok Sabha risks becoming a desk version of the Chinese People's Political Consultative Conference or the North Korean Supreme People's Assembly — enormous, unwieldy bodies designed to look grand, representative, and pluralistic, but reduced to applauding set speeches by the Great Leader. Their sheer size guarantees they cannot engage in real legislative negotiation or challenge the ruling executive. They exist to perform consensus, not to build it through debate. If India builds a massive legislature where MPs are stripped of their voices due to the arithmetic of time constraints, it will have successfully hollowed out its democracy, replacing a vibrant deliberative body with a performative pageant. Far better to save the extra expenditure on salaries, accommodation, travel and pensions for 300 more MPs and instead build a serious office building for the existing MPs near Parliament, as every other democracy provides its legislators.

The government's primary defence — that a single MP cannot effectively represent 2 to 3 million citizens — is a fallacy that misinterprets the role of a national lawmaker. An MP's constitutional duty is national legislation, foreign policy, macro-economic governance, and holding the Union executive accountable. They are not municipal councillors or MLAs. If India established a sharp, institutional demarcation between the roles of Members of Legislative Assemblies (MLAs) and Members of Parliament (MPs), a smaller, focused group of MPs could easily represent large constituencies. Local grievances, municipal infrastructure, and civic amenities fall squarely within the domain of state legislatures and local panchayats or municipal corporations under the 73rd and 74th Amendments; as population increases, expand the number of MLAs! If local governance frameworks are empowered, the local citizen does not need to look to an MP for everyday civic needs. By keeping the Lok Sabha compact and focused on national governance, and leaving localised representation to state and municipal levels, India could maintain a highly efficient, effective, and truly participative federal structure, without ruining the functionality of Parliament.

The proposal to expand the Lok Sabha to 850 would create a House that is not a forum for governance but an echo chamber for the government. As we contemplate the future of our democracy, we must realise that true representation lies in the quality of debate, the rigour of legislative committee scrutiny, and the empowerment of local levels of government — not in creating an unwieldy mega-charter that replaces democratic discourse with empty theatre.

The writer is a fourth-term Congress MP from Thiruvananthapuram

From Ravidas and Begumpura, a philosophy of governance, Dengue vaccine must complement prevention



ABHINAV PRAKASH

R AVIDAS is a saint amongst the saints'. Kabir's line captures the place of Sant Shirdi Gopalji Maharaj in awakening the consciousness of the Bhakti era. To carry that consciousness to every household, BJP president Nitin Nabin has launched a special campaign from Varanasi, running from Guru Purnima on July 29 to Mahatma on February 20, the 650th *jayanti* of Sant Ravidas.

This is not just an occasion for remembrance but also a chance to reaffirm our faith in the long-neglected, unbroken line of Indian social and spiritual thought. To understand Ravidas, one must revisit the Bhakti movement and the consciousness it produced, which expressed itself not in the language of philosophers but in *lok bhasha*, the language of the people.

Modernity is often confused with Western influence, but the seeds of Indian modernity lie in the Bhakti movement, especially the teachings of Ravidas. Modernity rests on four pillars. The first is equality and human dignity. To speak of equality in a society divided by *jati* and *varna*, and to carry spiritual democracy into social equality, was the movement's greatest achievement. Ravidas's famous line, "What separation is there between you and me?", is a social manifesto. The second is the reality of this world and the primacy of *karma*. Against every temptation of escapism, Ravidas insisted that this world is real, and that one must work here and make it better. The third is the dignity of labour. In a society that had long regarded physical work with contempt, Ravidas raised it to the level of worship. The fourth is good governance and welfare.

Ravidas did not confine himself to individual liberation; in conceiving Begumpura, he left a standard against which any state may be measured. The modernisation and democracy the BJP articulates in modern political vocabulary is a contemporary translation of these teachings, which are also reflected in the concept of *atma manav darshan*. Ravidas wanted a state in which everyone was fed, and the great and the small lived as equals.

That is *antayodaya*, which guides the BJP's governance philosophy.

How that grand conception is being translated into policy can be read in his poem, 'Begumpura'. Ravidas names his ideal city "the place without sorrow". PM-KISAN, Ayushman Bharat, the Garib Kalyan Anna Yojana and the Jal Jeevan Mission all seek a society in which no citizen is one illness or one failed harvest away from ruin. He then describes the city as having no revenue demand, no property burden, no fear, no wrongdoing, no dread of decline. Six centuries later, that list reads like a governance agenda, and it has been met by GST and direct tax reform, BNS, the SVAMITVA Scheme.

The governance of this city, he continues, is settled and permanent, and within it there is no second rank or third, for all are of one standing. That is a constitutional principle stated in the 15th century. Its fulfillment lies in discrimination-free access to government schemes, and in the abrogation of Article 370, which gave the people of Jammu and Kashmir the same rights as every other Indian.

Then comes the sharpest political demand in the poem: "Residents walk wherever they please, and nobody is stopped at the palace gate." This is a call for the abolition of the *darbar*. Seven Race Course Road is now Lok Kalyan Marg. Rajpath is now Kartavya Path, Raj Bhavans are now Lok Bhavans, and the new central secretariat is Kartavya Bhavan. These are not remainings but a change in the culture of power, as is direct benefit transfer, which removed the modern courtier who once stood between the citizen and what he was owed.

Ravidas closes by naming himself and his caste without apology: Whoever is a citizen of this city is a friend of mine. That is the fraternity on which Ek Bharat, Shreshtha Bharat rests. His Begumpura, Kabir's Premnagar, Tukaram's Pandharapur and Ambedkar's Prabuddha Bharat are names for a single dream, and Viksit Bharat is the contemporary link in that unbroken chain.

The writer is national vice-president, BJP Youth Wing



RAJIB DASGUPTA

INDIA HAS taken an important step in the fight against dengue. On July 21, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation granted approval to Qdenga, the country's first approved dengue vaccine. It has been approved in 42 countries. Over 24 million doses have been administered worldwide, and it has the WHO's imprimatur.

Dengue, one of the world's fastest-spreading mosquito-borne viral diseases, is caused by four closely related virus types — DENV-1, DENV-2, DENV-3 and DENV-4 — and is transmitted primarily by the *Aedes aegypti* mosquito. Clinical trials have shown that Qdenga provides long-lasting protection against all four dengue virus types in people who have had the disease. It has also been shown to protect against DENV-1 and DENV-2 among people who have never had dengue, with particularly strong protection against DENV-2, on which the vaccine is based.

The vaccine is administered in two doses. If the second is delayed, the schedule does not need to be restarted; the missed dose can be given at the earliest opportunity. It is not recommended for children under six because of lower efficacy and the relatively low prevalence of prior dengue infection in that age group. The WHO does not recommend its use beyond 60 years until there is more evidence on safety and efficacy. It should not be administered to pregnant women, women planning pregnancy within one month of vaccination, breastfeeding mothers, immunocompromised individuals, or those receiving immunosuppressive therapies such as chemotherapy or high-dose corticosteroids.

Affordability is likely to determine uptake. At an expected price of Rs 3,000-6,000 per dose, initial demand is likely to come primarily from the urban middle class. Whether the vaccine should eventually be included in the Universal Immunisation Programme is a complex question. The WHO recommends that countries consider introducing Qdenga into routine immunisation only in areas where dengue transmission is a significant public health threat. Indicators include a dengue seroprevalence exceeding 60 per cent by the age of nine or a mean age of dengue-related hospitalisation below 16 years. India will need robust epidemiological data to determine which regions meet these criteria before considering wider public funding.

Vaccination, however, is only one part of the solution. The same *Aedes* mosquitoes also transmit chikungunya and Zika, making integrated vector management indispensable. Eliminating mosquito breeding sites through better drainage and waste disposal must remain the first line of defence. These efforts should be complemented by biological measures such as larvivorous fish, judicious use of chemical and microbial control methods, stronger coordination across agencies, and sustained community participation. Improving public awareness and health literacy is equally important. Qdenga is a significant addition to India's public health arsenal, but it should complement, not replace, a comprehensive strategy for controlling mosquito-borne diseases.

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The writer is chairperson, Centre of Social Medicine and Community Health, JNU

40 YEARS AGO

July 30, 1986



Opposition stops amendment

THE UNION government's move to arm itself with special powers in border states proved abortive when an alert Opposition showed the proposed amendment was redundant. When PM Rajiv Gandhi convened a meeting of opposition leaders to seek support, Madhu Dandavate read out Article 249 to show the Constitution provided for these contingencies. The PM said the government would abandon the move.

dissident Akali leaders, who were colluding with extremists in Punjab, and said some leaders were willingly or unwillingly acting as agents of the country's enemies. He said Parkash Singh Badal and G S Tohra were organising the *kryia* and *bhog* ceremonies of terrorists killed in encounters and declaring that such extremists had attained martyrdom.

Darjeeling tense

TROOPS WERE patrolling all the hill subdivisions of Darjeeling district as tension mounted on the second day of the 108-hour bandh sponsored by "Gorkhaland" agitators protesting the police firing on July 27. Life was

paralysed in Darjeeling. Kurseong and Kalimpong as the strike, markets, educational institutions, and other establishments remained closed. GNLFS supporters abducted the deputy director of tourism after intercepting his vehicle near Pehsakh.

Car bomb kills 25 in Beirut

A CAR BOMB exploded in a crowded shopping centre in Beirut, killing at least 25 people and wounding 170. The blast came a day after a white Mercedes Sedan packed with a quarter-tonne of explosives blew up in the city's Christian sector, killing 32 people and wounding 140.

The Ideas Page

THURSDAY, JULY 30, 2026

As India's youth spoke up, the message from across the border — you inspire us



SANJAYA BARU

ASUBCONTINENT divided by the politics of the past came together last week through the activism of a generation unhappy with the present and with a stake in the future. India's Gen Z protests, triggered across the country by a movement launched by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), met with expressions of solidarity from young people across South Asia. The CJP movement was itself, in some ways, an echo of the Gen Z protests that began in Sri Lanka, went on to Bangladesh and then Nepal.

The Indian youth upsurge, interestingly, was welcomed by young Pakistanis. It remains to be seen if it will inspire them to stand up for democracy in their own country. Brought together by posts on Instagram and news coverage on channels like the BBC and Al Jazeera, young people in Bangladesh, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka chimed with the Indian protest movement. It is the music and its irreverent humour that found an echo across South Asia.

You inspire us, was the message from across the border. In response to such admiration and support, young Indians responded with gratitude. Hopefully in each of these countries the young fighting for their future will remain invested in the development of their own country, strengthening the roots of democracy at home and the prospects for development, rather than emigrate to greener pastures.

A subcontinent divided by the antediluvian bigotry of a dominant and powerful few suddenly found that such domestic prejudices are not shared by victims of similar forms of authoritarianism and corruption in their own country. More than the politics of the Indian protest movement, it is the music and its irreverent humour that found an echo across South Asia.

"You guys are too cool, *yarr*," said a Pakistani student who viewed on Instagram the opening of a bolt on a moving police van in Mumbai that enabled hold-up kids to jump



ILLUSTRATION: C S KASIKUMAR

out and dance on the road. At Jantar Mantar, a young man thanked these supporters from across the border saying, "We want peace, not war. We want to study. We want jobs."

In a few words, these teenagers and 20-somethings summed up the sentiment of millions across South Asia who wish to live in peace and live a dignified life, not exporting terror or hatred. They may well not reflect the attitude of the ruling regime in their respective country, but they surely reflect the shared attitude of a new generation seeking a good life and a fulfilling and fruitful future.

In the past, cross-border friendship in South Asia was promoted by concerned, elderly citizens, liberals and communists and a few among the elite who lived similar lives and would meet up on occasion in London or Dubai. Today, it is through Instagram that a new generation connects, with no prejudice and lots of pizzazz.

The initial narrative of the ruling regime's dirty tricks department that the CJP was inspired by Pakistan's ISI, America's CIA and George Soros fell flat when Gen Z protesters laughed off such accusations rather than get angry about them. The deployment of humour, laughter, music and poetry as

political weapons will remain the unique contribution of this campaign.

The CJP protest campaign has the potential to give meaning to a recent call given by the leadership of the Rashtriya Swamasevak Sangh (RSS) for increased people-to-people contact between India and Pakistan. We have seen the positive side of such contact on social media with youth across borders expressing solidarity with each other and recognising that all of them have shared concerns — about their own future, their education, their employment opportunities.

Having achieved the limited objective of getting the Union Minister for Education sacked, with some other demands waiting to be addressed, the CJP campaign across

India can easily evolve into a subcontinent-wide peace movement seeking better relations between neighbours. Prime Minister Narendra Modi can make good use of this opportunity to strengthen civil society engagement across borders. The CJP has demonstrated that a humane approach to social issues produces better results than hate, prejudice and violence.

An improvement in bilateral relations within South Asia due to social-media interaction between the

Brought together by posts on Instagram and news coverage, young people in Bangladesh, Nepal, Pakistan and Sri Lanka chimed with their Indian counterparts. Rarely has any political issue in one country brought together an entire generation across borders

subcontinent's youth would set an example for many embattled regions of the world. Wars between nations are declared by men and women in their sixties and seventies, fought by soldiers in their twenties, but hurt the future of tomorrow's adults. The youth, therefore, have a stake in the pursuit and assurance of peace.

The anonymity of social media presence has spawned trolling and abuse, making the medium a double-edged sword. A person can hurt you on social media but one can also express solidarity. In India we have seen far too much abuse and venom on social media, especially against Muslims at home and in our neighbourhood. The CJP protest has shown that idealistic youth can also use social media to build bridges, make common cause and express solidarity with neighbours with shared aspirations.

As a great democracy that has fought to defend its own democratic institutions at home, India can inspire its neighbourhood, where young people are also seeking to defend or establish democratic freedoms. The backsliding in India's democratic credentials over the past decade has hurt our credibility as a democracy. We must regain our standing as a torchlight of democracy in Asia.

The youth movement unleashed by the CJP this year has restored hope in the security of our hard-won personal freedoms. All is not yet lost. An authoritarian and majoritarian political leadership has been challenged and its hollowness within exposed. The Delhi Police and their political bosses have made an important contribution to the awakening of democratic consciousness in middle-class families that had been lulled by bigotry.

Across India, we witnessed an unbottling not just of individual grievances but of a collective concern with majoritarian assertion and the trampling of individual freedoms. The message may not have fully sunk in. After all, even after the events of the past week, there will be a backlash from aggressive and abusive members of the saffron brigade. But the fear is gone in a freedom-loving youth. They will, hopefully, continue to fight to preserve our democracy and our Constitution.

The writer is chairman of the board of trustees, Forum for National Security Studies (FNSS) & Centre for Aerospace & Strategic Studies (CAPS)

India's fertility decline story is not yet a crisis. It is a policy story



SRINIVAS GOLI AND K S JAMES

TODAY, INDIA'S most popular headline about its population is simple: The average woman is having about two children over her lifetime. That single figure has become a shorthand for "India has reached replacement-level fertility", and in one sense it is true. But successive Sample Registration System and National Family Health Survey rounds tell us something that should make us pause: India has achieved below-replacement fertility despite the near universality of marriage — only about 1 per cent of women remain never married by ages 45-49, the median age at first birth is 21.2 years, and childbearing is virtually imposed within marriage with a lower socio-economic status, a demographic pathway that sharply contrasts with the experience of most other low-fertility countries. Therefore, this is not the classic story of low birth rates driven by late marriage or people choosing not to marry. So what, exactly, is inside that two-child average and does it tell us the whole truth?

The widely used total fertility rate (TFR — average number of births per woman) counts all births, including births women did not plan or want, as well as those that happen because families kept trying until they got a son. Thus, it hides actual fertility intentions. Demographers have a name for the part of fertility that represents births women actually wanted: The "wanted fertility rate". If you count only the births that match what women say they intended, their preferred family size can be obtained. The gap between wanted and actual fertility has narrowed over the years but remains significant. Nationally, women have an average of 2.0 children, while their desired family size is about 1.6, leaving a gap of 0.4. Around eight states (Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Jharkhand, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh, Assam, Haryana) have a gap of more than 0.3 children per woman.

Here is where India gets genuinely unusual. The country has managed to bring birth rates down to near-replacement levels, and yet millions of women still can't reliably prevent pregnancies they don't want. How can both be true?

The answer lies in how Indian women control their fertility.

Women have children, reach their desired family size, and then stop permanently using sterilisation. What's largely missing are the tools that help young couples space their children to delay a first birth, or wait a few years between children. When family planning arrives late, unintended pregnancies tend to cluster in the early years of marriage, among the youngest women. This also reflects in relatively poor maternal and child health. Informed choice around sterilisation also remains partial. When women whose sterilisation was not a fully informed choice are counted alongside women with unmet need, India's "unwanted family planning" problem looks considerably larger than the headline numbers suggest.

There is another force propping up India's birth numbers: Son preference. In several states, many families don't stop having children after one or two, they stop after they've had a son. Analyses of NFHS microdata from the 1990s found that a disproportionate share of "unwanted" births — beyond what women said they wanted — were daughters. As son preference weakens — and slowly it is weakening, particularly among younger and more educated families — this hidden fertility inflation will deflate.

India's fertility decline story is not yet a crisis. It is a policy story, one about helping women and couples align their actual lives with their intended ones. Unintended pregnancies have already fallen reasonably from 21 per cent in 2005-06 to 8 per cent in 2019-21. If unmet need for family planning continues to fall, if spacing methods reach young couples who need them most, and if son preference keeps fading, India's birth rate will fall further on its own. Not because families are being pressured, but because many of the births that currently hold the number up were never truly planned in the first place.

The baby India didn't plan for may become rarer in future. The more pressing concern now is the recent decline in the use of modern contraceptive methods, which risks leaving the country's remaining unwanted-fertility gap in place even as the headline TFR falls. This becomes more critical when only 30 per cent of women seek a second birth on their own. India needs to monitor fertility preferences, both intended and unintended births, and ensure couples are able to realise their own choices instead of overall birth rates.

Goli is associate professor at the International Institute for Population Sciences and the author of A Treatise on Families in Contemporary India and James is a demographer and professional specialist at Princeton University. Views are personal



ILLUSTRATION: TANUSHRI MITRA

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Governance lessons

THE MSRDC-HDFC Bank issue provides key lessons for banks, regulators and boards ("Learning the right lessons at the bank", IE, July 29). While HDFC Bank's internal review concluded that there was business overreach rather than fraud or personal enrichment, it still identified governance and compliance lapses, resulting in disciplinary action against senior executives. Business targets should never override regulatory requirements. Boards and senior management must exercise effective oversight.

Bal Govind, Noida

Beyond borders

INDIA'S NATIONAL security strategy should increasingly recognise that influence today extends beyond territorial boundaries ("Our strategic imagination must look beyond geography", IE, July 29). Technology, trade, maritime connectivity, cyber capabilities and supply chains are as important as geography in shaping national interests. Investments in innovation, infrastructure and strategic partnerships will strengthen India's position. A co-ordinated approach involving government, industry and academia can improve preparedness for emerging challenges.

SM Jeeva, Chennai

Academic freedom

UNIVERSITIES SHOULD remain spaces for learning, critical thinking and open discussion, free from political interference and administrative bias ("On campus, questions about vendetta politics", IE, July 29). Institutional actions must be transparent, legally sound and guided by due process rather than perceptions of political influence. Governments and university authorities should resolve disputes through independent inquiries and fair procedures. Protecting the autonomy and credibility of educational institutions is essential.

Prakash Paramasivan, Neelambur



KAMINI WALLA

THE LATEST global study in *The Lancet Public Health* has again highlighted what infectious disease experts in India have known for years: India uses too many broad-spectrum "watch" antibiotics and too few first-line "access" antibiotics. It estimates that India's antibiotic consumption is higher than the optimal target and that the antibiotic mix is skewed towards drugs that should ideally be reserved for more serious infections.

The tendency to overuse broad-spectrum antibiotics has been documented repeatedly over the past two decades through surveillance studies, hospital audits and national antimicrobial resistance (AMR) programmes. The more important question is why physicians continue to prescribe them.

The answer lies less in irrationality than in the realities of clinical practice. Doctors frequently prescribe antibiotics before a definitive diagnosis is available because patients often present late. Diagnostic facilities are limited or unreliable, and treatment decisions cannot always wait. Similarly, inadequate infection prevention and control in healthcare facilities increases the likelihood of healthcare-associated infections, prompting clinicians to choose broader-spectrum agents from the outset. In other words, antibiotics are often used to compensate for systemic weaknesses.

Clinicians need training in antimicrobial stewardship and evidence-based prescribing. Communities must understand that antibiotics do not treat viral infections

If India wants to reduce inappropriate antibiotic use, it must address these underlying drivers. The first priority is strengthening infection prevention. Better water, sanitation and hygiene, wider use of vaccines, and sustained investment in infection prevention and control programmes in hospitals will reduce the burden of infections that require antibiotics. While initiatives like Kayakalp have improved cleanliness in public hospitals, preventing healthcare-associated infections requires continuous investment in trained infection-control personnel, surveillance systems, antimicrobial stewardship and institutional accountability.

The second priority is strengthening diagnostic capacity. Rational antibiotic prescribing is only possible when clinicians have confidence in laboratory results. India has begun building this through the National Health Mission, Free Diagnostics Service Initiative, National Essential Diagnostics List and expanded lab networks. Improving laboratory quality, accreditation, turnaround time and confidence in microbiology reports is equally important.

Educational reform. Clinicians need training in antimicrobial stewardship and evidence-based prescribing. Communities must understand that antibiotics do not treat viral infections and that demanding them for every fever is harmful in the long term.

On antibiotics, problem isn't just overprescribing

Yeah, the kids are alright

though, have forced a late realisation.

What my generation considered perseverance and adaptability was nothing but fear. The fear of authority, the fear of not being allowed to make it, of being singled out, of being left behind. Our grand ambition had simply been to get past the door before the doorman shuts it on us, too bad for the ones left behind. We who grew up in pre-liberalised India knew what scarcity was, and the psychological imprint it left on us was the ever-lurking fear of losing it all once again.

Nowhere is this fear as manifest as in my own fraternity: The Hindi film industry. In the last decade or so (that's the fearful boomer in me trying to add specificity when I could have easily written the last 12 years), it has witnessed an unprecedented clamping down on its freedom of expression. Our response to it has been that of the frog in

the pan, our boomerbodies skillfully "adjusting" as the water temperature kept rising. When my film *Udaan* (Punjabi translation: issues in 2016, a large part of the industry took a stance and came out in support. In 2026, merely 10 years later, a well-made, powerful film like *Satya* was banned and not a whisper could be heard. We chose this silence, for it kept us safe from being branded anti-nationals. We chose this darkness, for it

allowed us to hide in the shadows. Many of us "adjusted" even further, crawling when we were only asked to bend, and unleashed a hateful propaganda machinery on an unsuspecting audience. Heck, most of it wasn't even competent cinema, and yet, our award functions celebrated it with gusto. The rest of us continued to go to them just so we could preen with our glittering trophies on social media. It was my generation's fear of being left behind manifesting itself all over again.

Guilt, though, is a dead weight and to make it not do us in, we poured our hearts out in the safe space of like-minded company, blaming the state of affairs, the state of the audience, but never acknowledging our complicity. We consoled each other — "hang in there, this too shall pass". And to appear less guilty, we chose to lampoon the larger media landscape, taking

digs at the toxicity of the news channels in our films and shows. Yet, when the time came for their release, we chose to go the same toxic route as the media moguls, even though it ate at our conscience.

The Gen Z at Jantar Mantar, though, have refused to do that. What we did not understand then — and is crystal clear now — is that this generation has a different relationship with authority. What we read as their intransigence is a lack of fear. They are not afraid of authority. They look in the eye and ask for what they believe is theirs. Yeah, the kids are alright. They'll leave behind a better world than the one that was handed over to them. And while they are at it, they are teaching some of us how to speak again.

Sharma is a writer, director and producer



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LEGAL

As late PM Singh gets clean chit, recalling the coal block 'scam' case

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, July 29

THE SUPREME COURT Wednesday gave a posthumous clean chit to the late former Prime Minister Manmohan Singh in a case pertaining to the alleged coal block "scam" that the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) was probing. A Bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, Justice Jyotsna Singh and Justice V Mohana accepted the CBI's decision to close the case against Singh, who passed away on December 26, 2024, and allowed his appeal challenging the 2015 trial court summons to him in the case.

In August and October 2014, the CBI had filed closure reports before the trial court of then Special Judge Bharat Parashar, finding no case against Singh. The special court, however, rejected the reports, took cognisance of the case, and summoned Singh in March 2015. The Supreme Court had stayed the summons to Singh in April 2015.

The case

The case pertains to alleged irregularities in the allocation of Odisha's Talabira-2 coal block in 2005, when Manmohan Singh was PM and held the charge of the Coal Ministry portfolio. The block was allocated to Mahanadi Coalfields Ltd, Neyveli Lignite Corporation Ltd (NLC) and Hindalco by the three entities formed a joint venture.

The alleged irregularities pertained to the inclusion of Hindalco (an Aditya Birla Group flagship company) in the allotment of the block alongside the two public sector undertakings. While the 25th Screening Committee had originally recommended allocating the block to NLC, the decision was revisited after Birla wrote to the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) requesting coal allocation.

The special court had issued summons to Singh, Aditya Birla Group chairman Kumar Mangalam Birla, former Coal Secretary P C Parakh, the company Hindalco and its executives S Shubendu Amitabh and D Bhattacharya.

The court observed that Singh made a "conscious effort" to "somehow accommodate" Hindalco in the process by approving Parakh's proposal to accommodate the company in the block, while ignoring notes of caution from two PMO officials regarding relaxation of previously approved guidelines.

The judge noted that the allocation "nullified" the Screening Committee's recommendations, and that it hurt the NLC and its efforts to establish a 2,000 megawatt power plant in Odisha.

What Singh's lawyers said

Now, more than a decade after the special court's summons, the top court was hearing a batch of petitions in connection with the coal block allotment cases when Senior Advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for Singh, referred to the case against the late PM.

Sibal said that the matter had become infructuous after Singh's death, the special court's remarks against him ought to be expunged. Senior Advocate A M Singhvi, also representing Singh, urged the Supreme Court to do away with the remarks.

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SECURITY

Besra arrest may not stop Maoist insurgency, but effectively ends the movement

Deeptiman Tiwary
New Delhi, July 29

THE ARREST of senior Communist Party of India (Maoist) Politburo member Misir Besra in Jharkhand marks the culmination of one of India's longest counter-insurgency campaigns. For nearly four decades, Besra remained one of the Maoist's most influential leaders in the Jharkhand-Bihar region, surviving repeated security offensives even as the rest of the Maoist leadership was steadily eliminated through encounters, arrests and surrenders. With his arrest, the CPI(Maoist) has effectively lost the last active member of the leadership that built the organisation into a nationwide insurgent force.

Who is Misir Besra?

Born into a Santal Adivasi family in Madanah village of Jharkhand's Giridih district, Misir Besra studied in Dhanbad before completing graduation and postgraduation in political science at Raiganj. It was during the sociopolitical churn of the

Jharkhand movement in the late 1980s that he was drawn to Maoist ideology. Leaving behind his young wife and family, he joined the Maoist Communist Centre, which later merged with the People's War Group in 2004 to form the CPI(Maoist).

Besra's rise was driven by military success. Soon after Jharkhand was carved out of Bihar in 2000, he was instrumental in attacks on security forces, including the 2003 and 2004 IED ambushes in West Singhbhum's Bitikisoy and Baliba that killed 55 personnel. The attacks earned him a place in the Central Military Commission and charge of the Eastern Regional Bureau, making him one of the organisation's most influential leaders in eastern India.

For years, agencies knew little about the man behind these attacks until his arrest during a routine vehicle check in 2007. Two years later, he escaped in one of the country's most audacious Maoist jailbreaks when around 30 cadres attacked a court complex in Bihar's Lakhisarai, killing a policeman. Besra remained underground for the

next 17 years despite carrying a Rs 1 crore bounty and facing over 150 criminal cases.

What does his arrest mean for the Maoist movement?

Besra's arrest completes the dismantling of the CPI(Maoist)'s central leadership that security agencies have pursued over the past two years. Unlike earlier phases of the anti-Maoist campaign, which largely targeted field commanders, the recent offensive focused on decapitating the organisation's command structure.

At the start of 2024, the Politburo and Central Committee together had 21 leaders directing operations, recruitment and strategy across the country. Over the next two years, 12 were killed, seven surrendered and one was arrested. Besra, the only leader left underground, has now been captured. In the Dankaranyan region (spanning Chhattisgarh, Odisha, Telangana, and Andhra Pradesh) — the Maoists' principal military theatre — the State Committee was dismantled through killings, arrests and sur-

renders. The Madhya Pradesh-Maharashtra-Chhattisgarh committee disappeared after its remaining three members surrendered, while Odisha and Telangana also lost their state leaderships. The Disturbed Region Bureau, which coordinated operations across states, was similarly broken up.

Almost every nationally recognised Maoist leader has now either been killed or surrendered. General secretary Nambala Keshava Rao alias Basavaraj and Battalion 1 commander Madvi Hidma were killed, while senior leaders including Mallojula Venugopal Rao (Sonu) and Thippuri Tirupathi (Devuji) surrendered.

With Besra's arrest, the CPI (Maoist) is left with scattered armed groups led by lower-level commanders, but no nationally recognised leadership capable of directing a coordinated insurgency across states.

What action has the government taken over the past two years?

Security forces pushed deeper into strongholds such as Bastar and Abujmahad,

established forward operating bases, improved road connectivity, and increasingly relied on intelligence-led operations instead of large-area combat exercises. Local forces, particularly Chhattisgarh's District Reserve Guards, also eroded the Maoists' long-held advantage in jungle warfare.

Alongside military operations, the Centre expanded rehabilitation packages for surrendering cadres. The combined approach has sharply reduced the Maoists' geographical footprint. According to government data, Left Wing Extremism-related violence has fallen by more than 80% since 2010, and by early 2026 only seven districts remained categorised as LWE-affected, three of them severely so.

Can the movement survive?

The arrest of Besra does not automatically end Maoist violence. Small groups remain active, particularly in parts of Bastar, and could continue sporadic attacks or extortion. But security officials believe the CPI (Maoist) no longer possesses the leadership,

territorial control or depth needed to regenerate itself as a nationwide insurgency. Roads, connectivity and a stronger administrative presence have reduced the isolation that once enabled the movement to flourish.

Former Maoist leaders and security experts argue that the organisation also failed to adapt to changing conditions. Survival has depended on years of being on the move, but a permanent presence in former strongholds and tribal aspirations shifted towards education, welfare and employment. But the CPI (Maoist) remained committed to a strategy of protracted armed struggle.

What challenges does govt face?

Security experts caution that eliminating the leadership is only one part of the challenge. The areas once dominated by Maoists continue to face problems of governance, infrastructure and access to public services. They argue that security gains must now be consolidated by strengthening civil administration — through schools, health centres, roads, communications and jobs.

ECONOMY

As conflict expands to Red Sea, India's crude oil options



SUKALP SHARMA

THE THEATRE of the West Asia conflict, earlier limited to the Strait of Hormuz from the perspective of India's crude oil imports, has now widened. Last week, the Yemen-based Houthi militia announced it would target Saudi Arabian tankers attempting to cross the Bab el-Mandeb Strait and indeed attacked a few ships.

Like the Strait of Hormuz, the Bab el-Mandeb — which connects the Red Sea to the Gulf of Aden and the Arabian Sea — is another critical chokepoint for global trade, and energy supplies in particular.

Saudi Arabia was using the route to export its oil, including to India, as Strait of Hormuz traffic fell to a trickle. The Houthi impact is already visible, with vessel crossings via Bab el-Mandeb slumping to an average of 31 per day over the past three days from 43 per day in the first half of July, according to S&P Global data from July 27.

The Houthi blockade could delay oil shipments to Asia by forcing tankers to sail through the Suez Canal and then taking the circuitous route around Africa. This would add up to four weeks to the journey, and keep oil prices elevated. This matters for India, which depends on imports to meet over 88% of its oil requirement. But according to analysts, the current risks appear manageable despite the concerns.

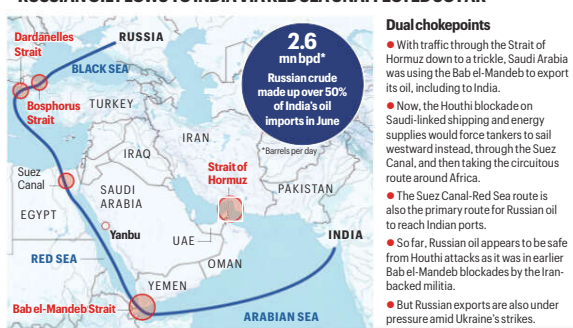
The first and the most obvious fall-back for the country is Russian crude, the mainstay of its oil imports. So far, Russian oil appears to be safe from Houthi attacks, as it was in earlier Bab el-Mandeb blockades by the Iran-backed militia.

Russian oil exports are also under pressure amid Ukraine's strikes against energy export infrastructure. But the expectation is that while this may restrict the availability of Moscow's crude, and thus drive up prices, any material impact on India would be limited from a supply security perspective.

The Russian option

As per the predictions, if Russian oil (coming through the Red Sea route) is not affected and the blockade is targeted only

RUSSIAN OIL FLOWS TO INDIA VIA RED SEA UNAFFECTED SO FAR



Dual chokepoints

- With traffic through the Strait of Hormuz down to a trickle, Saudi Arabia was using the Bab el-Mandeb to export its oil, including to India.
- Now, the Houthi blockade on Saudi-linked shipping and energy supplies would force tankers to sail westward instead, through the Suez Canal, and then taking the circuitous route around Africa.
- The Suez Canal-Red Sea route is also the primary route for Russian oil to reach Indian ports.
- So far, Russian oil appears to be safe from Houthi attacks as it was in earlier Bab el-Mandeb blockades by the Iran-backed militia.
- But Russian exports are also under pressure amid Ukraine's strikes.

against Saudi Arabia, we don't see a very big challenge. We expect the movement of Russian oil to be unaffected.

India's oil requirement, but many ifs and buts are still there, so maybe in another week or 10 days' time, there would be more clarity," state-owned Bharat Petroleum's Chairman and Managing Director Sanjay Khanna told *The Indian Express* last week. The Suez Canal-Red Sea route is the primary route for Russian oil to reach Indian ports.

Industry analysts said that if Saudi Arabian oil supplies to India are disrupted, Indian refiners are likely to further increase purchases of Russian oil barrels, while also drawing on commercial crude inventories to bridge temporary supply gaps. Moreover, India's increasingly diversified crude slate — which includes dozens of suppliers from across the world — provides greater flexibility than in previous years, reducing the risk of a severe supply disruption.

"If Red Sea transit remains uninterrupted, Indian refiners retain an important supply buffer through Saudi Arabia's East-West (Yanbu) pipeline, which has recently supplied roughly 300,000–500,000 bpd (barrels per day) of crude. However, if the security situation deteriorates and Red Sea imports become unavailable during August, refiners will need to replace those barrels from

Emergency options, beyond Russia

West Asian crude that can bypass regional chokepoints are practical emergency options for Indian refiners.

There are also options to increase purchases of American and South American oil, but the long voyage times are a challenge.

alternative sources. Indian refiners are likely to increase purchases of Russian spot barrels where available, while also drawing on commercial crude inventories to bridge any temporary supply gaps," said Sumit Ritolla, manager, refining and modelling at commodity market analytics firm Kpler.

Amid the Strait of Hormuz crisis, India's Russian crude imports have increased from around 1 million bpd in February to record highs of about 2.6 million bpd in June, accounting for over 50% of India's overall oil imports. July oil imports from Russia are also tracking at similar levels, as per ship-tracking data. Before the war, over 40% of India's oil imports came from West Asia via the Strait of Hormuz.

According to Ritolla, Russian crude remains India's strongest supply hedge, and imports could potentially rise toward or even above 3 million bpd if market conditions and Russian export availability permit. He added that the situation would become tighter if Red Sea flows are disrupted, but it is unlikely to become critical.

"Russian oil will provide some relief for India and China. Urales was offered at around \$7/barrel discount to Dubai (crude grade) before the latest escalation; those discounts have now disappeared, and Russian barrels are now moving at premiums as Indian refiners compete for supply. However, as India

India faces fresh oil supply risks as the Houthis threaten Saudi shipments via Red Sea. Russian crude and alternative sources could cushion the impact

will try to absorb as much Urales (Russia's flagship crude grade) as possible, its incremental availability is limited as China and Turkey are competing for the same barrels," Abu Dhabi-based energy analyst Natalia Katona told *The Indian Express*.

The risks to Russia's oil exports

According to industry experts and analysts, a key uncertainty from India's point of view is whether Russia can sustain higher export availability, given the impact of continued Ukrainian attacks on parts of its upstream and downstream oil infrastructure.

"While the Strait of Hormuz and Red Sea remain strategically important, the uninterrupted operation of Russian export infrastructure — particularly Black Sea terminals such as Novorossiysk — has become equally, if not more, critical for India's crude supply... any disruption to Saudi exports via the Red Sea would have a relatively smaller impact on India's overall crude availability than a sustained disruption to Russian Black Sea exports," said Ritolla.

Unlike the Red Sea, where some cargoes can be rerouted around Africa, export alternatives for oil exported from Black Sea ports are limited. Any prolonged disruption could tighten global crude availability, disrupt trade flows, and directly affect India's largest source of imported crude.

According to Katona, the longer immediate concern is Novorossiysk's Shesheks terminal, which halted operations last week following Ukrainian attacks on regional oil infrastructure. The terminal is particularly important for India, as of the 1.1 million bpd crude loaded there in June, around 840,000 bpd went to India. Overall, the Novorossiysk complex supplied about 28% of India's Russian crude imports in June.

Russia had recently increased crude exports as Ukrainian attacks sent several refineries offline for repairs, which freed additional barrels for the export market — mainly China and India. In the medium term, the return of the affected Russian refining capacity is also a risk for India, particularly if the Houthi crisis doesn't abate.

"As more refineries return, fewer barrels will be available for export. Given Russia's recent fuel shortages, Moscow is likely to reduce the record 4.5 million bpd of crude exported in June, of which about 55% went to India. If all major refineries resume normal operation, Russian crude exports could fall by as much as 1 million bpd," said Katona.

SPORT

The concerns raised by FIFA's plans for selling stake in World Cup

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, July 29

FIFA and its president Gianni Infantino sparked uproar when they announced the formation of a new entity, called the FIFA Forward Enterprise (FFE), that would control the commercial aspects of football's global governing body.

Part of the proposal is to sell a minority stake in the new company that will effectively run the World Cup, the Club World Cup and all other events organised by it — a proclamation that brought condemnation from European, Asian and North and Central American footballing confederations.

What raised eyebrows even more was that Thrive Eternal, an investment vehicle headed by Joshua Kushner — the brother of US President Donald Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner — was "expected to lead the proposed investor group for FFE".

What is FIFA proposing?

Infantino has proposed the formation of the FFE — an entity completely controlled by FIFA and governed by Infantino. The entity would gain control of the commercial arm of FIFA events — ticketing, broadcasting, sponsorships and licensing. FIFA plans

to sell up to 28% of that entity to private investors — an admission it had to make through a hasty press release after the news leaked. The intention is to bring in up to \$4.2 billion based on an equity valuation of \$20 billion, according to FIFA's own estimates. It then intends to distribute the \$4.2 billion among the 211 countries that form FIFA.

How can Infantino make this happen?

Each of FIFA's 211 countries, or Member Associations (MAs), stand to gain an immediate \$20 million from an initiative the world body intends to start, called FIFA Fast Forward Programme. Each MA currently gets \$8 million from FIFA as part of its Forward Funding programme. That number jumps to \$20 million for the 2027–30 cycle, \$22 million for the 2031–34 cycle and \$24 million for the 2035–38 cycle — if the MAs agree to be part of this deal.

Will countries accept the deal?

Most will. FIFA has bypassed continental football bodies and directly proposed sending money to countries for their backing. Poorer African and Asian countries enjoy voting powers equal to European giants like England, France and Germany. The money FIFA is offering countries may

Shock and surprise

Continental football governing bodies have been withering in their response.

Europe's UEFA said: "The soul and governance of football are not assets to be traded, especially with zero transparency as to who gains financially. None of us are the owners of football. It is not FIFA's to sell."

The Asian Football Confederation and the CONCACAF (North and South American, and Caribbean) expressed surprise and said none of these plans were discussed with them.



FIFA president Gianni Infantino. AP

not be significant for the footballing powerhouses, but FIFA has used the pretext of democratising football to provide an incentive to the rest of the world to back them for making further profits, and hand control of the biggest sporting event in the world to private investors. It may be easy for a rich country to say no to \$86 million from now till 2038, not so much for a majority of countries affiliated to FIFA.

Does FIFA need this money?

FIFA had estimated the 2026 World Cup and the current four-year cycle (2023–2026)

would bring in \$13 billion. It ended up earning \$15 billion. Selling off a percentage of the World Cup to private investors could bring in vast swathes of additional money. But the real problem lies in who the organisation is planning on selling the World Cup to.

Who is FIFA selling the World Cup to?

This is where the plan starts to make sense in Infantino's world. Prominent among the buyers is Thrive Eternal, an investment vehicle founded by Peter Thiel. Running it is Joshua Kushner.

What are Infantino's ties with Trump?

The FIFA president's relationship with Trump has been unusually close. Infantino conferred up a 'FIFA Peace Prize' for Trump, who had spent years bemoaning that he had not got the Nobel Peace Prize. The cosy ties came under severe criticism when Trump personally petitioned for US forward Falorin Balogun's red card to be rescinded so that he could play in a knockout game. Now, that closeness has tied into a financial deal, indirectly, with the Trump clan.

Even the disgraced former FIFA president Sepp Blatter was unequipped in his contentment. "No one has the right to sell our game," he said.

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, JAGRUTI VINOD JAIN C/o Rohit Kumar, A-101-102, St. Sustain Vihar, Chandra Vatika, Sector-45, Noida-201301, have changed my name to JAGRUTI.

0071050769-1

I, Sanyia W/o Deepankar R/o 135/157, Sector-8-Near RK Memorial, Munirpur (59), Po-Kheri Manajit Dist.Sonapat Haryana-131103, have changed my name to Sanyia Adya, for all future purposes. 004086915-6

I, PRIYA CHAUDHARY W/o Hrishav Ravi R/o S/N/A, 38,SRINAGR PATRIAL NEAR SAI MANDIR, KUSUNDA,DHANBAD, JHARKHAND-828116, have changed my name to PRIYA CHAUDHARY 004086917-2

I, Gunjan Singh wife of Arpit Singh R/o T-72/701, Panchsheel Pebbles, Sector-3, Vaishali, Ghaziabad, Up, have changed my name to Gunjan Rani Agarwal to Gunjan Singh for all purposes. 0040868814-1

I, Jasmine Kaur W/O, Ranjeet Singh R/o 45a, Second Floor Begumpur Malviya Nagar New Delhi 110017 have changed my name to Bajaj Kaur.

0040868924-1

I, Meenish W/o Hari Kishan R/o A-197, Sector-47, Noida-201301 (Uttar Pradesh), have changed my name to Mitahesh for all purposes. 0040868915-6

I, Kanchan D/o Nanak Chand W/o Nishant Anand R/o A-3/72, Sector-5, Rohini, Delhi-110085, after marriage have changed my name to Kanchan Anand. In future shall be known by my new name for all purposes. 0040868934-2

I, Meena Devi, W/o M.K. Gupta, R/o G-334, Preet Vihar, Delhi-110092, do hereby declare that the names Meena Devi, Meena Gupta, and Meena Devi Gupta appearing in my Government, Banking, Educational, Financial and other records/documents refer to one and the same person, i.e., myself. Henceforth, I shall be known and identified only as MEENA DEVI for all future purposes. 0071050806-1

I, RAJENDER KUMAR S/O LALA RAM SHARMA R/O F-187/30, C.R.SANI PUBLIC SCHOOL, LAXMI PARK, NANGLO DELHI-110041 have changed the name of my minor daughter from PRAGATI SHARMA to PRAGATI for all purposes. 0071050708-1

I, Gita Devi Sepaul, W/o Sunil Kumar R/O-Flat No.KM-406,Amrapali Village, Nyaag-Khand-2,Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201014, inform that GITA DEVI SEPAUL, GITA DEVI SINGH, SRIVASTAVA AND GITA SUNIL SRIVASTAVA are names of one and same person. 0040868915-8

I, DAVINDER KOUR alias DIPTI BHATTIA, D/O S HARDAMAN SINGH W/o Davinder Singh Bhatia, R/O-H-33/35 Sector-3, Rohini Delhi-110085, have changed my name to DIPTI BHATTIA. 0040868971-4

I, MOHAMMAD SABIR, S/O ABDULLAH, R/o 3324, Gali Sawaar Khan, Kucha Pandit, Lal Kuan, Delhi-110066, have changed my name to ABDUL SABIR to MOHAMMAD SABIR, for all future purposes. 0040868906-1

I, Rajiv Singh Yadav, R/o 9/4, Chhurniya mohalla, Tughlakabad village, New Delhi-110044, have changed my name to Rajbeer Singh for all purposes. 0040868915-1

I, DARSHAN AGRAWAL, S/O NAKAN AGRAWAL, R/O-SAKET COLONY Gali No.71, ALIGARH ROAD, HATHRAS UTTAR-PRADESH-204011, have changed my NAME TO PRAVIN KUMAR AGARWAL. 0040868960-7

I, Sachin Kumar, S/O Deveshwar Sugandha, resident-of-1204 12th-Floor, Excitosa-Khand-2, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad-201012, Uttar Pradesh, have changed my name from Sachin Kumar to Sachin Sugandha. Henceforth I would be known by the name of Sachin Sugandha for all future purposes. 0040868905-4

I, Aanchal W/O Shivansh Jain R/O H.No. 69, Sector-15, Sonapat, Haryana-131001 have Changed my Name Aanchal To Aanchal Jain Permanently. 0040868820-1

I, SARAJODDIN S/O KARIMUDDIN R/O 3910 F.G.GALI JAGAT CINEMA JAMA MADHID DELHI G HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO SIRAJUDDIN

0040868960-2

I, Shraddha Khatia Lal alias Shraddha Kumar, W/o Mr. Kaustubh Verma, R/o K-1, Ph-2, Sector-14, Park 1, Gurgaon Road Sec-42 Gurgaon, Po-Galleria DLF-IV, Dist. Gurgaon, Haryana-122009 have changed my name to Shraddha Lal for all future purposes. 0040868983-1

I, LMO KALAM S/O-NAIRUDDIN KHAM, HALKA WASH, CHORHILL, PO: CHORHILL, DIST:KHAGARIA, BIHA R-852161 MY NAME TO MOHD KALAM for all future purposes. 0040868990-2

I, Shradha Khatia Lal alias Shraddha Kumar, W/o Mr. Kaustubh Verma, R/o K-1, Ph-2, Sector-14, Park 1, Gurgaon Road Sec-42 Gurgaon, Po-Galleria DLF-IV, Dist. Gurgaon, Haryana-122009 have changed my name to Shraddha Lal for all future purposes. 0050294042-1

I, Arun Kumar S/o-Raj Kumar R/O-Flat No.29-B, Ravai Apartment, Vikasipur, Delhi-110018, have changed my minor son's name from Rudra Teotia to Rudra Chaudhary and minor daughter's name from Gargi to Gargi Chaudhary, for all future purposes. 0040868915-7

I, BABAR MIAN S/O CHOTE MANSOOR, R/O A-56/2, main road, Shastri park seelampur, Delhi-110053, have changed my name to BABU MANSOOR, FOR ALL PURPOSE. 0040868971-5

I, Sallai Dubey S/O Shes Shankar Dubey R/o N1/65, A-15, GaneshaBagh, Nagwa, Varanasi, Bihar Pradesh-221005, have changed my name to SALLAI KUMAR DUBEY for all future purposes. 0071050719-1

I, SIMMI AGGARWAL W/O RAJ S/O R/O C-7/23, SECTOR-7, ROHINI, Delhi-110085 CHANGED MY NAME TO SIMMI GUPTA PERMANENTLY. 0040868960-8

I, SEEMA RAWAT, W/O Anoop Singh Rawat R/O-D-11, Mayur Vihar, Vardhaman Apartment, Mayur-Vihar, Ph-1, Extension, Delhi-110091, have changed my name to SEEMA REG, for all future purposes. 0040868915-2

I, Suljit S/O Raghuvaran Gopinathan, PRAKRITHI, Gandhi Nagar, Manthuppi PO, Thrissur, Kerala-680651, have changed my name to Suljit Gopinath. 0071050702-1

I, Asha Makkar W/o Pradeep Kumar Makar R/O H.No.70, J.K. Apartment, A-3-Block, Paschim Puri New Delhi-110063, have changed my name to Asha Makkar. 0040868905-3

I, Gurvinder Singh S/o Mr. Sukhvinder Singh R/o 13/348, Tripathi Puri, Delhi-91, do hereby solemnly affirm & declare that my correct DOB is 30-06-84, which should be used for all future purposes. In my personal documents, my DOB 30-06-85 is wrongly printed & betreated as null & void. Both are one & same person only. 0040868801-1

I, Kumar Rajiv Ranjan S/O Bishwanath Singh R/o Tower 3, 4A, Annapurna Apartment, Gita-1, Greater Noida, have lost my original sub lease deed number 17320 dated 12.07.2013 for my flat 104, Tower 3, Annapurna Grand registered under Greater Noida Authority. 0071050718-1

I, ATIF S/O SIRAJUDDIN R/O 3910 F.G.GALI JAGAT CINEMA JAMA MADHID DELHI HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO MOHAMMAD ATIF

I, Rakesh general information that I, Prakash Devi, W/o Ashok Kumar, residing at C-83/7, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad UP-201013, declare that name of my mine has been wrongly written as Parkash Devi in my Bol Data. The actual name of mine is Prakash Devi which may be amended accordingly. 0040868971-6

I, Simran Singh R/O C-32, Hari Nagar, Delhi-110064 have changed my daughter's name from Sakhi Rani Rajpal to SAKHI PREET KAUR. 0040868902-1

I, VINAY KUMAR BANSAL S/O PRITAM LAL BANSAL R/O MD-2, 3rd-FLOOR ROAD NO.25 EAST PUNJABI BAGH PUNJABI BAGH DELHI-110026, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO VINAY BANSAL. 0040868960-6

I, Rajat, M. Sachdeva S/o Manohar Lal Sachdeva R/O C-63 Tagore Garden West Delhi-110027, have changed the name of my minor daughter Anaisha Sachdeva to Anaishaa Sachdeva aged 13 years. 0071050742-1

I, KATYAVANI Wadhawan Popli D/o Atul Wadhawan Ex W/o Prateek Popli R/O Flat No-321, Gurgaon Apartments, Plot No-2, Dwarka Sec-6, Delhi-110075 that I got divorced from my Ex-husband vide Divorce Decree No. HMA No. 2808/2024, dated 02/12/2024, have changed my name to Katyavani Wadhawan. 0071050743-1

I, Unnati Mehndiratta W/o Tarun Mehndiratta R/O-PP-2, Second Floor, Pitampura, Mayura Enclave, New Delhi-110034, have changed my name to Unnati Mehndiratta. 0040868971-1

I, DARSHAN MUKESHBHAI SHAH, S/O Mukeshbhai Shah R/O 44/404, ANHO, Gurjari Vihar, CH-II, Greater Noida, Gautam Budh Nagar, U.P., have changed the name of my minor son DIKSHAN to DIKSHA. DARSHAN SHAH for all future purposes. 0040868904-1

I, Vidya Devi D/O, Jagdish Jha R/O B-132, Sector-36, near Nishi Gunki School, Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh have changed my name to Bibha Devi. 0040868922-1

I, Rajal Kumar S/o Om Prakash R/O H.No.766, Ram Mandir, Sector-5, Gurgaon (Haryana)-122001 have changed my name to Raj Kumar Shah. 0040868960-4

I, Bhupinder Kaur Kharbanda W/o Manjeet Singh R/O H.No.81/82, 1st Floor, Pocket-16, Sector-24, Rohini, Delhi-110085, have changed my name to Bhupinder Kaur for all Purposes. 0040868983-3

I, Ashok Kapoor, S/o Indar Prakash Kaur R/O D-6/2, Rana Pratap Bagh, Delhi-110007 have changed the name of my minor son from Madhav Kapoor to Maadhav Kapoor for all purposes. 0040868903-1

I, NEETU W/o Deepak Chandra born on 20-01-1979, residing at W-311 3rd floor Rishi Nagar, Rani Bagh Delhi-110034 have changed my name to NEETU BHANDUWALA vide affidavit. 0050294042-1

I, Arun Kumar S/o-Raj Kumar R/O-Flat No.29-B, Ravai Apartment, Vikasipur, Delhi-110018, have changed my minor son's name from Rudra Teotia to Rudra Chaudhary and minor daughter's name from Gargi to Gargi Chaudhary, for all future purposes. 0040868915-7

I, Sanjeev Kumar Yadav S/O Ram Prakash Yadav R/O Ward No.15, Khajepith, Thadhi, Lachhminagar, Madhubani, Bihar-847232 have changed my name to Sanjeet Kumar Yadav effective 24/04/2013 for all future purposes. 0040868932-3

I, UNAVESH S/O HARI RAM R/O H.No-246/4 A/BEHIND P.W.D.STORE NEHRU COLONY ROKHTAK H.No.124001, HAVE CHANGED MY NAME TO NAVEEN KUMAR. 0040868960-8

I, Surinder Singh Bhatia, S/O Sh. Trik Singh Bhatia R/O 3/116, Geeta Colony, East Delhi-110031 have lost my ORIGINAL G.A. AND WILL BOTH EXECUTED ON 17.08.2001 BY S. KULWANT SINGH IN FAVOUR OF SURENDER SINGH BHATIA DULY REGD. AS DOCUMENT NOS. (1) 32588 & (2) 14721 RESPECTIVELY, REGISTERED ON 17.08.2001 IN THE OFFICE OF SUB REGISTRAR U DELHI BOTH W.R.T. PROPERTY No. 3/116, GEETA COLONY, DELHI-110031. Finders may contact at above address. 0040868902-3

The allotment related documents viz. Allotment letter, Possession letter, Demand Letter, NDC Letter, Conveyance Deed in respect of U.G. DDA Flat No.931, Pocket-D, Loknayakpura, New Delhi-110041 have been lost. If any body found Please contact Smt. Soni Kumari, Mob.-711189572. 0040868901-1

I, Kumar Rajiv Ranjan S/O Bishwanath Singh R/o Tower 3, 4A, Annapurna Apartment, Gita-1, Greater Noida have lost my original sub lease deed number 17320 dated 12.07.2013 for my flat 104, Tower 3, Annapurna Grand registered under Greater Noida Authority. 0071050718-1

I, KUMAR RAJIV RANJAN S/O BISHWANATH SINGH R/O TOWER 3, 4A, ANNAPURNA APARTMENT, GITA-1, GREATER NOIDA have lost my original sub lease deed number 17320 dated 12.07.2013 for my flat 104, Tower 3, Annapurna Grand registered under Greater Noida Authority. 0071050718-1

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PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Kalicharan @ Kali, S/o: Rajkumar, R/o: H.No. D-454, 4th Floor, Mangolpuri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case E-FIR No. 44940/2018, U/s 379/411/482 IPC, P.S.: Hari Nagar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Kalicharan @ Kali** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Kalicharan @ Kali** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Kalicharan @ Kali** accused of offence in case E-FIR No. 44940/2018, U/s 379/411/482 IPC, P.S.: Hari Nagar, Delhi and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 03.09.2026.

By Order

Ms. Moksha Bains

DP/10354/DW/2026 Judicial Magistrate First Class-11 (West) (Court Matter) Court No. 31, Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Rahul @ Pintu S/o Munnaral R/o 3rd Pusta, Gali No. 5, Usmanpur, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide E-FIR No. 1306/2020 U/s 379/411 IPC, PS Kashmir Gate, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Rahul @ Pintu** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Rahul @ Pintu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Rahul @ Pintu** of E-FIR No. 1306/2020 U/s 379/411 IPC, PS Kashmir Gate, Delhi is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of 05.10.2026.

By Order,

Sh. Vaidharg Garg

DP/9892/2026(Court Matter) Judicial Magistrate First Class-11 Central District, Court No. 138, 1st Floor Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS / 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Kanhaiya Tanti, S/o Sahdev Tanti, R/o RZ-462/13B, Tuglakabad Extension, Govindpur, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case E-FIR No. 77/2023, U/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. Okhla Industrial Area, New Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Kanhaiya Tanti** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Kanhaiya Tanti** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Kanhaiya Tanti** accused of e-FIR No. 77/2023, U/s 379/411 IPC, P.S. Okhla Industrial Area, New Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 31.08.2026.

By Order - Ms. Akansha Gautam

Judicial Magistrate First Class-02

DP/10486/SE/2026 South-East District, Room No. 513 Saket Courts, New Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Navjot Singh @ Rocky S/o Jasbir Singh R/o A-52, Gali No. 33, Sunday Bazar Road, Chandni Vihar, Nitihi Extn, Nihal Vihar, Outer Distt., Delhi** also at A-72, Ind Floor, Gurgaon Enclave, Chandni Vihar, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence FIR No. 809/2020 U/s 308/34 IPC at P.S. Nihal Vihar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Navjot Singh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Navjot Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proceeding U/s 82 Cr.P.C. has been initiated in the case. Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Navjot Singh** @ Rocky accused of FIR No. 809/2020 U/s 308/34 IPC at P.S. Nihal Vihar, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 01.09.2026.

By Order, Ms. Priya Mahendra,

Additional Sessions Judge-09, (West),

DP/10491/OD/2026 Court No. 307, 3rd Floor, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi,

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Irfan S/o Abdul Gaffar, R/o D-1215, Ji Colony, Bawana, Delhi** (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 114921/ U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, registered at P.S.: Bawana, Delhi and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused **Irfan** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Irfan** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Irfan** accused of FIR No. 114921/ U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, registered at P.S.: Bawana, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 21.09.2026.

By Order

Ms. Bharti Bhatnagar

DP/10329/ON/2026 Judicial Magistrate First Class-06 (N) Room No. 114, North District, Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Parveen @ Kanihya, S/o Avadh Mishra, R/O B-92, Raghuber Enclave, Nangloi Star, Najafgarh, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 285/18, U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, P.S. Dwarka North, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Parveen @ Kanihya** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Parveen @ Kanihya** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Parveen @ Kanihya** accused of FIR No. 285/18, U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, P.S. Dwarka North, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 29.09.2026.

Mr YouTube to Kenyan icon: Yego's Commonwealth farewell

Rio Olympics medalist opens up on his journey, friendship with Neeraj and the rise of javelin throw

Nihal Koshie
New Delhi, July 29

JULIUS YEGO is an Olympic silver medalist and a former World Champion. However, the most memorable reception he received on returning home to Kenya was after winning gold at the 2014 Commonwealth Games in Glasgow.

The victory in Scotland's largest city was special because it put Kenya on the javelin map of the world. The country erupted in joy; Yego got unforgettable memories—including a helicopter ride to his village in the Rift Valley. "After the Commonwealth Games, I had a huge reception back home. Even my school, Kapsabet High School, had a big reception. A helicopter took me to my village (Cheptonon). There was a huge crowd in my village. They wanted to see me and also see a helicopter landing in the village. I was young back then; people didn't expect me to win the Commonwealth Games gold in javelin. It was a big story," Yego told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow.

There was no electricity in his village and no tarred roads, but Cheptonon had a champion athlete. "Even now, in some areas of my village there is no electricity. But we do not have a water problem because there are streams. Rich people have tap water, but others drink stream water because they believe it is clean," the 37-year-old said. The roads are still basic. "There are small roads but no tarmac roads. I moved to Eldoret for my training, but I still go back to my village," Yego said.

Yego's stardom continued to grow in Kenya, the East Afri-



2021 champion Julius Yego will be one of the favourites as javelin gets underway on Thursday. REUTERS

can nation known for its distance runners, when he won a World Championship gold in Beijing a year later. He was the first from Kenya to become a world champion in a field event. A hip-hop musician, Khaligraph Jones, made a song titled 'Yego' to celebrate his achievements. Like Yego, the song is still popular.

"I am a big football fan, and I support Arsenal. Sometimes, when I go to social places, people see me, and they play the song and have fun. I like it because it reminds me of what I have achieved," he said.

Even before social media became a thing, a young Yego, without a coach, was on YouTube learning how to throw the javelin. When he travelled outside Kenya for the first time—for the 2010 Commonwealth Games in Delhi—he didn't have a coach, but he had YouTube to fall back on. Once he became famous, the monkier

“Neeraj is a good friend. I have a good relationship with him. We try to make our sport friendly. If you don't win, then your friend will win, then you clap for him. And when I win, they clap for me.”

JULIUS YEGO
ON HIS RELATIONSHIP WITH NEERAJ

Mr. YouTube stayed.

"It (YouTube) is used more now. Maybe, in the beginning it was to know what you have to do, but now you can watch and correct yourself as well. I get lots of questions from India. I do respond and give comments when I have time on

Instagram."

The father of three, two sons and a daughter who just turned one, Yego wants to keep going till the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. As much as aiming for another podium finish, he also wants to do his bit towards more athletes taking up sports.

"I think, at the moment, I'm looking to motivate more athletes in Kenya to pick up sports, not just javelin. I can see this happening in my time, when I am still active. This will also motivate me to make it to L.A." Yego has been around long enough to see the change in the sport, from European dominance on the podium to medals being spread out across the globe. "That's what I like about this sport. It is no longer set in one place. When I was starting the sport, it was being won by athletes from Europe. At the moment, every part of the world is being represented in javelin. Athletes come say-

ing, 'we can do it'. Keshorn Walcott (Trinidad and Tobago) won in 2012 (Olympics), but nobody expected it. I won in 2015 (World Championships). Anderson Peters from Grenada won. Neeraj (Chopra) has won. It shows the sport has changed and it has gone global. We changed the thinking of the sport, yes, everybody can win."

The competition at the Commonwealth Games will be tough with Chopra, Olympic Champion Arshad Nadeem from Pakistan, Sri Lanka's Ramesh Tharanga Pathiraja and Yego in the fray, but the Kenyan says the camaraderie in javelin is strong.

"Yes, Neeraj is a good friend. I have a good relationship with him. We try to make our sport friendly. If you don't win, then your friend will win, then you clap for him. And when I win, they clap for me. When your friend is down, you cheer him up. Put a smile on your face. We talk normally when we are in the competition, maybe correct each other, like say 'maybe do this'. You compete of course, but after the competition the friendship remains."

Yego hopes to leave Glasgow, his Commonwealth swansong, with a medal. "I won't be competing in India (in 2030). If I win this championship, I will be so happy. I will say bye-bye Commonwealth Games and I will see you next time in some other capacity. It has been fun and amazing to compete at the Commonwealth Games."

Working as an inspector of police in the Directorate of Criminal Investigation, Yego is also an anti-doping crusader. Like India, Kenya too has a doping problem, and Yego wants to help to clean up the mess. "I posted a video a few days ago saying it is a historic moment (fifth CWG) for me to be at the Games and in Glasgow again. My message was to compete clean, respect your opponent, and it is ok to lose if you compete fairly."

The elder statesman of javelin wants to make a mark on the field in Glasgow and make a difference off the field.

Back at CWG, Neeraj faces world-class field in chase for gold



2018 Gold Coast CWG was Neeraj Chopra's first-ever major medal. PH

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

NEERAJ CHOPRA is back at the Commonwealth Games (CWG) after missing the previous edition in Birmingham due to a groin injury. There is a special connect between Chopra and the CWG because he won his first major senior international medal, a gold, at the 2018 Commonwealth Games in Gold Coast.

Back then, the venue for track and field was the 40,000-seater Carrara Stadium. For the ongoing truncated edition, it's the 11,000-seater Scotstoun Stadium. But the significance of Glasgow will remain, given that Chopra is aiming to win his first medal since winning his own event—the Neeraj Chopra Classic—a year ago.

Return from layoff

"The 2018 Commonwealth Games was my first senior competition, and it was a good start because I had won gold. I have focused on technique, and I want to execute that well. I don't have any target, but I want to give my 100 percent," NEERAJ CHOPRA, ON HIS GRADUAL COMEBACK

medal prospect. Ahead of the Games, he's been posting training videos on Instagram with captions like 'locked in', 'pushing with everyday', 'getting stronger slowly and steadily'. But how well prepared he is to push himself to the limit if competitors produce big throws will be the key for a podium finish.

Pathirage threat

As always, there is the subplot of an India vs Pakistan rivalry with Nadeem, but Sri Lanka's Pathirage could be the one to watch out for from the sub-continent. The former fast bowler is the only thrower to go over 90 metres this season with 92.6m at the Diamond League in Rome last month. Pathirage also finished first at the Doha Diamond League with a throw of 88.6m. Nadeem had a low-key start in Luzern, Switzerland, managing to throw just 78.47. For Chopra, his only event this year till now, the Doha Diamond League, was about testing how ready he was for competition.

"My body is better but not yet back to the old Neeraj. There was no pressure (in Doha), so I didn't put extra effort because I just wanted to participate. I wanted one good throw, I got a good throw of 85.69 metres. I felt it was good because I was not throwing this distance in training. As I have come back from injury... earlier I wouldn't have accepted a fourth-place position or the 85-metre throw. But I know from what situation I have made a comeback. Step-by-step I have to progress. And for the kind of preparation I had, the throw was good," Chopra had said after Doha.

He may need a bigger throw to finish on the podium on Friday.

Harjinder 'lands' second successive weightlifting medal

Nitin Sharma
Chandigarh, July 29

SOME MORE farmland.

That was the thought that came to Harjinder Kaur's mind immediately after she won the Commonwealth Games silver medal in the women's 69kg weightlifting event.

The medal was an improvement on the one the girl from Punjab had clinched in the 71kg category at the previous edition in Birmingham. Since then, her marginal farming family had moved to a new house and bought some farmland in their village, and Harjinder's father Sahib Singh may interpret her latest achievement in terms of what it could provide the family materially. "We had marginal farmland and the income was

augmented by selling milk from the six buffaloes we owned. The bronze medal won in Birmingham landed me a job as an income tax inspector, apart from cash awards. I wanted to upgrade my medal here and now I will get some more farmland for my father," Harjinder told *The Indian Express*.

Harjinder lifted a total of 227 kg—101kg in snatch and 126kg in clean and jerk—to finish behind Canadian Charlotte Simionescu (240kg—108kg and 132kg). With the family owning six buffaloes, Harjinder got milk and home-made paneer. She would often help her father operate the chaff-cutting machine, and the strong physique came handy when Harjinder started playing kabaddi at Government Girls School at



Harjinder Kaur. PH

Nabha, where she would commute daily by bicycle. She was then selected to play for Punjab University, Patiala where 1990 Commonwealth Games weightlifting champion Parmjit Sharma took her under his wings. "I was healthy and I knew I could groom her into a good weight-

lifter. I put her initially in tug of war teams before starting weightlifting. Her mother sold her jewellery and the family took loans to support her training, which made Harjinder determined to excel in her sport," he told *The Indian Express*.

It was in 2019 that brother Prithpal Singh got a contractual job in the PWD department and with Harjinder too getting a scholarship from Punjab University, the family's financial situation improved and she could focus solely on weightlifting.

Battling injuries

Last year, Harjinder suffered a wrist injury while a back problem that she suffered in 2019 also aggravated. She moved to the 69kg class and won the

bronze at the Commonwealth Championship in Ahmedabad with a mark of 222kg. Despite winning her second successive CWG medal on Tuesday, Harjinder knows she has work to do in the coming years.

"I have had some issues in my clean and jerk technique, and have been working on them for a few years. (National coach) Vijay Sharma sir has been working on getting some technical flaws rectified and the aim is to improve further," she said.

Meanwhile, mother Kuldeep knows what Harjinder would demand when she gets home from Glasgow. "She always asks me to cook vegetables like pumpkin, which she doesn't get to eat at hostels or abroad."

Animesh wins heat, reaches 200m semis

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

NATIONAL RECORD holder in the 200m, Animesh Kujur clocked 20.46s in the heats to book his berth in the semifinals of the event at the 2026 Commonwealth Games.

Running in the fourth heat, Animesh was up against 100m champion Emmanuel Eseme of Cameroon and South African Myvuo Moss, but came out flying with his season's best and topped the heat.

Overall, Animesh finished seventh in the heats as 16 sprinters progressed to the semifinals with eight other getting byes.

His coach Martin Owens had thought Animesh would have to go quicker to advance. "It was a quality display from Animesh today. A fine performance by him as I thought it would take a quicker time to qualify for the semis. He is in very good shape and



Animesh Kujur clocked 20.46s to book his berth in the semifinals of the 200m sprint. INSTAGRAM

we are looking forward to the semis. It will be very tough as it is a very high quality field," the Briton said in a press note.

Owens believed that defeating Eseme, who won the 100m gold medal the previous day, would give the Indian

“Animesh will get a lot of confidence by beating the 100m champion from this edition today. It is another feather in his cap and I am pleased with his display.”

MARTIN OWENS
ANIMESH KIJUR'S COACH

confidence. "Animesh will get a lot of confidence by beating the 100m champion from this edition today. It is another feather in his cap and I am pleased with his display. It is good to check the first box but we're now looking forward to the next stage," he said.

Animesh will face Olympian Israel Ikin of Nigeria and Jevaughn Powell of Jamaica

in his semifinal. He is placed in the first lane in the semifinal as against his preferred outer lanes.

"We like the outer lanes, really. The curves are a little bit kinder. If you are on the inner lanes, you can watch what everybody else is doing and can follow what's going on. So that's an advantage there. But people tend to run a little wider subconsciously on the inner lane. Some people like just the easier curve. Animesh prefers lane 6 or 7," Owens had told *The Indian Express* earlier.

Toor, Gill qualify

Veteran Indian shot putter Tajinderpal Singh Toor and youngster Samardeep Singh Gill booked their berths in the men's shot put final.

While Toor achieved the direct qualification mark of 20m by throwing 20.14m, Samardeep recorded a best throw of 19.95m.

Express News Service
New Delhi, July 29

INDIAN BOXERS went six for six at the Commonwealth Games on Wednesday, with each win ensuring a medal for the country in Glasgow. Sakshi Choudhary, Arundhati Choudhary, Sachin Siwach, Ankush Yadav, Narendra Bernal and Jaishime Lamboyia all booked their spots in the semifinals of their respective categories. Ten Indian boxers are now in the semifinals, a result that has gone along expected lines at a tournament devoid of tough Asian competition.

Sakshi defeated Northern Ireland's Caitlin Fryers in the women's 90-kg quarterfinal. The perfect performance followed a Tuesday when Jadu mani Singh, Preeti Pawa and Priya Ghanghas also assured themselves of medals after winning their quarterfinal bouts. Lovlina Borgohain had defended one for herself without losing a punch.



Sakshi Choudhary defeated Northern Ireland's Caitlin Fryers. PH

Ankush was a class above his opponent and repeatedly beat Micock with his superior speed, movement and intensity. The Indian won 30-26 on one judge's card and 30-27 on the remaining four. Earlier in the day, making full use of her height and reach advantage, Sakshi, who has moved down from the 54kg weight class, dictated the contest from the opening bell, keeping

Fryers at bay with accurate jabs and straight punches.

The Irish boxer tried to unsettle Sakshi with constant aggression, throwing punches in volume, but the Indian remained composed, evading most of the attacks before responding with cleaner, more effective combinations.

The bout featured frequent clinches as both boxers got tangled at close quarters, even tumbling to the canvas. Step-by-step I have to progress. And for the kind of preparation I had, the throw was good," Chopra had said after Doha.

He may need a bigger throw to finish on the podium on Friday.

(With agency inputs)

'Clicky Ponting' at centre of England club cheating row

New Delhi